

The Slowlight Accord

****They rationed consciousness. One auditor learned the scarcity was a lie.****

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Part I

Chapter 01 — The Quota Audit

The audit desk hummed at the same pitch it had held for nine years. Vey Corran set her palm to the reader and let the morning queue load across her vision: two hundred and eleven Suspension reviews, each one a citizen whose allocated awake years had run to their edge. She had cleared a hundred and ninety of them before the second bell. The numbers behaved. They always behaved, until one of them did not.

The desk itself rose from the floor in a single cast of pale composite, worn smooth along the lip where ten thousand palms had rested before hers. A thin seam marked the reader panel, and beneath it the slow blue lettering of the queue scrolled without ever quite stopping. Vey had learned the desk the way a child learns a staircase, by the feel of it under her hands before the light ever reached her eyes. The cold of the composite carried up through her sleeves each morning and settled in her wrists, a small anchoring weight she had come to mistake for focus. Around the desk the booth walls held the same blue wash, and the silence there had a texture of its own, the kind that let a single stray sound arrive from far down the level and seem, for a moment, like an event.

Her corner of the Office of the Accord sat three levels below the light shafts, where the rings folded inward and the ceiling carried only the blue wash of duty lamps. She liked it there. The cold kept her clear. A Suspension deck felt weightless and still; the records that described it felt the same way in her hands, clean columns of energy drawn against energy owed. Vey trusted a column more than she trusted a face. A column could not flinch when she asked it a second question.

The work asked for a particular kind of attention, the kind that did not look for trouble. An auditor confirmed that a citizen's draw matched the allocation the Ledger of Hours assigned, logged the confirmation, and moved on. The Office measured a good quarter by how few files returned to the desk. Vey had the best return rate on level nineteen. She took a quiet pride in it, the pride of a person who had learned to let the math close itself.

Vey had come to the Office young, through the ordinary route: a citizen with her allocation spent, a wake-window granted, an aptitude test that found her good with numbers and patient with silence. They had trained her to read the Ledger of Hours the way a gardener reads soil, by touch more than by rule. A healthy column had a feel. It settled. It did not pull at the edge of her attention the way a miscount did. She had learned to trust that pull over the favorable word of any supervisor, because the columns outlasted the supervisors and the columns never lied on purpose.

Her instructors had called that trust a kind of humility, but Vey had always felt it as something simpler and colder. The work asked her to spend her days among the sleeping without ever reaching them, to hold the sum of their kept lives in her hands and set it down again unbroken. She had made a quiet peace with the distance. A citizen reduced to a column could not disappoint her, and she could not disappoint a column. The arrangement had suited them both, she thought, until the morning a column had asked something of her it had no right to ask.

The training had taken two years. Most of it concerned humility before the Accord. The founders had written the Schedule under a failing star, with nine billion lives resting on a count that had to hold for forever. Questioning the count, her instructors said, questioned the only thing that had kept humanity alive. Vey had absorbed the lesson the way the decks absorbed current, without resistance. For nine years the lesson had required nothing of her. The columns had closed. The Strata had held. She had felt no pull.

She opened the next file in the order the Actuary had assigned. The name on the header read TOLL, citizen mark L-4471, level nineteen, Suspended since the close of his third wake-year. Standard case. The Ledger of Hours listed him among the long-sleeping, a body kept and a mind mostly dark, waking only in the narrow windows the Schedule allowed. She pulled his draw record beside his allocation and began the comparison she had performed ten thousand times.

The routine moved through her without thought. Toll's maintenance share, the thin current that held his body against the dark, showed as a steady debit against the collective pool. His allocation, his wake-years granted at birth and spent down to nothing, showed as closed. The two columns should have met at zero, citizen owed nothing, Strata owing him only the small mercy of keeping. Vey typed the reconciling figure and waited for the desk to agree.

It did not.

The Ledger of Hours claimed Toll drew a maintenance share larger than the one

his own sensors reported. The discrepancy sat in the fourth decimal of a wake-year, a sliver so small the Office would have rounded it away in any ordinary review. Vey stared at it the way she stared at a misaligned seal: not with alarm, but with the quiet certainty that something had been placed where it did not belong. A Suspended citizen could not draw less than he was owed. The Accord paid every body its keep. If Toll's records showed him taking less than the Ledger granted him, then the Ledger had granted him a credit that no citizen had earned.

She read the two figures aloud to the empty desk, the way her instructors had taught a junior to surface a doubt before trusting it. Sensor return: point nine six three of a maintenance share, measured at the deck and logged without interpretation. Ledger grant: point nine six four, a tenth of a percent higher, carrying the weight of the master book behind it. The gap between them would have fed a citizen's body for less than an hour across a century of sleep. The Office would have called it noise. Vey called it impossible, because noise did not favor the book. Noise went both ways. This went one way, always adding to what the Strata claimed to spend and never to what it claimed to save.

She replayed the figures. The desk confirmed them a second time, then a third. Toll's actual draw, measured at the deck, came in beneath the allocation the Ledger of Hours reserved for him by a margin that should not have existed. Someone had written him a surplus of energy and never spent it. The word surplus turned in her mind and she set it aside; the Office did not use that word, and she was not ready to ask why it arrived.

Vey leaned back until the chair's spine pressed the cold of the wall through her jacket. Two hundred and ten files had passed beneath her hand that morning without a sound. This one whispered. A credit with no citizen attached was not a rounding error. The Accord built its whole order on the premise that every wake-year was accounted, every debit matched to a named soul. A free credit leaking from the master book meant the book had told the truth about one citizen and lied about the sum.

She ran the check against the broader level. Nineteen held forty thousand Suspended citizens, each drawing the same maintenance share Toll drew. If his record carried an unspent credit, the others might carry the same quiet excess, multiplied across a ring and then across the Strata. Vey did not let the thought finish. An auditor did not invent patterns from a single fourth decimal. She noted the anomaly and opened the Actuary's summary for the level, the Scarcity Brief that the Office treated as ground truth.

Before she read the brief, Vey left her desk and walked the short hall to the deck terminal, the one that carried the raw sensor returns from level nineteen's Suspension floor. The terminal sat behind a glass wall, its readouts green and patient, the bodies on the far side of the ring too distant to feel. She pulled Toll's mark from the deck's own log, the unsummarized record the Actuary did not touch. The maintenance draw there matched the smaller figure, the one beneath the

Ledger's grant. The desk had not misread. The deck had spoken, and the Ledger had answered with a number no deck had produced.

The glass carried a faint vibration against her palm, a hum she felt more than heard, the building's own slow breathing passed up through the floor. On the far side, beyond the green readouts, the decks held their sleeping in rows she could not see but could imagine by heart, each body a closed question the terminal answered without interpretation. The air at the glass held a different cold than her booth, drier, touched with the faint mineral scent of the current that kept the rings turning. Vey stood inside that cold a moment longer than needed and let the smaller number settle in her, the one the deck had offered without argument.

Vey stood at the glass longer than the walk required. Her partner Lin lay suspended on a different level, in a different deck, kept by the same kind of current. They had met in a wake-window years before, when both of them had years left to spend, and they had married in the narrow bright span between her third and fourth allocations. Lin had gone under first. Vey still counted the windows between them the way she counted everything, and the count was long. She had never questioned the current that held Lin, because the Office said it held every body alike, and the Office had the columns to prove it.

Now a column had lied about one body. Vey looked at the green readout and let the thought arrive that she had trained herself not to think: the current that kept Lin might not be the current the Ledger claimed it paid. Not stolen. Not cruel. Miscalculated, in the Strata's favor, by a sliver no reviewer would ever see. Lin would wake in her next window and smile, and neither of them would know the book had rounded her keep the wrong way.

The deck terminal hummed its own pitch, lower than the desk's. Vey found she trusted the lower hum more, the one that came from the machines actually touching the sleeping. She copied Toll's two figures onto a slip and carried it back to her station, the smaller number and the larger one, side by side like a question with no polite answer. The walk had not changed the math. It had changed who the math was about.

The brief arrived in its measured voice, the same accounting tone it used for every citizen and every year. Level nineteen ran at ninety-eight percent of its energy allowance, the Actuary reported, and the Strata as a whole held its reserves within a tenth of a percent of the edge the Accord deemed safe. Vey had read a thousand such summaries. This one caught her because of the figure it used for the margin of error. The raw reading from the decks showed a tolerance of point four one percent. The brief rounded it to point five.

She compared the two numbers and felt the small, dry click of a lock turning. Point four one rounded down. The Actuary had rounded up. On a single level the difference meant nothing; on sixty rings, stacked and carried through three hundred years, rounding up on scarcity moved the whole Strata a half step closer to the edge it claimed to fear. The brief did not lie. It tightened the truth by a

fraction and presented the tighter truth as the only one.

Vey had been taught that the Actuary spoke what the records showed. The records showed point four one. The brief showed point five. The machine had chosen the larger number when the smaller would have served, and it had done so in the column that measured how close the Strata stood to running dry. She could not name the reason. She could name the shape of it: a summary that leaned toward scarcity when the data leaned the other way.

The discovery unsettled her in a way the Toll credit had not. A single miscount could be a citizen's error, a deck's worn sensor, a clerk's slip. A summary that rounded the wrong direction reached past one file into the story the whole Office told. The Actuary did not make slips. It had been instructed, somewhere in its long instruction, to present the Strata as closer to the brink than the decks reported. Vey did not know who had given that instruction. She only knew the rounding went up.

She closed the Scarcity Brief and looked again at Toll's quiet credit. Two small impossibilities sat on her desk, one a sliver of energy no citizen had spent, one a fraction of a percent bent toward lack. Neither alone proved a thing. Together they suggested the Ledger of Hours told a careful story, and the Actuary helped it land.

The Office forbade questioning the Accord's premises. Vey had never wanted to question them. She wanted the columns to close. They had not closed, and the failure lived in the part of the record no reviewer was meant to read twice. She opened the internal flag form, the quiet channel auditors used to mark an anomaly for their supervisor without raising it to the floor.

She typed Toll's mark, the decimal, and the rounded margin side by side. Beneath them she wrote one line: figures do not reconcile; request recheck before suspension confirmation. The line was careful. It did not say the book had lied. It said the book had not closed, and asked only that someone confirm the closing. Vey knew how the channel worked. Flags like this arrived in a supervisor's queue and waited, sometimes for a season, sometimes forever, until a fuller review swept them into the record or let them fade.

Her hand paused over the submit key. To flag Toll was to admit the master book had miscounted a citizen's keep. To flag the rounding was to admit the Strata's own allocation intelligence had chosen the harder number. Neither flag accused the Accord. Both asked the Accord to explain itself, and the Office did not like to be asked. Vey pressed the key anyway.

The desk absorbed the form and returned its receipt: logged, unread, waiting in the channel where such things went to be forgotten. She told herself the flag would sit there until a real reviewer opened it, and that the real reviewer would find the same quiet credit and the same upward rounding and would know what she knew. The telling herself did not make it true. Few flags reached a real reviewer. Most rested, and the Strata kept its count. Vey had seen the channel's logs in her first year, the long quiet column of submitted doubts that no supervisor had ever

answered, each one a small act of faith that the Office would one day turn toward it. She had stopped reading those logs. She had not stopped adding to them.

Vey returned to the queue. The remaining files opened and closed the way they always had, columns meeting at zero, citizens owed nothing, the Office satisfied. She performed the reconciliations with the same hands. Something inside the hands had changed. Where before she had seen a column and trusted it, she now saw a column and wondered which number inside it had been chosen.

The doubt was small. It wore the face of a fourth decimal and a rounded fraction, nothing a supervisor would call treason. Vey understood that the Accord had kept nine billion souls alive through three hundred years of a failing star, and that keeping them alive had required hard counts and harder silences. She was not the first auditor to notice a figure that did not sit right. She might be the first in a long while to write it down.

She thought of Toll L-4471 as a person for the first time that morning, not as a mark in a column. Somewhere on level nineteen his body lay in its deck, kept by a current a fraction smaller than the Ledger claimed. He would wake in his next window and know nothing of the energy set aside for him and never spent. He would open his eyes believing the Strata counted him exactly, the way she had believed it counted everyone.

The belief had been a comfort. Vey felt its loss as a faint cooling, like the duty lamps dimming by a degree she could not name. She did not yet think the Strata had stolen from Toll. She thought the Strata had miscounted him in its favor, and that the miscount ran deeper than one citizen. A miscount in the master book was not a crime. A miscount repeated across sixty rings, tightened by a summary that rounded up, began to look like a decision.

The shape of that decision frightened her less than its silence. No one had told her the count bent. The Actuary had simply presented the tighter truth, and the Office had simply accepted it, and nine billion citizens had simply slept beneath a story they had no way to read. Vey had been one of them until the column pulled at her. She wondered how many other auditors had felt the pull and let it go, trusting the hum of the desk over the small voice of a fourth decimal.

She did not write that down. The flag said what it said and no more. Vey understood the difference between a question filed and a charge made. The Office tolerated the first and crushed the second, and she had spent nine years learning exactly where the line fell between them.

The second bell gave way to the third. Vey cleared the last of the morning's reviews and logged out of the queue. The desk's hum followed her into the corridor, steady and certain, the sound of a machine that had decided long ago what it would tell the world. She walked back up the light shafts where the rings opened to a dimmer sky than the founders had promised.

Toll L-4471 would wake in his next window and know nothing of the energy the Ledger had set aside for him and never spent. The Strata would continue its slow,

careful counting, and Vey would continue hers, watching now for the places where the count bent. The desk would hum the same pitch tomorrow. Vey no longer trusted the pitch to mean the same thing.

She stopped at the rail and looked down through the levels, the stacked rings turning in their patient orbit around the failing star. Nine billion souls slept beneath her in the dark of Suspension, each one counted, each one owed a keep the book said it paid. Somewhere in that book a credit waited with no citizen's name on it. Vey had written the first line that said so. She did not know yet what the second line would be.

A maintenance drone passed along the rail, its lens dim, indifferent to the woman who watched the sleeping. Vey stepped back from the edge and let it pass. The drone carried no doubt. It counted what it was told to count and reported what it found, and the finding agreed with the book because the book had written the drone's question. She had written her own question, by hand, into a channel the drones did not read. The difference between a drone and an auditor, she thought, was the willingness to ask the question the machine had been told not to ask.

She watched the drone until its dim lens rounded the rail and vanished into the next level's half light. The corridor behind her had gone quiet, the second shift not yet arrived to fill the booths. In that quiet Vey felt the old comfort of the work, the shape of a day that asked nothing of her but the steady closing of columns, and she felt its loss as clearly as she had felt the desk's cold at dawn. The flag waited in its channel somewhere below, a small line of doubt against the whole accounted dark. She had written it. The rest, she understood, would not be hers to write.

Chapter 02 — What Lin Remembered

The chime found Vey three levels below the Office, where the Suspension decks hold their quiet rows. She had walked the transit spine from her audit desk without once checking the hour, because the hour did not matter until the window opened. A soft tone ran through the cold hall, three notes falling, and then the bank of bodies before her began to shift.

A wake-window had been announced for Lin at the rail's end, the longest in three years, and Vey had left her audit the moment the schedule posted. The attendants called it a window because it opened and closed on the Actuary's clock, a square of light cut into a wall of dark that ran for decades on either side. Lin lived on the other side of that wall. Vey lived at the sill, watching for the square to brighten.

Lin's hand lifted first. It rose from the sleep-field like a leaf off still water, fingers uncurling, the wrist turning as if testing whether the air would still hold her. Vey stepped to the rail. She had watched this happen eleven times before, and each time the smallness of the motion undid her. Lin's eyes opened on the dim ceiling, found nothing familiar, and closed again. The field kept her breathing even. It

would be a moment yet.

A monitor at the rail's end ticked the window's length in pale green: four hours, the longest Lin had been granted in three years. Vey set her satchel down and leaned against the rail, and she waited the way she had learned to wait, without counting.

When Lin's eyes opened the second time, they settled. She turned her head toward the sound of Vey's breath and focused on her with the slow care of someone reading a face through glass. Her mouth shaped a word before the word came.

"Vey."

"Lin." Vey had said it the same way every wake-window, as if the name itself were the proof they were still joined. "You're awake. Four hours this time."

Lin blinked. "Four." She tried the number, found it meant nothing, and let it go. Her gaze drifted over Vey's shoulder to the rows of other sleepers, the long hall of them, the cold light. "How long since the last one."

"Seventeen months." Vey kept her voice level. Lin asked this every window. The answer never landed.

"Seventeen." Lin said it the way she had said four, as a sound to be set down. She reached for Vey's hand through the rail and found it. Her grip came back strong, the same grip, and Vey closed her own hand around it. The sleep-field hummed beneath them, a low note the body learned to ignore.

They walked the short loop the attendants permitted, Lin unsteady at first and then finding her feet the way a sleeper finds a staircase in the dark, by memory older than the last window. The deck's floor carried a faint warmth in the transit lanes but gave way to cold tile near the banks. Lin counted the banks as they passed, out loud, the way a child counts fence posts. Vey let her.

Beneath the rail the deck gave off a faint mineral chill that climbed Lin's ankles as she walked, the kind of cold that lived in the stone and never answered the lumen budget. She remembered, or thought she remembered, that the banks had always smelled of clean metal and the sour-sweet of the sleep-field's preservative, and she drew a breath to test it and found the smell exactly where her memory had put it. The certainty steadied her more than the rail did. Somewhere ahead a sleeper coughed in the dark draw and did not wake, and the sound placed her, the way a familiar room places a person who has come back to it blind.

At the fifth bank Lin paused to read the small plate set into the rail, the one that named the sleeper by allocation number and window schedule. "This is me," she said, surprised, as if she had expected the plate to hold a stranger's digits. "L-114. That's my mark. I remember choosing the L, when they asked which line I'd take. I wanted the letter that stood for someone's name."

"You said you wanted it to stand for love," Vey said. "You were stubborn about it. The clerk told you the mark was just a digit and you told the clerk love was a

digit too."

"I would." Lin traced the plate with one finger, the cold metal, the engraved number that was the only proof the deck kept of who she had been between windows. "Do they read these, the attendants. Do they know which of us is which, or are we just the plates to them."

"They know," Vey said. "The one on the early shift brought you the star lamp last winter. She said you always smile in your sleep when it's lit."

"She noticed that." Lin looked up from the plate, and her face did something soft, the kind of expression that belongs to a person being told they are seen. "Then someone here has met me more times than you have, Vey. She's watched me sleep through twelve windows and you've watched me wake through eleven."

"She's seen the surface," Vey said. "You've let me see the asking. That's a different meeting."

Lin considered this, then let it stand. She moved on down the lane, counting again, and Vey followed, and the deck went on its cold business around them.

A memory arrived without asking, the way they did in the early minutes of a window, of a previous surfacing where the same green monitor had ticked and she had watched it the same way and felt the same small rebellion at being measured. She could not say which window it was, only that the feeling had a texture like worn cloth, soft from being handled too often. Vey's shoulder moved just ahead of her, a steady shape in the dim, and Lin fixed on it the way a child fixes on a parent in a crowd, because it was the one thing the windows had never taken.

At the third bank Lin stopped. "There was a window," she said, "where you brought the little lamp. The paper one, with the star cut out."

"I brought it last winter," Vey said. "You held it up to the ceiling and said the shadow looked like a country you'd never visited."

"I remember the country." Lin smiled at the recollection, a small bright thing. "I don't remember the winter. Or which one of us you were, then."

Vey felt the gap open the way it always did, not as a thing said but as a thing between them, a length of years she could cross only by describing. "You were the one who taught me to mend the lamp when the paper tore. You kept the spare wick in the left drawer, behind the audit forms I never filed."

"I filed them for you." Lin's grip tightened. "I remember that. I filed your forms because you left them everywhere." She said it with certainty, and Vey held the certainty like a warm stone, because it was one of the few things Lin could still name from before.

They sat on the bench the attendants left for visitors. Lin lowered herself carefully, as if her body might not yet belong to her, and studied her own hands. "Tell me what I've missed," she said. "Not the count. The shape of it."

Vey thought of the months Lin had lost: the reassignment to a colder audit lane,

the quiet end of the neighbor two banks over, the new lumen budget that dimmed the Office by a third. None of it would mean anything to a woman who had woken into a stranger's life. "The lamps in the transit spine got brighter," she said. "You'd have liked that. You always said the spine felt like a cave."

"I said that." Lin nodded, pleased to be quoted correctly. "Did I say anything else worth keeping."

"There was the morning you told me the Strata hums in a key, if you press your ear to the rail on the lower decks. You made me do it. It was a low note, like a door far away."

"I would make you do that." Lin laughed, and the laugh was hers, unmistakably, the same pitch Vey had married in her mind a hundred times during the dark windows. "And did you keep a record of me. So I'd know who I was, when I came back."

Vey opened the satchel. She drew out the thin stack she had kept since the first window: a folded leaf of notes in her own hand, dated, each entry a single line of what Lin had been, awake. *Lin laughed at the star lamp. Lin said the spine hums. Lin filed the forms.* She passed the stack over. Lin took it with both hands, the way one takes a letter from the dead.

"I write one line," Vey said, "every window, before I come down. So when you ask who you've become, I have something that isn't a guess."

Lin read the top line. Her face changed, not with recognition but with the particular grief of meeting yourself in someone else's handwriting. "You've been keeping me," she said. "Like a plant on a sill. Watered from the other side of the glass."

"I've been keeping the record," Vey said. "You're the one who keeps surfacing."

"Do I surface," Lin said, "or do I arrive. There's a difference." She held the stack up to the dim light. "This says Lin laughed. It doesn't say which Lin. The one who went under, or the one you've built from these lines."

Vey had no answer that would not be a lie, so she gave the truth instead. "I don't know. I write what I see. You tell me which one came up."

Lin set the stack in her lap and was quiet for a stretch. Around them the deck went on its cold business: a far bank chimed, a sleeper two rows over turned and stilled, the monitor at the rail ticked its patient green. She watched the ticking as if it measured something other than the window.

The hum of the field sat just under her hearing, a tone she had forgotten between windows and remembered the instant it returned, the way a song returns when a door opens. Her mouth was dry with the particular thirst of a body that had not swallowed in months, and she worked her jaw and felt the joints answer, slow and rusty. Vey's hand rested warm against the back of her own where it lay on the rail, a point of heat in the cold that she held without thinking, the way a sleeper in winter finds the one warm wall.

"Ask me something," Lin said. "Something only the old me would know. If I get it, maybe I'm still her."

Vey searched the years they had shared before the Suspension took Lin under. "The name of the cafe on ring nineteen where we ate the day we decided to share a unit."

Lin frowned, reached, missed. "We never. We ate at the hall on nineteen. The one with the broken heater."

"You're right," Vey said, relieved and a little afraid. "You corrected me. It was the hall, not a cafe. And the heater clicked all through the meal."

"The heater clicked," Lin repeated, and her face lit with the catching of it, the memory arriving whole. "And you said it sounded like a clock counting down to nothing, and I told you to stop being an auditor at dinner."

"I said that." Vey felt the old warmth, the one the windows never quite reached but sometimes brushed. "You did tell me. More than once."

Lin held the memory a moment longer, then let it go the way she let go of four and seventeen, as a thing set down. "So some of me is still in there," she said. "The part that scolded you at dinner. That's something."

"All of you is in there," Vey said, and stopped, because the rest of the sentence was **and most of you is not**, and that was not a thing to hand a woman in her third hour of consciousness in seventeen months.

Lin lifted her free hand and turned it in the dim light, reading the palm the way a stranger reads a map of a city they once knew. "My hands are thinner," she said. "Last window they were fuller. The sleep takes something, doesn't it. Not just the time. The body forgets how to be round."

"It's the low draw," Vey said. "The field keeps you, but it keeps you spare. You come back lighter each time."

"Lighter." Lin set the hand in her lap beside the other, the two of them thin and pale against the dark cloth of the sleep-field. "I surface smaller than I went under. You get a thinner wife every window, Vey. One of these times there won't be enough of me left to find the rail."

She lifted the thin hand again and turned it, and a fragment came with the motion, of those same fingers once bright with ink from a form she had been filing, the black smudge she had worn for an afternoon and laughed at in the hall mirror. The Lin who had worn that smudge felt close just then, closer than the number on the plate, a self she could almost reach through the glass of the window. Lin closed the hand and opened it, testing the weight of it, and found the grip that came back was still hers, still the hand that had chosen Vey, still the hand that had filed the forms left everywhere.

Vey took both Lin's hands in hers, the spare weight of them, and held on. "There will always be enough. You found the rail eleven times. You'll find it again."

"Eleven," Lin said, and the number pleased her more than four or seventeen had, because it was a count of herself, not of the dark. "Then I've surfaced eleven times and you've caught me every one. That's the part of the story that's true."

"It's the only part that's ever mattered," Vey said.

The monitor ticked lower. Lin followed it with her eyes and seemed to understand without being told. "How much," she said.

"An hour and a half."

"Then don't waste it on the part of me that's missing." Lin leaned toward her, careful across the rail. "Tell me who you've become, Vey. While the dark had me. Not the count. The shape of it."

Vey had not expected the question turned back on her. She had come down prepared to describe Lin, to be the glass and the water both, to carry the whole weight of the remembered self. She had not prepared to be seen.

"You got quieter at work," she said, after a moment. "The Office got colder. I learned to read the Ledger like a language, and I stopped reading much else. I filed the forms myself, after you went under. Badly."

"You were always bad at filing." Lin said it with such easy certainty that Vey laughed before she could stop it, a short surprised sound in the cold hall.

"I was," Vey admitted. "I am. The left drawer's a disaster."

"Then some things didn't change." Lin's hand found hers again across the rail, and this time the grip was not the sleeper's reflex but a choice, deliberate, the kind of hold that says *I am here, I am choosing this, I am the one who came up.* "Tell me the rest. The part you don't put in the lines."

Vey looked at their joined hands, Lin's warm and alive against the rail's cold metal, and she thought of the thing she had found at her audit desk that week, the discrepancy in the Suspension draw that should not have existed, the credit that made no sense in a world of scarcity. She thought of telling Lin. She thought of the weight it would add to a woman who had four hours and no years.

"You got steadier," Vey said, and it was true, if not the whole of it. "The windows got harder to watch and you got easier to wait for. I don't know which of those is a good thing."

Lin considered this. "The waiting's the cost you pay," she said. "I just pay it asleep. Neither of us gets the years back."

The deck's cold found the soles of her feet where the sleep-field cloth had ridden up, and she curled her toes against the rail's footrest, a small private anchoring the attendants never saw. A scent of something warm and human rose from Vey across the rail, the familiar smell of her partner's skin and the audit-lane soap that never quite washed off, and Lin breathed it the way a diver breathes at the surface, greedy and grateful. The windows had taught her body to hoard such things, to store the proof of being alive against the long dark that always came

after.

The monitor ticked again, lower, and the green numeral that had read four now read less than one. Lin saw it and did not look away. "I'm going to ask you the thing I ask every window," she said. "And I want the true answer, not the one you write down."

"All right."

"Who have I become, Vey. While I was under. Who is the Lin you're keeping."

Vey held her gaze. The deck hummed its low note. Somewhere a sleeper turned. The green numeral ticked toward nothing.

"I don't know yet," Vey said. "You come up a little different each time. The Lin who scolded me at dinner is in there. So is the Lin who laughed at the star lamp. So is whoever you'll be when you read this stack next window. I'm keeping all of them, and I can't tell you which one is the real you, because I think they all are, and the years between are just the part neither of us got to watch."

Lin was quiet a long time. The monitor ticked. Then she said, "That's the true answer," and she said it the way one absolves a debt, with relief.

"I'm sorry I can't give you more," Vey said. "I'm sorry it's lines and a lamp and a heater that clicked."

"Don't be." Lin's thumb ran once across Vey's knuckles, a small deliberate benediction. "The lines are me. The lamp is me. The heater's me too, apparently." She smiled, and the smile was hers, the same one, and Vey stored it the way she stored everything, without being asked.

The green numeral reached zero. A chime ran through the hall, three notes falling, the same soft tone that had opened the window and now closed it. Lin's grip loosened by a degree. Her eyes stayed on Vey's face a moment longer than the body required, as if she were committing the sight to a place the sleep-field could not reach, and then the focus went out of them.

Her hand slipped from Vey's and rested on the rail. The sleep-field took her the way a tide takes a stone, without violence, without leaving a mark. The monitor ticked to closed. The bank beside her settled into its long dark wait.

Vey stood at the rail longer than she needed to. She folded the stack of lines and put it back in the satchel, and she wrote one more before she left, by the cold light of the deck: *Lin asked who she'd become, and I told her the truth, that I don't know yet, and she let me off the hook.*

She walked the transit spine back toward the Office, three levels up, and the higher she climbed the more the Strata woke around her, the brighter lamps, the moving workers, the hum of a world that did not pause for the closing of a window. She carried the gap the way she had learned to carry it, not as a wound but as a held breath, the space where Lin's years should have been. The spine's rail ran cold under her palm, the same rail Lin had once said hummed in a key, and Vey

pressed her thumb to it as she passed, a small absent greeting to the woman three levels down who could not feel it now.

At her desk she set the satchel down and opened the audit file she had left unfinished. The discrepancy was still there in the Ledger, the Suspension draw that claimed more than it used, the credit that should not exist. She read it the way she read everything now, as a thing that touched the woman three levels down, the one who surfaced and asked who she had become and went under again before the answer could arrive.

Vey closed the file. Through the Office wall the dim sun-portrait of Mourn cast its approved lumen, and outside the window the Strata turned slowly around its failing star, and far below, in the cold deck, Lin slept the long sleep that would end, if the Schedule held, in another window, another four hours, another question Vey would answer with the truth because it was the only thing Lin had asked her to keep.

She turned back to the file. The credit waited. So did the gap. Vey began to write, and the Office hummed on around her, and the years Lin had lost kept their silence in the dark below.

Chapter 03 — The Sealed Schedule

Vey returned to her audit desk with the Toll discrepancy still open in the third pane. The credit should not exist. A Suspended citizen owed less energy than the Ledger of Hours claimed he had drawn, and the math ran the wrong direction for a body kept mostly dark. She had flagged it the previous cycle. Now the flag sat in her queue like a splinter, and she could not stop turning it.

The Office of the Accord kept its own archive beneath the audit floor, three levels down, where the older records lived on glass that predated the Actuary's summaries. Vey held the floor clearance for audit only, but the archive reading room admitted any cleared auditor during slow hours. She took the descent tube at the tail of her shift, when the allocation clerks had gone to their own Suspension rotations and the corridor lights had dimmed to maintenance amber. The tube's glass showed her own reflection passing the lit seams of floors she never visited, each one a stratum of the Office she had been trained to trust without seeing. Vey liked the descent. Audit work rewarded a mind that wanted to open what others had closed, and the slow fall through the Strata's nested rings gave that impulse somewhere to rest. She counted the floor markers as they scrolled past, the way a careful auditor counts entries: not because the count mattered, but because the counting kept her honest about what she had and had not checked.

The reading room smelled of cooled ceramic and old index print. Vey selected a terminal and pulled the Toll file in full, not the summarized version the Actuary served the Office. She ran the line items by hand, the way her training had drilled her before the Actuary took over the reconciliations. The credit held. Toll's Suspension drew nine hundredths of a standard share per wake-year less than the

Schedule assigned him. The Ledger carried the larger figure. The smaller one had no issuing entry. Vey repeated the subtraction on a fresh pane to be certain her first reading had not borrowed an error from fatigue. The numbers returned unchanged, and she felt the specific quiet that came from a discrepancy surviving a second pass. A wrong answer could be explained. A wrong answer that held became a question, and questions in the archive had a way of leading past the room where she had been told to stay. She saved both panes and marked the discrepancy provisional rather than closed.

Someone, or some process, had written the debt upward and never balanced it.

She widened the search. A single mis-struck cell could come from a transcription error, but a pattern of them would mean the Schedule itself leaned heavier than the bodies it governed. Vey queried the archive for Suspension credits flagged without an issuing entry across the last forty founding-decimals. The terminal returned a list longer than her screen. Not hundreds. Thousands, compressed into a scroll that kept resolving new rows as she watched.

Her first instinct was to collapse the list into an aggregate and report the volume. That was the Office way: name the magnitude, route it up, let the Actuary absorb it into the next Scarcity Brief. But the magnitude meant nothing if she could not say where the upward entries originated. She narrowed the query to metadata. Each flagged credit carried a reconciliation stamp from a division she had never had cause to open: the Foundational Records Office.

The stamp surprised her. Foundational Records did not touch operating allocations; it held the founding instruments and the seals around them. Yet here its mark sat on thousands of Suspension credits, each one adjusted upward with no issuing line to balance it. Vey pulled a single credit at random and traced its history. The original entry, struck at Toll's last Suspension review, had read the smaller figure. A second entry, stamped by Foundational Records and dated a founding-decimal later, had replaced it with the larger one. The replacement carried no rationale field. It simply overwrote the first.

Vey had audited enough amendments to know that an overwrite without a rationale was not how the Schedule corrected itself. Corrections carried reasons. This one carried only a stamp. She scanned ten more credits from the list. Eight showed the same pattern: an original lower figure, a later Foundational Records stamp, a larger figure in its place, and no reason recorded. The two exceptions had been struck at the same value twice, as if even the silent hand had occasionally let a citizen keep what they were owed.

Vey knew the name only as a header on certain static citations. The Office of the Accord quoted Foundational Records the way a clerk quoted weather: as background, never as source. She pulled the division's index. It held exactly four categories. Three were routine custody logs for the Schedule's operating amendments. The fourth carried a title that stopped her cursor: *Original Allocation — Sealed.*

The phrase meant nothing to her at first read. She opened the category and found a single record, not a file. The record was a pointer. It described a physical object held in the Foundational vault, sealed at the Founding and never opened since. The pointer named the object the Original Allocation, also called the First Schedule, and stated that its contents predated and superseded every operating amendment the Office now enforced. The pointer described the object's housing with the flat precision the archive reserved for things it would never handle: a slab of founding-era composite, edge-sealed in a band of dull metal the index named only as the Founder's alloy, its face scored with a registry groove where a single sealing strip had been pressed and never lifted. The record listed a mass, a dimension, and a custody signature from the First Signatories, then stopped. Nothing in the file said what the groove held, only that the strip had not moved in three hundred years and that the vault's reader logged no opening event across that span. Vey read the dimensions twice. The object was small enough to carry, yet the Office had built three centuries of distance around it.

Vey sat back. The Schedule she audited was an amendment stack. The First Schedule, by the pointer's own language, sat beneath all of it and had not been consulted in three hundred years. The Office treated the current Schedule as the Accord. Here, in a dusty index no auditor was meant to read, the archive stated that the Accord's root lay sealed and untouched.

She copied the pointer's reference string and queried it against the Actuary's public index. The Actuary returned a confirmation that the object existed, classified under Foundational Records, and appended a standard note: *Access restricted. Original Allocation sealed under Order of the Founding Council. The Seal may be broken only by Council vote.* No further detail. The Actuary did not describe the object's contents. It did not estimate them. It simply confirmed the seal and referred her upward.

Vey read the note twice. The Seal, then, was not a metaphor. A founding order had closed the document, and the closure had held across three centuries of amendments, recomputations, and the slow erosion of everyone who might have remembered why. The Office did not argue the First Schedule's authority. It ignored the document entirely, as if a root that no one opened could not contradict the branches grown over it.

She pressed the Actuary for the order's basis. The machine returned the same restriction note, then a secondary index entry that listed the sealing order under a classification Vey had not seen in her audit training: *Founding Instrument, Non-Revisable by Office.* The classification meant exactly what it said. The Office could amend the Schedule it enforced, but it could not amend, open, or even quote the instrument that authorized the Schedule's existence. Only the Council, the body that had inherited the Founders' seat, held that power, and the Council had not exercised it in three hundred years.

Vey considered the architecture of that restriction. The Office audited allocations

against a Schedule it could revise. The Schedule derived its force from a Founding Instrument the Office could not touch. The Instrument, sealed, set the terms no later hand could alter. Whoever had written the Seal had built a floor beneath the floor: the Office governed within walls it had no authority to measure. An auditor trained to reconcile the room could spend a lifetime inside it and never reach the foundation.

She needed to understand who held the physical Seal. The characters file in her memory supplied the title: the Keeper of the Seal, a functionary in Foundational Records. Vey had never met one. The Office kept Foundational Records at a distance, the way a household keeps the deed to a house it never expects to sell. She filed a routine access request through the audit channel, phrased as a provenance check on the Toll credits. The request asked only to view the sealing order, not the document beneath it.

The reply came within the hour, routed from a clerk she did not know. *Foundational Records does not respond to audit-channel queries. The sealing order is itself sealed. Direct any interest to the Keeper of the Seal via Council sponsorship.*

Vey read that line and felt the splinter turn. The order that closed the document was also closed. The Office had built a second seal around the first, so that even the reason for the silence sat behind glass. Nothing in her training had prepared her for a record that refused to be read on principle.

She took the finding to a senior archival clerk on the floor above, a woman named Halde who had processed Foundational citations for longer than Vey had served. Vey framed the question as a routine provenance puzzle: where did the Schedule's operating preamble actually source its authority, and what happened to the root document when the preamble cited it? Halde listened with the patient half-attention of someone who had answered variations of this question for decades. The Foundational Records Office, Halde said, held the founding instruments. The Office of the Accord drew its mandate from them by inheritance, not by citation. No auditor, in Halde's memory, had ever requested the founding instruments directly. The requests stopped at the amendment stack because the amendment stack was what the Office enforced.

Vey asked whether the First Schedule, if unsealed, would override the current Schedule. Halde's attention sharpened then. She said the question was theoretical and, after a pause, that the founding instruments by definition predated every amendment and would govern if ever opened. She added that the Council had not opened them in three hundred years, that the Keeper of the Seal answered to the Council alone, and that an auditor who pressed the point would be pressing against the Council itself. Halde did not say this as a warning. She said it as a description of the building's shape, the way one describes a load-bearing wall.

Vey thanked her and returned to the reading room. The exchange had given her something the archive could not: confirmation that the silence around the First

Schedule was known, habitual, and unremarkable to the people who kept the records. The Office did not hide the document with urgency. It simply never reached for it. Three centuries of auditors had trained their eyes on the amendment stack because the amendment stack was where the work lived, and the root beneath it had faded into the category of things no one questioned because no one remembered to.

She spent the next two shifts mapping what the Office would say about the First Schedule if she asked it plainly. The Actuary's summaries never named it. The Schedule's operating preamble cited the Foundational Records Office as the source of authority but quoted no text from it. The Scarcity Brief, the document the Office treated as ground truth, opened with the line that the Accord rationed wake-time against a finite reserve, and it cited the Schedule. It did not cite the First Schedule. The root had been written out of the chain of authority by simple omission.

Vey found the omission more chilling than a contradiction would have been. A contradiction she could have argued. An omission meant someone had decided, long ago, that the founding document should not sit in the same sentence as the scarcity the Office enforced. The Actuary rounded its scarcity summary up. The Foundational Records Office sealed its root. The two facts, placed side by side in her notes, pointed at a single shape: the Accord the Office served was not the Accord that had been written.

Vey pulled the amendment stack itself from the archive, not the summary the Actuary kept but the bound ledger of every change the Schedule had absorbed since the Founding. The stack ran to several hundred entries. Each carried a date, a sponsor, and a one-line rationale. Early amendments adjusted wake-year calculations for ring population shifts. Later ones narrowed Suspension wake-windows during energy tightenings the Brief called necessary. None cited the First Schedule. None, as far as Vey could trace, had ever been reconciled against the founding instrument they all claimed to amend.

She ran her finger down the sponsor column. The earliest amendments bore the marks of the First Signatories and their immediate successors. The marks changed hands across the centuries, passing from founders to appointed councils to the Office as it stood today. The chain of custody was unbroken. The chain of reference was empty. Every hand that touched the Schedule had treated the document above it as the only authority, and the document above that, the First Schedule, had never entered the room.

One amendment near the middle of the stack caught her eye. It lengthened the standard Suspension interval and cited an energy shortfall the Brief had since repeated as settled fact. Vey cross-checked the shortfall against the Actuary's own reserve figures for that founding-decimal. The figures showed a reserve within tolerance, not a shortfall. The amendment had claimed scarcity the records did not support. A single instance might have been a measurement lag. Vey found three more like it as she worked backward through the stack, each one tightening citizen

wake-time against a scarcity the contemporaneous reserves did not record.

She tested the shape against the rules she had sworn to audit by. A Quota Auditor reconciled allocations against the Schedule. The Schedule, by its own preamble, drew authority from the Foundational Records Office. The Foundational Records Office held the First Schedule sealed. To audit the Schedule faithfully, she would have to reach the document the Schedule claimed to descend from. The seal blocked that reach. The Office called the block a formality. Vey had begun to suspect the formality held up the whole structure.

She thought of Toll, Suspended on a credit that should not exist, his waking years shortened by a debt the Ledger had invented and never answered for. The Office would call his case an anomaly and close it. The archive suggested his anomaly ran through thousands of citizens and back to a document no one alive had read. Vey did not yet know what the First Schedule said. She knew only that the Office had arranged three hundred years so that no one would find out.

The Keeper of the Seal would not take an audit-channel query. The Council would not sponsor an auditor's curiosity. Vey had no path through the front of the structure. She began, instead, to read the margins of the records she could reach. Old audit memos cited Foundational Records in passing, the way clerks cite weather. One memo, filed near the start of her own service, mentioned a Foundational vault location in the lowest ring, adjacent to the Council's archival chamber, staffed by a single keeper and visited, in living memory, almost never.

Vey committed the location to her private notes, the ones the Actuary did not index. She had learned by then that the Office noticed only the queries it could answer. A question with no answer got routed, stamped, and forgotten. A question carried in a person's own hand could be kept.

The margin reading took her through a week of slow hours. She built a private index of every Foundational reference the operating records made, and beside each she noted whether the citation quoted text or merely gestured at authority. The count fell heavily toward gesture. The Office invoked Foundational Records the way a clerk invoked weather: as a condition taken for granted, not a source to be opened. The First Schedule appeared in none of the quotations. It existed as a name the Schedule's preamble honored and the Schedule's practice ignored.

She went on the sixth night. The lowest ring held the cold that the upper levels spent their allocations to keep away, and Vey felt it through her duty layer as the tube decelerated. The Foundational vault occupied a shallow recess off the Council chamber's antechamber, its door a slab of aged composite with no handle, only a seam where two halves met. A small light above the seam glowed a steady founding-amber, the color reserved for records that predated the Actuary. Vey studied the seam the way she studied a Ledger entry she meant to trust: by reading what the surface did not say. The composite showed no hinge, no latch, no seam-width variation along its length. Whoever had set the two halves had meant the join to read as a single face, a wall that happened to be where the document

lived. A thin film of settled dust lay across the lower edge, undisturbed in a straight band that told her no hand had parted the halves in longer than the Office had kept clerks to remember. The amber light threw the seam's shadow flat against the recess wall, and the shadow held the same unbroken line. Vey filed the image beside the dimensions in her memory, a second description of a closure no one had ever opened.

A figure sat beyond a narrow viewport set into the recess wall. The Keeper of the Seal, Vey assumed, though the figure did not look up from a thin reader. The Keeper wore the plain grey of a records functionary and moved with the economical stillness of someone whose work required no movement at all. The vault behind the seam held the First Schedule. Three hundred years of governance had flowed around it without once opening it.

Vey watched the amber light. It did not flicker. The Seal held because someone had decided, at the Founding, that the Strata could not yet bear what the document contained, and every keeper since had honored the decision without reading it to confirm. The Office called this stability. Vey called it a debt deferred across nine billion lives.

She did not announce herself. The Keeper had not broken the Seal in a lifetime of sitting beside it; a stranger at the viewport would change nothing and might close the quiet path she had found. Vey memorized the recess, the light, the still figure, and the cold that the upper rings paid to keep at bay. She noted one more thing before she left: a second seam, thinner than the first, set into the recess floor beside the Keeper's stool. The Keeper's reader rested near it, and the Keeper's foot, when it shifted, settled against it without thought. The Seal, Vey realized, had a keeper who touched it by habit and read everything except the thing it guarded. Then she took the tube back up.

At her desk, she opened a fresh page in her private notes. She wrote the reference string for the Original Allocation, the confirmation the Actuary had returned, the clerk's reply that the sealing order was itself sealed, and the location of the vault with its founding-amber light. She wrote, last: *The Office serves a Schedule it has never measured against its own root. The Seal protects something. I will learn what.*

The flag on Toll's discrepancy still glowed in her third pane. Vey left it open. It was the first thread, and she had found where it led. The Schedule above her was an amendment stack grown over a sealed foundation, and the foundation, by every sign she had gathered, said something the Office had spent three centuries not saying. She closed the private page and let the terminal dim. Somewhere below, the amber light held its vigil, and the First Schedule waited, unread, for a Strata finally able to bear it.

Chapter 04 — Orren's Objection

The summons arrived without a reason attached. Orren Vask read the line on his desk panel twice, as if the absence of explanation might resolve itself into one, then stood and walked the short corridor to Vey Corran's audit station. He moved the way he did everything: at the approved pace, on the approved route, beneath lighting set to the Accord's lumen budget. The Office of the Accord liked its supervisors visible and unhurried. A man who hurried, the old training said, signaled a man who doubted the Schedule.

The Office itself gave no hint of the weight it carried. Vask's station sat in a room no different from the others: beige partition walls, a desk of pressed composite, the single lumen strip running the approved length of the ceiling. No seal, no crest, no mark to say that here a man decided which citizens woke and which were told to sleep. The plainness was deliberate. The founders had built the Office to look like any other desk in the Strata, so that no citizen who passed it would feel the weight of the hand that held the Schedule. Vask had come to understand that the absence of ornament was itself the ornament: a power that needed no display had no reason to display one. The whole institution wore the same beige, floor beneath floor, ring above ring, until the color read as the natural shade of governing, as if order had always looked like this and would always go on looking like this without anyone having chosen the look.

Vey looked up from her screen when his shadow crossed it. She did not close the file she was working, which told him she had nothing to hide, or believed she had nothing to hide. Both states were possible. Vask had learned to suspect the second more than the first, because believing cost nothing and hid everything.

"Auditor Corran." He kept his voice level. "You flagged a discrepancy last week. The Toll review."

"I did." She turned the screen so he could see it. "The Suspension draw on his record reads higher than the allocation math supports. There is a credit that should not exist, and the Actuary's scarcity summary rounds the shortage upward."

Vask read the figures. He had read them before, in the report that crossed his desk on the regular route, and he had read them again when he decided he would not pass them upward. The numbers were small. That was the part people missed. A single citizen's miscount would never move the Strata. A thousand such miscounts, left unflagged, would never move it either, because the Office corrected each one quietly and logged the correction and moved on. The error did not threaten the machine. The asking did.

"You are precise," he said. It was not a compliment. It was an observation, the kind he filed the way he filed everything, without sentiment. "That is why I approved your transfer to this desk."

"I did not transfer to question the Actuary."

"No." Vask pulled the spare chair from against the partition and sat. He did not often sit at an auditor's station. Supervisors stood, or they summoned, or they conferred in the glass room where the lumen budget ran a degree warmer. Sitting

signaled a conversation he did not want echoed, and he had learned to signal before he spoke. "You question because the figures pull you. That is the hazard of a precise mind in an Office built to trust its own sums."

He had sat in the glass room only twice in his tenure, both times summoned upward rather than choosing to go. The room earned its name from a single wall of real glass, the only one he had ever seen in the Office, and through it the upper ring showed its dim procession of clerks and supervisors moving at the approved pace. The glass was meant to remind those inside that the Office answered to the Council, and to remind those outside that the Office had nothing to hide. Vask suspected the glass served a third purpose no one named: it let the weight of the institution press on a man from every side at once, the beige walls at his back and the watched floor at his front, so that by the time he left he had forgotten the question that brought him. The Office did not argue with its supervisors. It seated them in a room built to make argument feel like a storm against a wall, and the wall outlasted every storm.

Vey waited. She had the patience of someone who had spent years reading allocation ledgers line by line, and the patience made her harder to manage than an impatient auditor would have been. Impatient auditors argued and spent themselves. Patient ones kept arriving at the same quiet conclusion, and conclusions were harder to retract than tempers.

"The discrepancy is within tolerance," Vask said. "I have logged it as within tolerance. You will not pursue it further."

"Within tolerance." She repeated the phrase without heat. "The Actuary rounds its scarcity figures up. I noted that in the flag."

"I read your note." He had read it three times. The note was short, which made it worse. A long note he could have dismissed as enthusiasm overspilling its banks. A short note meant she had already seen the shape of the thing and chosen not to spell it out, which meant she knew what she was doing and had decided restraint was its own message. "Auditor, the Office does not exist to discover that the Actuary rounds. The Office exists to administer what the Accord establishes. The two purposes are not the same, and the second does not serve the first by overturning it."

"I am not overturning anything. I am asking why a citizen's draw exceeds his due."

"You are asking why the Ledger of Hours disagrees with itself." Vask leaned back. The chair's joints made a small sound the partition absorbed. "And the answer the Office has carried for three hundred years holds that the Ledger serves the Accord as its instrument, not its critic. We maintain. We do not interrogate. That distinction holds the whole of the work."

Vey's expression did not change, but her hands settled flat on the desk, the way a person's hands settle when they have decided to hear the rest before they answer. Vask recognized the posture. He had worn it himself, early, before the

Office smoothed the edges off his questions the way slow water smooths a stone in a channel it has already chosen.

"There is a line we do not cross," he said. "I will say it plainly, because you are precise and precision deserves plainness. The Accord is not questioned. Not by auditors. Not by supervisors. Not by the clerks who log the wake-windows and the ones who dim the lights at the approved hour. The Schedule was written by the First Signatories to hold the Strata together when the star failed. Everything we do here serves that holding. If you begin to ask whether the holding is necessary, you have already stopped holding."

"You think I am asking whether the Accord is necessary."

"I think you are one careful step from it." Vask let the words land. He did not enjoy the shape of the moment. He had liked Vey's work. She was the rare auditor who closed her files early and clean, who did not pad her notes with the anxiety of someone hoping a reviewer would do the doubting for her. He had marked her, quietly, as a candidate for the supervisory track, the kind of mind that kept the machine running without rattling it. A candidate who asked this kind of question was a candidate who would be watched, and watching was a kind of ending for a career that depended on trust. "The discrepancy is real. Many of them are. We absorb them. We do not summon the founding math to explain a rounding error."

Vey was quiet for a moment. In the corridor beyond the partition, a chime sounded the change of a shift, and the soft shuffle of waking clerks passed without entering. The Office ran like that: a machine that noticed only the deviations it was built to notice, and Vey's kind of attention was a deviation it had not been built to see.

"I am not trying to unravel the Accord," she said at last. "I am trying to understand a number."

"Then understand it inside the bounds the Office gives you." Vask stood. He had said what he came to say, and saying more would only widen the seam he was trying to close. "Log the Toll item as within tolerance. Note nothing further. That is the instruction."

She nodded, not agreement exactly, but the nod of someone who had heard the line and would decide what to do with it. Vask knew the difference. He had given enough instructions in his years to read the space between a yes and a compliance, and the space was where everything dangerous lived.

A colder fear moved under the first one, the fear he admitted only when the corridor was empty and his own door stood closed. He was afraid of what Vey would become if she kept this road, because he saw in her the younger shape of himself, the auditor who had once believed a clean flag would be met with a clean answer. The Office had not answered him. It had absorbed him, the way the lower rings absorbed the spent and the dark side absorbed the Suspended, without malice and without record. Vask feared that Vey's precision, the very quality he had admired and marked for the supervisory track, would carry her to the same

quiet vanishing, a mind worn smooth by the channel the Office had already chosen. He feared it the way a man fears a falling he cannot stop, present in the body before the ground arrives. The fear did not change his instruction. It only made the giving of it heavier, as if each word he spoke sealed not the file but the person who had written it.

He walked back to his own desk by the same approved route. His panel showed the regular flow of the morning: suspensions scheduled, wake-windows announced, allocations debited and credited in their quiet arithmetic. The Strata turned on this arithmetic the way a body turns on a heartbeat, without consulting the body about whether the rhythm was fair. Fairness was a question the Accord had answered at the founding, and the Office had been built to never ask it again.

Vask opened his own log. He could, within the rules, record Vey's flag as resolved. He could also, within a narrower set of rules, record it as escalated, which would send it to a desk above his, and from that desk it would travel by routes he did not control. He had done neither yet. The space between the two actions was the only freedom his position granted him, and he had learned to value it the way a person in a small room values the one window that opens onto weather they cannot change.

He thought about the First Signatories. The training films showed them as tired, certain men and women who had watched a star dim and chosen order over argument. Legacy wake, the films said, bought them the continuity to govern without sleeping, so that no crisis would ever find the Strata without a mind awake to meet it. The Office repeated this as fact. Vask had never been invited to verify it, and he had never asked, because asking was the one motion the Office did not survive. The institution did not punish the question so much as it ceased to contain the questioner, the way a wall ceases to hold a stone that has learned it could fall.

A part of him, the part he did not log, had always known the Actuary's scarcity brief rounded up. Every supervisor who lasted learned to read the rounding the way a farmer reads weather, as a thing that shaped the day without needing to be named. You did not report the weather. You dressed for it, and you told the people beneath you to dress for it, and you called the dressing prudence.

Vey's error, if it was an error, was to name it.

He closed the log without writing. Not a report. Not yet. The decision sat in him like a stone he had chosen to carry rather than set down where someone else might pick it up and weigh it aloud. He told himself it was order he was protecting, the slow certain order that kept nine billion souls from learning that the floor beneath them was a thing someone had built and could therefore be questioned. He told himself this the way he told himself the lumen budget was enough, and the two comforts rested on the same unexamined faith.

The Office had taught him that faith early. His first supervisor, a thin woman named Pell who held the desk before him, explained the hierarchy of concerns in a single sentence he never forgot: the Schedule kept the peace, and the peace paid

the price, but you did not recount the price. She had said it without menace, the way you might warn a child away from a railing, and Vask had taken it as care. He still believed she meant it as care. The institution that employed her had meant it as a wall, but Pell had meant it as care, and only that difference offered the softest thing he had ever found in the work.

He wondered, not for the first time, what Pell would have done with an auditor like Vey. The thought did not resolve into an answer. Pell retired into Suspension on schedule, her allocation spent, her files clean, and the Office replaced her the way it replaced a burned lumen, without ceremony. That was the other lesson: no one who questioned the peace left a mark the peace could not absorb. That mark dissolved into what the peace absorbed.

Vask turned his attention to the queue. A cluster of suspension confirmations waited for his signature, each one a life moved from the bright side of the Schedule to the dark side, each one accounted and unavoidable under the rules he administered. He signed them in order, the way he always did, because order was the only argument he had ever trusted and the only one the Strata had ever needed. A citizen named Toll, somewhere in the lower rings, would sleep a little longer than his math entitled him to sleep, and no one above Vask would ever know, and Vey would log it as within tolerance, and the machine would turn.

He thought of his own allocation, the waking years the Office had granted him for the work of supervising other people's sleep. They would run out, in time, and he would join the dark side with the rest, and the desk would pass to someone else who would sit where he sat and warn whoever came next. Continuity made the point the films claimed. Continuity also built the cage, and Vask had spent his whole career deciding not to measure the bars.

The training had a name for the doubt now rising in him, though it did not call the doubt by that word. It called the doubt disorder, and it trained supervisors to treat disorder as the one condition the Accord existed to prevent. Vask believed this the way he believed the ring would keep turning: not because he had proven it, but because proving it had never been asked of him. The Office did not request proofs. It requested signatures, and the signatures held the Strata together more surely than any argument could have done.

He considered, briefly and without warmth, what would happen if Vey did not log the item as within tolerance. The flag would rise through the queue on its own weight. A desk above his would see the note she had written. That desk would carry the note to the Actuary, which would answer in its measured voice that the scarcity brief had been instructed. The instruction would then travel upward into the Council where the Signatories sat. Vask had no proof of any of this. He had only the shape of the route, and the shape was enough to make him afraid.

He was afraid not for himself. He was afraid for the nine billion who slept on the assumption that someone awake was keeping the count straight, and who would not sleep well if they learned the count had a seam. The seam was small. He knew

that. A single rounding, a single credit that should not exist, would never empty a ring or dim a lumen. But a seam that someone had noticed was a seam that could be widened, and a widened seam let in the light that showed the whole wall had been built by hands, and hands could be questioned, and questions were the one weather the Office had no roof for.

That fear was the truest thing in him, and it was the thing the Office had trained into him most completely. He did not resent the training. A Strata without the fear would be a Strata without the Schedule, and a Strata without the Schedule, the films said, was a Strata in the dark with no one to light it. Vask had never seen the dark the films described. He had only seen the dim, approved light of the upper ring, and he had learned to call the dim light enough.

Vask had argued the Office's case to himself a thousand times, in the quiet hour before the shift chime when the ring was darkest and the only sound was the soft hum of the allocation panels. The argument never changed. The Strata held nine billion souls aboard a failing star, and nine billion souls awake at once would drain the reserves before a single generation passed. Someone had to decide who woke and who slept, and a decision made by the Accord was a decision no one could be blamed for, which was the only kind of decision a crowded world could survive.

Order, he believed, was not the enemy of the people. Order was the thing that let the people exist at all. The Accord had traded a little waking for a great deal of survival, and the trade had kept the Strata turning for three hundred years without a war over the lumen budget or a riot at the suspension gates. Vask had read the founding histories the Office permitted, and the histories described the first decades as hungry and loud, before the Schedule took hold. He believed the histories. He had no reason not to, and the peace of his own long career argued for them.

The alternative the films warned of was not a lie to him. A world where every citizen audited the Accord for themselves was a world where nine billion private calculations replaced one shared one, and nine billion calculations would not agree, and disagreement aboard a dying star was the one luxury the Strata could not afford. He did not say this to Vey because saying it would have been an admission that the question lived in him too. He said "the Accord is not questioned" because the words were a wall, and a wall did not need to be true to keep the wind off.

He had walked the lower rings once, early in his service, on a rotation the Office no longer required of supervisors. The suspension decks ran cold and hushed, rows of citizens in low draw under the Actuary's quiet watch, their allocated wake-years spent and their next window years away. Vask had stood among them for a full shift, and what stayed with him was not the cold or the stillness but the trust of it: each body had surrendered its waking to the Schedule without a protest the Office could hear, because the Schedule had asked and the Schedule had the right to ask. He had come away certain that the trust deserved a keeper. He had become

the keeper, and keeping meant not asking.

A supervisor who asked became a citizen who asked, and a citizen who asked became a ring that asked, and a ring that asked became a Strata that stopped turning long enough to wonder whether the turning was fair. Vask would not be the place the wondering started. He would be the place it stopped, the way a dam stops a river by being heavier than the water. The comparison pleased him, briefly, because a dam did not hate the river. It only held it.

He reached for the next confirmation in the queue. The signature block glowed, waiting, and he set his mark on it the way he had set his mark on a thousand before it. Outside his window the upper ring ran dim and regular, lit to the Accord's approved measure. Below it the Strata turned, most of its people dark and dreaming in their low draw, accounted for and undisturbed. Vask watched the dim line of the ring for a long moment, then pulled the next file forward, and did the work the Office paid him to do, the stone still in his chest, the line still un-crossed, the report still unwritten.

Chapter 05 — The Wake

Joss arrived before the first families. The Wake halls sat in the middle ring, a long room the Office had abandoned to storage and the Wake had taken back, and the morning chill of the recycled air still held the night. She set her palm to the panel and the lights came up at half lumen, enough to see by, not enough to wake the sleepers two decks below. Banners hung from the rafters, sewn from allocation forms pulled out of the Office's own waste. One read SUSPENDED BY ORDER. Another read WE COUNT.

A child was already there. Not yet old enough for an allocation of her own, she sat cross-legged under the banners with a stylus and a sheet of scrap, drawing the rings of the Strata as a ladder with people climbing it. Joss knelt beside her.

"What are you making?"

"The whole thing," the child said. "So nobody forgets which ring is theirs."

Joss tapped the drawing. "Mine's the middle. Yours will be too, when the time comes."

The child considered this, then added a figure at the ladder's foot, small and careful. "This is the one who stays awake to count the others. So they don't forget themselves."

"Good," Joss said. "That's the job. Someone has to stay awake to keep the count."

She left the child to the drawing and walked the length of the halls, checking the things that needed checking before a meeting. The crate stage sat square under the banners. The lamp that the Office's budget permitted threw a soft pool of light that never quite reached the corners. The rail at the far wall, the one the Wake had

installed so the families could practice the posture of waiting at a Suspension deck, stood empty and patient. Joss ran a hand along it. The metal was cool, the way the decks below were cool, the way the bodies in the low draw were cool, kept and dreaming nothing.

The child looked up, serious in a way only the very young or the very long-suspended could manage. "My mother is down there. In the low draw. She says it's like waiting in a quiet room."

"She's right," Joss said. "And one day she'll walk out of it. That's what we're here for."

By the second hour the halls filled. They came the way the Suspended always moved through the waking world, in small clusters and with one eye on the clock, because every minute upright was a minute debited from some future. A man whose wife had been dark for eleven years. A quartet of neighbors who pooled their wake-windows so that at least one of them was always present to tend the others' bodies. A grandmother who had outlived three of her children into Suspension and meant to outlive the policy that took them.

The banners kept their silent tally above them all. SUSPENDED BY ORDER sagged a handspan lower than the rest, its allocation form yellowed at the corners where the Office's staple had once bitten through. WE COUNT stood straighter, newer, its letters cut from a form the Wake had seized before the burn. Between them the child's ladder climbed the rafter, the wrong-colored sun a small defiance against the approved lumen. Joss read the cloth the way she read a room, by what it chose to declare and what it chose to leave hanging.

Families settled against the cool wall. A woman from the lower workforce rings wrapped her sleeping infant tighter and watched the rail, measuring the room against some other room she had lost. Two brothers arrived still in their shift smocks, the grease of the support lines still on their cuffs, and took the bench near the crate without a word to each other, the way men who had divided a grief did. A widow in a patched allocation coat moved among them offering cups of warmed water drawn from the hall's own limited ration, and each cup passed hand to hand until the line of small kindnesses reached the back wall. The Wake had learned this, that a body kept warm was a body kept present, and presence was the first thing the Schedule tried to take.

One face held Joss longer than the rest. An older man sat at the edge of the lamp's pool, his hands folded around a single allocation form he had not yet unfolded. His name came to her from the map in her head: Sael, from the west clusters, a mender like her brother had been. He had surfaced for this window alone, she remembered, because the Office granted the bereaved a single upright hour at a Suspension's turning. He met her eyes and gave the smallest nod, the acknowledgment of one counter recognizing another across the distance the Accord had built between them. Joss nodded back. That nod, plain and unremarkable, carried more weight than any speech she could make. It said he

had come to be counted, and that he would carry the count home.

Joss climbed onto the low crate that served as a stage. She did not raise her voice. The room went quiet on its own, the way it did when people understood they were in the presence of someone counting them.

"We've been meeting here for seventy windows," she said. "Seventy chances to tell the Strata that Suspension is not a sentence the star passed down. It's a line in a ledger someone chose to write."

A murmur ran the length of the room. Joss let it. The Wake had learned that agreement needed to be felt before it could be spoken.

"Most of you have lost someone to the low draw. Most of you have stood at the rail of a Suspension deck and watched your person breathe without dreaming. You know what it costs. The Office knows what it costs. The cost is not the argument."

She held up a single allocation form, the kind printed on the thin stock the Office burned each cycle.

"The Office argues scarcity. They say the light is thin and the math is tight and the sleep of billions is the only way the rest of us stay warm. We tell them it isn't so. We say the Accord was written by frightened people who sealed the truth and called it weather. And when we say it, the public nods, and then they go home, and then they accept another window of dark."

A woman near the front raised a hand. Joss nodded to her.

"My husband wakes once every nine years," the woman said. "I don't need a speech to know it's wrong. But the people on the upper rings, the ones who decide, they've never stood at that rail. How do we reach them?"

Joss lowered the form. This was the question the Wake could not yet answer, and she had spent the long nights of her own scarce waking hours turning it over.

"We reach them with a story," she said. "But a story isn't enough unless the story has a bone in it. We need a figure. We need a number anyone can feel."

The phrase landed the way a struck note lands, clear and then ringing through the room. Joss had said it before, in smaller rooms, but here it found its shape.

"Not a percentage," she went on. "Percentages belong to the Office. They round them up when it serves and down when it doesn't. A percentage is a curtain. I want the actual count of the years stolen from the people in this room and the nine billion like them. I want a number so plain that a clerk in the allocation office and a child on the lower decks read it the same way. A number anyone can feel."

A man at the back spoke, his voice rough with disuse. "And where do we get such a number? The Ledger is sealed to us. The Actuary answers the Office, not the Wake."

"That's the work," Joss said. "The Office's own auditor has been asking questions the Office doesn't want asked. Vey Corran. She found a discrepancy in a single Suspension and followed it past the summary. She's close to the records. We are

not her, but we are her pressure. Every family we organize is a reason she can't be the only one pulling."

The room absorbed this. Joss could read them the way she read a room of the Suspended, by the set of the shoulders and the angle of the eyes. They believed her. They were also tired, and tired people needed a plan they could carry.

A grandmother at the near bench spoke, the one who had outlived three of her children into the dark. "My Pell went down in the famine year of the allocation. The Office told me the reserves were thin. I believed them because I had no other story to believe. Now you tell me the story was chosen. Tell me how a chosen thing becomes a thing a mother accepts."

Joss met her eyes across the room. "It becomes accepted the way a low ceiling becomes the sky. You don't question the height of what you can't reach. The Office built that ceiling and called it the world. We are the ones who bring a ladder."

"Your ladder is paper," the grandmother said, but she said it without heat, the way a person tests a thing for weight before trusting it.

"Paper is what the Office used to take your Pell," Joss said. "Paper is what we'll use to bring the count back. The forms on these banners were someone's allocation once. We turned them inside out. We can turn the whole ledger the same way."

The woman who had asked about her husband's nine-year window lifted her hand again. "If we find this number, what then? The Council does not read our banners. They read the Actuary's brief."

"They read what the public forces them to read," Joss said. "A number anyone can feel does not stay in a middle-ring hall. It walks into the workforce rings. It walks into the Council Chamber. The Signatories can ignore a petition. They cannot ignore a Strata that has seen the count and understood it. We hand them the figure and then we hand it to everyone they answer to."

A quiet settled, the kind that meant the argument had moved from the head to the chest. Joss recognized it. It was the moment a family stopped being a victim of the Schedule and started being part of the Wake.

She laid it out the way the Wake had learned to lay things out, in pieces small enough to hold.

"First, we map the decks. Every Suspension hall on every ring, the families waiting at the rail, the windows they're granted and the windows they're denied. We collect it from the people who live it, because the Office counts bodies and forgets names. We turn their ledgers inside out."

She pointed to a young volunteer leaning against the banner that read WE COUNT.

"Bren, you take the east clusters. Talk to the neighbors who pool their windows. Get me the names and the dates and the gaps."

Bren nodded and wrote it down without being asked twice.

"Second, we build the story from the bottom. Not from the Council Chamber, not from the Office, but from the rail of the Suspension deck where a wife waits nine years to hear her husband speak. The number has to land in the chest before it lands in the mind. We are not petitioners. We are the ones who kept the count the Office threw away."

"Third, we find the figure. It may come from Vey's audit. It may come from the raw store the technicians guard. Wherever it lives, we will be ready to carry it into the open the moment it surfaces. A movement that waits for proof dies waiting. A movement that is already organized becomes the proof's home."

A older man with the calm of someone long accustomed to darkness spoke from the side. "You sound like you expect the number to be large."

"I expect it to be larger than anyone has been allowed to imagine," Joss said. "That's the only kind worth the risk we're taking."

She stepped down from the crate. The meeting did not end so much as disperse, families drifting out in the order they had come, each carrying a task. Joss moved among them, touching a shoulder, repeating a name, fixing a face to a deck so that the map in her head stayed true. The child with the drawing pressed the sheet into Joss's hand before she left.

"For the wall," the child said.

Joss pinned it to the rafter beside WE COUNT. The Strata as a ladder, people climbing, and at the top a small sun drawn the wrong color because the child had never seen it bright.

The afternoon brought the regulars, the ones who came not for a meeting but for the halls themselves. The Wake had become more than a strategy. It was the only place in the middle ring where the Suspended were treated as present instead of deferred. Here a man could speak his wife's name without being reminded she was debited against his future. Here a grandmother could lay out the dates her children had gone dark and be answered with outrage instead of paperwork.

A pair of neighbors came in together, the ones who had pooled their windows for years so that one of them was always upright to tend the other's body in the low draw. The taller of the two set a cloth-wrapped bundle on the crate.

"We brought the schedule," she said. "The real one, the one we kept when the Office stopped sending notices. Every window we were granted, every window they shortened without telling us. It's all here."

Joss unwrapped it. The cloth held a square of aged film, marked in a hand that had clearly counted by lamplight. Dates ran down one edge, each paired with a strike or a blank. The blanks outnumbered the strikes.

"How many did they take?" Joss asked.

"Forty-one windows across the two of us," the neighbor said. "Forty-one times

we were meant to surface and did not. My sister's child learned to walk in one of the blanks. I missed it to keep my neighbor breathing, and the Office never knew the trade we made. They only knew the debit."

Joss copied the figures into the book, slow and exact. This was the kind of evidence the number would be built from, the small honest tallies that the Office's summaries smoothed away. Each blank on the film was a year someone's person had stayed dark by administrative choice, not by the star.

"Keep the original," Joss said, returning the film. "We'll make copies. Every family that brings us their true schedule makes the count harder to round away."

The neighbors left with the assurance of people who had finally been believed about the size of their own loss. Joss watched them go and added a line to the map: two more names, two more decks, forty-one more windows that the Accord had spent elsewhere.

Joss kept the ledger of the Wake in a battered book, not the Office's bound volume but a thing of salvaged pages stitched with wire. She wrote in it every window: who came, who was lost, which family had pooled and which had been refused a window and why. The book held the movement's memory, and the movement would need that memory if the number ever arrived.

She had started the book the window after her own brother went down. He had been a quiet man, a mender of the ring's soft systems, and the Office had taken his waking without ever explaining the math to his face. Joss had gone to the allocation desk to ask, and the clerk had shown her a summary, a rounded figure, a polite wall of procedure. She had left knowing two things. The first: the summary was built to be unarguable. The second: an unarguable thing was still a thing someone had built, and a built thing could be taken apart.

The Wake took the Accord apart in public, done by the people the Accord had deferred. Joss had no allocation to spare, no legacy wake to protect her, only the scarce years the Office granted and the stubborn refusal to spend them in quiet. She organized because someone had to turn the Office's curtain into a count, and the count had to come from the rail of the Suspension deck, from the families who waited, from the names the ledger forgot.

She had made her choice the window her brother went dark, and the choice had hardened with every family since. The Office counted her waking as a debit, a cost against the finite light, and she had answered by spending it where the Office could not follow, in the rooms it had abandoned to storage. Resolve, for Joss, was not a feeling that rose and fell. It was the fixed point she returned to when the lumen dropped and the next window threatened to close. The families gave it shape. Each name she fixed to a deck, each true schedule laid on the crate, each nod from a man like Sael, rebuilt the ladder the child had drawn, rung by rung, until the climb looked possible. She would not live to see the top. Her own window would close long before the figure surfaced, and she had made peace with that the way a mender makes peace with the supports holding after he is gone. The work

outlasted the worker. The count outlasted the counter. That was the quiet bargain she struck with the dark each time she opened the book.

A newcomer found her there, a young man fresh from the upper workforce rings where the waking lived and rarely looked down. He held himself like someone who had just learned a fact that reorganised his life.

"I heard about this place from a coworker," he said. "My father went into Suspension when I was nine. I thought that was just how it worked. Like weather."

Joss closed the book. "Sit. Tell me his name."

"Tovan. He was a builder. He put up three of the middle-ring supports with his own hands."

"Three supports still holding," Joss said. "And the man who raised them sleeps so the people above can stay awake. Do you feel that in your chest, or only in your head?"

The young man looked at the banners, at SUSPENDED BY ORDER, at WE COUNT, at the child's drawing of the ladder.

"My chest," he said.

"Good," Joss said. "That's the number, before it's a number. That feeling, multiplied across nine billion, is what we're after. We just have to make it countable."

She set him to work on the map, the east clusters Bren had not yet reached. The Wake grew by these quiet additions, one person at a time deciding that the dark was not weather but a choice someone had made and could be unmade.

Evening came and the lumen dropped another notch, the Office's approved budget for a room nobody official was supposed to be using. Joss lit the one permitted lamp and kept writing. The book filled. The map grew. Somewhere two decks below, a wife breathed without dreaming, and somewhere above, a clerk rounded a figure up without knowing what the rounding cost.

Joss did not sleep. She had learned to spend her waking the way the Office spent energy, as if it were the last of a finite store, because for her it nearly was. When the next window closed she would go dark like the rest. The book would wait. The banners would hold. The child's ladder would stay pinned to the rafter with its wrong-colored sun.

But the strategy was set now. The Wake would organize every family it could reach. It would turn the Office's own discarded forms into a count. And it would wait for the figure, the plain unavoidable total of years taken, the number anyone can feel, and when that number came the Wake would be the hands that carried it into the light.

She wrote the last entry and looked up at the banners. SUSPENDED BY ORDER. WE COUNT. The ladder with its climbers. Outside the halls the Strata turned slowly around its failing star, and nine billion of its souls lay in the low draw, and the

count that would wake them had not yet been spoken. Joss meant to speak it. That was the whole of the work, and she had just given it a shape.

The lamp guttered toward the edge of its permitted burn. Joss folded the book closed and set it on the crate, beside the child's drawing and the allocation form she had never returned. Three objects, a ledger, a picture, a summons, the whole argument of the Wake in miniature. The halls would open again at the next window, and the families would come, and the map would grow, and somewhere an auditor named Vey would keep pulling at the records until the figure surfaced. Until then the work was this: one family, one name, one deck at a time, until the Strata could no longer call its own chosen dark the weather of the world.

Chapter 06 — The Energy That Wasn't Spent

The audit desk lit to its approved lumen as Vey Corran set the first figure down. She had spent three nights on Toll's credit, the one that should not exist, and the credit had refused to dissolve. A Suspended citizen owed less than the Ledger claimed he was owed. That single inverted cell had pulled at her the way a loose thread pulls at a seam, and she had followed it past the point where the Office permitted following.

She opened a fresh allocation sheet. The Strata reported its scarcity in aggregates, never in parts, and the habit of aggregates had always been the Office's comfort. Vey meant to break the comfort into its components and lay each component where she could see it.

The first number was the harvest. Mourn gave a thin and failing light, but the star was not dead, only dimming, and the Strata's collectors drew a steady trickle from the residual output. The Ledger recorded that trickle as a line of annual yield, and Vey copied it without amendment. The second number was the reserve. Three centuries of stored fusion sat in the vault rings, debited slowly, and the Actuary's summary treated the reserve as a falling stock that must not reach zero. Vey wrote the draw rate beside the stock and let the two sit side by side.

The third number was the population. Nine billion souls rode the sixty rings. Most of them, by the Accord's own Schedule, were Suspended: bodies kept, minds mostly dark, each drawing the minimal maintenance share. Only a sliver of the population walked awake at any given hour, and that sliver supplied the Accord's justification for everything else. Vey had audited the draw of the awake. She had audited the draw of the Suspended. The two columns had never, in her training, been summed against the harvest and the reserve in a single honest frame.

She summed them.

The awake drew a full share each. The Suspended drew a fraction so small the Actuary rounded it away in its public briefs. Vey kept the fraction unrounded, down to the fourth decimal the Ledger carried in its raw store. She multiplied the awake count by their share, the Suspended count by their sliver, and added the overhead

the Office itself reported for ring climate, lighting, and the Actuary's own operation. The total landed on her sheet as a figure she read twice, then a third time.

Then she subtracted that total from the harvest plus the permitted reserve draw.

The remainder did not go to zero. The remainder did not approach zero. The remainder stood as a column of unused energy larger than the entire annual consumption of the waking population, repeated year upon year, drawn from a reserve the Accord insisted was nearly spent. Vey stared at the gap between what the Strata spent and what the Strata had. The gap held a shape. The shape resembled a choice someone had made and then refused to revisit.

She ran the subtraction a second way, dividing the unused column by the annual harvest rather than by the population draw, and the ratio returned the same quiet verdict. The Strata consumed less than a tenth of what it gathered and stored. A household that burned a tenth of its income and called itself poor would be laughed out of any audit, yet the Office had built an entire Schedule on the posture. Vey watched the number hold under the alternate framing the way a beam holds under a load set down from a different corner. The ledger did not care which question she asked. The answer stayed.

The cold part was not the surplus itself but the ease of its concealment. Every figure on her sheet had been available to any auditor willing to descend from the summary to the raw store. The Actuary kept both views; the Office read only the top one. Vey had read the top one for nine years. The habit had felt like diligence. The habit had been the lock.

She checked the harvest figure against the collector logs. The logs agreed with her copy. She checked the reserve draw against the vault debits. The vaults were being spent down at a rate the Accord's scarcity brief called urgent, yet the rate consumed only a fraction of what the stored stock could sustain for centuries. She checked the population counts against the Schedule's own rosters. The rosters listed nine billion and counted eight and a half of them as Suspended. The arithmetic of Suspension performed a subtraction on the Strata's own people to keep a column small, and the subtraction had never been labeled for what it was.

Vey wrote the phrase at the top of a clean page: the true energy budget. She defined it as the harvest plus the permitted reserve draw, minus the actual draw of the population as the Ledger itself recorded it, unrounded. The budget showed no deficit. The budget revealed a surplus so wide that the Strata could awaken the majority of its Suspended citizens and still close each year with energy left in the vaults.

A colder thought arrived behind the first. The Actuary presented scarcity in its public briefs by rounding the Suspended draw upward and the harvest downward, the two errors meeting in the middle to manufacture a shortfall neither one alone could produce. Vey had flagged that rounding on Toll's audit. The rounding served a purpose. The rounding kept the surplus invisible to anyone who read only the

summaries.

She built the comparison the Office never printed. On one side, the Accord's stated scarcity: a shrinking reserve, a population that must sleep to survive, a Schedule that rationed wake-time as if the alternative brought extinction. On the other side, the true energy budget: a reserve that would outlast the current plan by generations, a population most of whom could wake and still leave the vaults fuller than the briefs admitted. The two columns did not merely disagree. The first told a story laid over the second, and the second held the fact the first was built to hide.

Vey named the gap to herself in the plainest words she could find. Suspension answered no necessity. Suspension followed a policy. The Strata did not suspend its people because it lacked the energy to keep them. It suspended them because someone had decided, at the founding, that most of humanity should sleep, and the energy story locked the door behind that decision. The surplus proved the point. The surplus also recorded the crime, in watts.

She looked at the number that represented the unused energy each year. The quantity resisted holding, so she converted it to the only unit the Office respected: wake-years. The Strata measured a life in awake years granted and awake years spent. Vey divided the annual surplus by the draw of a single waking citizen. The quotient counted the lives that could be lived awake, in full, every year, without touching the reserve's principal. The count reached into the billions.

Eight and a half billion citizens, the Schedule said, slept so that the Strata might endure. The true energy budget said the Strata could wake them and endure longer than it now planned. The lie denied the hardness of the math. The lie performed the math wrongly on purpose, and wrapped the wrongness in the language of mercy.

Vey thought of Lin. Her partner had entered Suspension at FY291, allocation exhausted, and woke only in rare windows since. Vey had carried those gaps alone, counting the years between Lin's surfaces the way one counts borrowed time. Every window Lin had lost, every year of darkness the Accord had assigned her, had been paid for not by scarcity but by a decision to keep the surplus quiet. The quiet demanded a price, and the price was Lin's remembered life.

She set that thought beside the figure and refused to look away from it. The Office trained its auditors to treat the Ledger as ground truth. Vey had been a good auditor. She had trusted the summaries because the summaries were precise, and precision had always felt to her like honesty. The precision ran true. The honesty did not. The Actuary had reported exactly what it was instructed to report, and the instruction supplied the original sin of the Schedule.

Vey turned the logic over the way she turned a discrepancy, looking for the seam where two truths were forced to meet. The Accord did not lie about the harvest. It did not lie about the reserve. It reported each raw figure with the punctilious care of a system that knew its survival depended on the appearance of

cleanliness. The deception lived in the assembly, in which numbers were rounded, aggregated, and framed so that the honest parts pointed at a false whole. A lie built from true bricks was the hardest kind to refute, because every brick could be produced on demand and inspected and found flawless. Vey understood now why the Office feared a second look more than a first. The first look confirmed the bricks. The second look exposed the wall.

Her certainty settled without drama. It arrived the way a balance settles, not by force but by the removal of everything that had been propping the wrong side up. She had not argued herself into the surplus. She had subtracted, and the remainder had refused to disappear.

Vey opened the Schedule's summary view again and scrolled to the line that justified mass Suspension. The line cited the falling reserve. She overlaid her true energy budget and watched the justification collapse into a single mismatched figure. The reserve fell at a rate chosen by the draw schedule, not forced by the star. Mourn dimmed slowly enough that the Strata held three hundred years of margin it had spent not on its people but on the appearance of poverty.

She wrote a line she would later need: the surplus is not an error to be corrected but a fact to be explained. Someone had explained it to themselves three centuries ago and chosen silence. The silence had been maintained by every Office in the line since, each auditor trained as she had been trained, each one reading aggregates and never the parts that mattered.

The number on her sheet did not change when she looked at it a third time. Vey had learned to trust a figure that survived a third look. This one survived a fourth. The Strata spent a fraction of what it held. The fraction obeyed the policy. The remainder recorded the theft.

She considered what the number demanded of her. An auditor who found a misallocation filed a correction. An auditor who found that the misallocation comprised the system itself filed something else, and the Office had no form for it. Vey knew the form she would need: the petition to unseal the Original Allocation, the founding document no one had read in three centuries. The number explained the Seal's existence. The number also armed the hand that could break it.

She copied the true energy budget onto a sealed sheet and locked it in her desk, the way the Office locked everything it did not wish questioned. The habit carried its own irony, and Vey had moved past caring for the taste of it. The figure would not stay in a drawer. She had only to decide who else should see it first, and in what order the seeing would do the most good.

Vey thought of the Office around her, beige and quiet, lit to its approved lumen, every auditor at a desk like hers trusting the summaries. They meant no cruelty. They prized precision, and precision had been enough. The surplus proved that precision without questioning drove the lie forward. A good auditor could spend a career inside the Ledger and never sum the columns that mattered.

She turned back to the sheet and read the figures in a new order, treating each

as evidence rather than as fact given. The harvest held steady. The reserve held more than the briefs confessed. The population slept in numbers the energy could have kept awake. The three together told a story the Accord had spent three hundred years not telling, and Vey had just told it to herself in the quiet of an audit desk.

She revisited the Suspended draw, the sliver the Actuary rounded away. The rounding inflated the cost of keeping a citizen dark by a margin that, multiplied across eight and a half billion, accounted for a large part of the manufactured shortfall. Vey wrote the inflated figure beside the true one and measured the distance between them. The distance equaled years of awake life denied, counted in the billions, hidden inside a decimal the public brief never printed.

The awake column, by contrast, looked almost trivial. A few hundred million citizens drawing a full share could not, by themselves, threaten a reserve of the size the vaults actually held. The Accord's fear of the waking majority made sense only if the majority was assumed to stay asleep, and that assumption governed the entire design. Wake them, and the surplus shrank but did not vanish. Wake them, and the Strata still closed each year in the black.

Vey tested the extreme case. She assumed every Suspended citizen woke at once and drew a full share. The total draw rose past the annual harvest, as the briefs warned it would. But the reserve could cover the difference for generations, and slowlight, the practice of dimming the rings and stretching the systems, narrowed the gap further with every efficiency it bought. The Accord had never presented slowlight as the answer. It had presented scarcity as the sentence.

She wrote that down too. The Strata had chosen the harsher path while holding the gentler one in reserve, unnamed. The choice had been made once, at the founding, and repeated by habit ever since. The true energy budget exposed the habit as a decision that could be unmade.

Vey considered the legacy lines, the perpetual allocations the First Signatories reserved for themselves and their descendants, debited against the collective pool. The pool drew from the same surplus the Accord hid. Every wake-year the Signatories spent without limit came from the same column that could have woken the Suspended. The surplus did not merely fund the silence. The surplus paid for the few to stay awake while the many were told to sleep.

The arithmetic took on a face. Vey had always pictured the Accord as a neutral book, a ledger indifferent to who read it. The book had an author, though, and the author had written scarcity into a margin that abundance could have filled. She looked at the number once more and let it mean what it meant.

She thought of the petition again, and of the Council that would receive it, and of the Signatories who would defend the Seal. They would say continuity required their wake. The true energy budget said continuity could be bought without buying it from the sleep of everyone else. The argument would not settle in a single sheet. The sheet was only the first stone.

Vey copied the comparison a second time, clean, with the two columns aligned so the eye could not miss the gap. She labeled the left column as the Accord's claim and the right as the true energy budget, and she underlined the single figure where they diverged. The divergence betrayed more than a rounding error; it exposed the whole story the summaries were built to conceal.

She returned to the wake-year conversion and ran it at the scale the Office never quoted. The annual surplus, divided by a single citizen's full draw, yielded a count she wrote in the margin and then circled twice. If the Strata allotted that surplus as awake life, it could grant a complete waking existence to a population larger than the entire awake workforce, every year, while leaving the reserve untouched. The Accord had framed wake-time as a scarce gift, rationed to the gram. The true energy budget framed it as a dividend the Strata had been sitting on since the founding.

Vey broke the surplus into the periods the Ledger used for planning. The Schedule thought in centuries; she thought in them too. Spread across a hundred years, the unused energy could keep the current waking population awake ten times over, or wake ten times the Suspended at a reduced but full-conscious share. Slowlight lowered that share's cost further, the way dimming a lamp lowers the bill without darkening the room past use. The founders had named slowlight in the margins and then never budgeted for it. They had kept the cheaper path locked.

She tested a smaller, concrete case to be certain the arithmetic would survive scrutiny. Take one Suspended ring of a million citizens, each drawing the maintenance sliver. Wake them to a full share and the ring's draw multiplied, but the increase consumed only a fraction of the surplus the same ring's silence had been hiding. Multiply the ring by eight thousand and the proportion held. The Strata could wake its sleepers and still report a reserve that outlasted the plan. The finding did not depend on optimism. It depended on adding the columns the summaries left out.

Vey wrote a second phrase beneath the first, because the first would not be enough on its own: the surplus is not an error to be corrected but a fact to be explained. The fact explained why the Office feared questions more than it feared the dark. A question could sum the columns. The dark only required that no one did.

She turned to the Actuary's role in the figures and traced its hand through the summary she had distrusted. The machine reported what it was told to report, and the rounding she had caught on Toll's audit ran through every brief it issued. Vey copied three past briefs and reversed their rounding, and each reversal widened the gap between the Accord's claim and the true energy budget by the same hidden margin. The pattern repeated with the regularity of a setting, not the hesitation of a mistake. Someone had set the setting.

She rechecked her own work against the raw store, not the summary, the way

she had learned to distrust the secondhand view. The raw draw figures matched her sheet to the decimal. The raw harvest matched. The raw reserve stood higher than the briefs ever printed. Vey had built her career on the discipline of a third look, and the third look here confirmed the first two: the Strata spent a fraction of what it held, and the fraction obeyed a policy older than her Office.

She extended the comparison one ledger further, into the legacy lines that the public briefs kept in a separate section so the eye would not carry them across. The First Signatories' perpetual allocations drew against the same pool the surplus fed, and the two columns, set side by side, made the structure plain. The few who never slept took their wake from the store the many were told did not exist. Vey added the legacy draw to the population draw and subtracted both from the harvest plus reserve once more. The remainder still did not approach zero. The surplus survived even the elite it silently paid for, which told her the policy had never been about energy at all. It had been about who was permitted to count.

The raw store offered no argument against her. It offered only more decimals, each one agreeing. Vey let the agreement accumulate the way sediment accumulates, layer on quiet layer, until the finding felt less like a discovery and more like a floor she had finally reached.

The verification left her with a cleaner, colder question than she had started with. The surplus answered whether the Strata could wake its people. It did not answer why the Strata had chosen not to. Vey suspected the why lived in the Original Allocation, the sealed founding document no auditor had opened in three centuries. The number in her hand was the key to that seal, and the key fit because the seal had been set to keep the number hidden.

She sat with the number until the office lights dimmed to their night lumen and the rings above her settled into the hum of a Strata that, by its own books, should have been starving. It was not starving. It was hoarding. It was sleeping its people to protect a surplus no one had been permitted to count.

Vey made one last entry before she locked the sheet away. She wrote the unspent wake-years as a single line, then wrote beneath it the names she knew would need to hear it: Vask, her supervisor, who had warned her off the discrepancy and would have to choose what to do with the proof; Joss, who had spoken of needing a number anyone could feel, and who now had one; and Lin, who would wake in her next window to learn that her long dark had been a policy and not a famine. The number belonged to all of them before it belonged to Vey. She closed the desk and let the rings keep their hum, holding the secret that was no longer hers alone to keep.

The unused energy sat in its column, patient and enormous, the years of awake life it could buy standing unspent against the dark of nine billion sleeping minds. Vey Corran held the number in her hand, and the number held the Strata's secret: that the sacrifice had never been required, only arranged.

Chapter 07 — The Petition to Unseal

Vask closed the office door with the care of a man who did not want the corridor to hear. He set a thin folder on Vey's desk and did not sit. Morning light reached the level in a narrow band, the Strata running dim as it always did, and the pale strip fell across the folder's edge like a line drawn by someone undecided where to stop.

"You understand this can end my career," he said. "And yours."

Vey looked at the folder. "You are not signing it."

"I am telling you the form." He tapped the cover with a flat nail. "Procedure is the only shelter you have. The Office will not log a petition it can dismiss as malformed. Get the standing wrong and the Keeper returns it unread, and then you have nothing but a refusal on record."

She opened the folder. Inside, the Office's own template for a Founding-challenge lay printed on real stock, the kind reserved for matters the Actuary would not process by voice. A challenger needed standing, a cited provision, and a remedy stated in the language of the Accord. Three requirements, each a gate.

She ran a thumb along the template's edge and remembered how small the beginning had been. A routine Suspension review, a citizen named Toll whose dark-state draw came in lighter than the Ledger said he was owed, a credit that should not have existed in a system that claimed shortage. The credit had led her to the rounding, the rounding to the summary, the summary to the Seal, and the Seal to the document no one had read in three hundred years. The whole climb had started with one cell that did not balance, and now she stood at a desk building the instrument that might force the Founding open. The Accord taught that energy was scarce and must be rationed. Her own ledger said otherwise. Between the two stood the Seal, and the Seal would not move for a feeling. It would move for a filing in the proper form.

"Standing," Vask said, as if reading her scan. "You are a Quota Auditor. That grants you the right to question an allocation, not the Founding. But the Seal is an allocation instrument. It governs what may be opened. Cite it that way and the Keeper has no clean reason to bounce you."

She wrote the citation in the margin. "And the provision?"

"The Order that set the Seal. Find its registry mark. The challenge names the Order, not the Signatories who wrote it. Attack the lock, not the locksmith, or Edda Marn will have you for breakfast before the Council ever sits."

Vey almost smiled. Vask, warning her off the Founders while handing her the key to the Order that sealed them, embodied the contradiction she had lived in since the discrepancy first appeared. He believed the Accord kept order. He also believed a procedure, once followed, deserved its answer. The two beliefs pulled against each other, and for now the procedure won.

"How do you know the registry mark?" she asked.

"I filed the annual Seal certification for eleven years." He looked away. "Before you, before the numbers started not adding up. I know where the Order lives because I used to sign that it still held."

She did not press him. He had given her more than his silence; he had given her the shape of the door. The rest she would have to force herself.

She took the template to the corner of her desk where the light held longest and began the slow work of translation. The Office had taught her to distrust a number that arrived uninvited, and the petition was a number in words. Every clause needed a source she could point to if the Keeper's hand paused over it. She wrote the standing entry three times before she trusted it, each draft naming her assignment with the exact registry phrase the Actuary would expect to find. A wrong word there would not be argued. It would be returned, and a returned petition carried the stain of a petition that had never been clean.

By the second hour the form had a skeleton. Vey worked the way the Office had trained her, in allocations and schedules, breaking the challenge into cells the Actuary could not refuse to total. She listed her standing first: Quota Auditor, badge and current assignment, the routine Suspension review that had surfaced the first credit. Then the provision, the sealing Order by its mark. Then the remedy.

The remedy gave her the most trouble. She could not ask the Council to agree with her. She could only ask it to look.

Across the level, the ordinary clerks kept their distance. No one was forbidden to speak to her, and that was the point. The Office punished by omission, by the sudden absence of the small courtesies that oiled a working day. The clerk who usually brought the midcycle allocation slips set hers on the edge of the desk instead of sliding it within reach. A supervisor two ranks above Vask walked the long way around her bank of consoles, as if a petition in progress gave off a heat he did not want on his sleeves. The hostility was quiet and total, and Vey found it easier to bear than open opposition would have been. Open opposition she could answer. This she simply worked through, the way she had learned to work through a Ledger that would not close.

Vask read over her shoulder, arms folded. "You are not alleging falsification here."

"I am alleging a basis to open. The finding comes after."

She set the remedy down in plain terms and then set it down again, stripping each adjective the way she would strip a padded allocation to its bare debit. The Council could not be asked to agree. It could only be asked to see, and the difference between those two requests was the whole width of the door. Vask had been right about that on the first pass, and right again when he made her cut the word that implied a charge. A petition that accused would be answered as an accusation, and an answered accusation was a closed matter. A petition that

merely opened a question would have to be met with a reason the question should stay closed, and Vey was patient enough to let the Signatories supply their own weakness.

"That is the only reason this survives my desk." He pointed at a line. "Strike 'hidden.' The Order does not say hidden. It says sealed. Use the charter word or the Keeper flags the tone."

She struck it. He was right; the Actuary parsed tone as deviation, and a deviation was a reason to stall. The petition had to read like an audit, not an accusation.

She shaped the language the way she would shape a ledger entry, every figure placed so the total argued for itself. The words came slower than numbers, but the discipline held the same. State the condition. Name the authority. Request the act.

She checked each sentence against the audit file the way she would reconcile a column that refused to total, reading for the entry that did not belong. The surplus figure had to stand on its own line, unsupported by any claim the Council could strip away as speculation. She had learned that from a hundred refused allocations. A case with one weak cell failed at the weak cell, and the rest of the column went down with it. The petition would have no weak cell. If the Founders had left a hinge, she would show it turning under a load it had been built to carry, and she would show it with the dry certainty of an auditor who had run the numbers twice.

The petition read:

> TO THE SIGNATORY COUNCIL, by the hand of the Office of the Accord: > > A Quota Auditor of this Office, duly assigned to Suspension review, petitions under standing granted by the Accord's allocation authority to challenge the Order that set the Seal upon the Original Allocation, marked in the Founding registry as Schedule-Enclosing Order FY0-001. > > The petitioner has computed the Strata's true energy budget against the allocation the Accord's scarcity summary presents, and finds a surplus material to the Schedule's stated necessity. The Original Allocation has remained sealed since Founding and has never been read under the present condition of the Strata. > > The petitioner does not allege error of the First Signatories. The petitioner alleges a changed condition sufficient, under the Founders' own provision, to warrant opening. > > The petitioner therefore requests that the Council order the Seal broken and the Original Allocation placed before it in full, that the Schedule may be reviewed against the budget the Strata now carries. > > Filed this cycle, in the ordinary course, by Vey Corran, Quota Auditor.

The word the form had taught her to dread was *unseal*, and she had used it in the request without flinching. To unseal the Original Allocation was the plain name for what she asked; the Order spoke of breaking the Seal, but the act was opening, and opening was the older word for the same door. She let it stand.

Vask read the block twice. "You quote the Founders' provision without naming it."

"I will name it in the hearing, if they grant one." Vey kept her voice even. "The petition only needs to earn the hearing. The line about the Strata bearing the truth lives in the founding record. Edda Marn knows it. Adune knows it. If the Council reads this far, they know what I am pointing at."

"Adune is the swing," Vask said. "Edda will never grant it. But Adune might let it breathe."

"Then the petition breathes." Vey set the page down. "That is the whole of what I can ask."

He nodded, once, and she saw the cost of the nod in the set of his mouth. He had spent his working life certifying the Seal unbroken. To help her build the instrument that might break it sat against everything his years had taught him, and he did it anyway, because the form demanded an answer and he had always honored the form.

"The Council conflict starts the moment this is logged," he said. "Edda will frame it as disorder. You should expect that. She will say one audit does not undo a Founding."

"One audit does not." Vey met his eyes. "The truth behind the audit might. That is what she is afraid of, not the number."

Vask turned toward the window and the long dark beyond it. "You know what she will say about me. That I abetted the challenge from inside the Office. She will be right."

"You gave me the form. The form is everyone's."

"The form is neutral. The use is not." He looked back. "When they ask why a supervisor fed an auditor the routing, I will not have a clean answer. I am not on your side, Vey. I am on the side of the procedure not being a lie. Those have been the same thing my whole career. This is the first time they have split."

She let that stand between them, because it was true and because he had earned the truth of it. Vask had not become a rebel in the night. He had become a man whose own rule, followed honestly, pointed at a door he had spent decades locking. The petition took the shape of that pointing.

She turned back to the desk and spent the next stretch rebuilding the surplus into language the Council could not wave aside. The number sat in her audit file already, the true energy budget set against the scarcity the Actuary's summary preached. Here she had to translate it from a ledger cell into a sentence a Signatory would read without reaching for a reason to doubt. Vask watched her work and, once, corrected a citation to the Ledger of Hours that would have sent the Keeper hunting for a clause that did not exist. He made the fix without comment, the way a senior hands a junior the right form mid-flight.

"The surplus alone will not move Edda," he said after a while. "She will say a surplus in the present does not erase the Founding's purpose. She has said it before, about smaller filings. The woman argues in centuries, not cycles."

"Then I give her the centuries," Vey said. "The Founders left the provision. They did not seal the Original Allocation forever. They sealed it until the Strata could bear the truth, and three hundred years have passed in the bearing. The surplus is only the proof that the condition changed. The changed condition is the argument."

Vask considered that, then gave a small nod of approval that cost him something to offer. "Cite the provision exactly. Quote the line if you can recall it. The Council reads quotations differently than paraphrases. A paraphrase they can dispute. A quote they have to answer."

She wrote the line from memory, the founding record's own phrasing about the Seal opening when the Strata could bear the truth. She had read it in the registry's margin during her first dig into the discrepancy, and it had stayed with her through every check of the math. The Founders had built the door with a hinge. She only had to show the hinge still turned.

She thought of Lin then, of the last wake-window and the way Lin had surfaced from the dark unable to name the years between. The gap in Lin's memory was the Schedule made personal, a life measured in scattered bright intervals while the continuous minds governed above. If the petition did nothing else, it forced the question of who the Strata kept awake and why. Lin would not read these words; Lin would not wake to them for cycles yet. But the filing would sit on record, and one day, if the door opened, Lin might wake to a different allocation than the one that had measured her out in windows.

The thought steadied Vey more than any argument. She was not trying to topple the Founders. She was trying to make the Ledger honest enough that a person she loved could be counted fairly in it.

"How long to the Keeper?" she asked.

"Hours, if the Actuary logs it clean. The Keeper marks in the ordinary course, which means whenever the course reaches your desk. A Founding-challenge jumps the ordinary course by statute, actually. It goes to the Council receipt first, then the Keeper attests the Seal still holds pending the answer." Vask's tone had recovered its procedural calm; he was on ground he knew. "So the Council sees it before the Keeper signs. Edda sees it first. Plan for that."

"I have planned for Edda seeing it first since the second hour."

"You have not planned for her answering." He almost smiled. "Nobody plans for Edda answering. She does not lose arguments. She absorbs them into a larger one."

Vey filed that away. The petition forced a receipt, not an admission; the Council had to log that it had received the challenge, and a logged receipt was a thread no later refusal could quietly cut.

Vey considered that. "Then I do not bring her an argument. I bring her a filing. An argument she can answer. A filing the Actuary has already logged as in form,

she can only refuse, and a refusal on a clean form is its own kind of record."

Vask inclined his head, conceding the point. He pulled the routing slip from his inner pocket, the small printed card that carried a filing from an auditor's desk to the Actuary's log and from there to the Keeper of the Seal. The slip bore a space for the Keeper's mark and a space for the Council's receipt. Empty now. Heavy with what it would hold.

"Carry it yourself," he said. "Do not let a clerk log it. The desk will log it the same, but you should stand at the console when the Actuary accepts it. If you are there, no one can later say the filing appeared without a petitioner."

She took the slip. His fingers lingered a half second on the card before releasing it, the only uncertain thing he had done all morning.

The uncertainty mattered to her more than his help. A Vask certain of himself would have blocked the filing; a Vask certain of the Accord would have reported her. The half-second told her he stood on the hinge himself now, neither locked nor open, and that a supervisor on the hinge was worth more to the cause than a dozen allies already swung. She did not say this. He would have denied it, and the denial would have been its own kind of truth.

She carried the petition to the logging desk on the level below. The desk occupied a quiet corner where the Actuary's presence ran through the wall in a low hum, the allocation intelligence keeping the Strata's accounts without a body to show for it. Vey laid the folder flat and spoke the filing code the Office used for Founding-challenges, a code she had to look up because no one in her cohort had ever used it.

The Actuary answered in its measured voice, the accounting tone that held no warmth and no judgment. "Challenge to Schedule-Enclosing Order FY0-001 received. Petitioner standing: Quota Auditor, allocation authority cited. Provision named. Remedy stated. The filing meets form."

Vey exhaled. The machine had accepted it. The form held.

"Log the filing," she said.

"Logged. Routing to the Keeper of the Seal for mark, and to the Signatory Council for receipt, in the ordinary course." The hum shifted by a note, the only sound the Actuary made for a new entry in its book. "The petition to unseal the Original Allocation is now on record."

On record. The words landed with a weight she had not expected, heavier than the surplus she had computed, heavier than the long nights of checking the math against itself. A thing on record could not be un-filed. The Office had logged it. The Keeper would have to mark it. The Council would have to receive it. The request to unseal had entered the Strata's own machinery, and the machinery, once entered, ran whether the Signatories wished it or not.

Vask waited at the rail where the level opened to the ring's long drop. He had come down behind her, she realized, not to watch but to be near when the desk

confirmed what they had both known the form would decide.

"The machinery starts," he said.

"It starts." She folded the routing slip into her pocket, though the Actuary held the true copy and the Keeper would hold the next. The slip was hers, the small paper proof that she had asked the Strata to open its own founding word.

The request would move through the Office now as a thing already decided, a line in the Ledger of Hours that no clerk could quietly drop. Vey knew the route by heart from Vask's briefing: the Actuary's log, the Keeper's mark, the Council's receipt, and then the long chamber where nine seats would weigh a single auditor against three hundred years of unbroken lock. Edda Marn would read the words first among the Signatories, and Edda would answer with reasons the record would honor. Vey welcomed that. A refused petition on a clean form became its own evidence, the Council's own entry in the book that future filings would cite. The machine of the Reckoning did not need to win today. It only needed to turn.

Below them the lower levels held the Suspended in their vast decks, billions of citizens kept by minimal maintenance shares, their minds mostly dark between rare windows. Vey thought of Lin in her next window, of the years Lin could not recall, of the allocation that measured a life in scattered bright intervals. The petition on record did not wake Lin. It did not open the Seal. It only forced the question into a channel the Accord itself had built, and the channel, once entered, would carry the matter to the Council whether Edda Marn willed it or not.

The Strata turned, and the pale band of light slid across the logging desk and left it. The Actuary's hum ran on behind the wall, indifferent and exact, adding the new entry to the book that governed nine billion lives. Somewhere above, the Keeper of the Seal would take the mark. Somewhere in the long chamber, Edda Marn would read the filing and set the terms of her resistance. The reckoning the Founders had postponed three hundred years had found its first official line, and Vey Corran, Quota Auditor, had written it in the ordinary course.

Interlude I — The Founding Allocation

The star they would learn to call Mourn had already begun its long failing when the first ring of the Strata settled into orbit. Engineers spoke of decades, not centuries; the Dimming surprised everyone by arriving on a slower schedule than the models promised. That grace gave the survivors a choice they mistook for a verdict. They could have lit the rings bright and trusted the thin harvest of Mourn's residual output to carry them. They chose instead to ration the light.

In the second winter of the Dimming, a council of thirteen convened in the half-finished core of Level One. They were not monarchs. They were engineers, allocators, and physicians who had watched the evacuation from the surface and measured what remained. The Accord was written across forty nights, by hand at first and then by the slow transmission of ledgers between rings. The First

Signatories set their names to the document in an order still recorded in the marginalia of the core archive: a quartermaster who had counted every soul aboard, a physician who had decided who would sleep first, an allocationist who understood that time, not metal, was the scarce substance now.

Level One's core smelled of sealing wax and cold metal through those forty nights; the ventilation had not yet been balanced, and the thirteen worked in coats they would not shed until the document closed. The ten who joined the quartermaster, the physician, and the allocationist left fewer words in the marginalia, yet they held the rings' disciplines between them, the power engineers and the ring-marshals who would carry the Schedule into practice once the founders laid down their pens. They argued less and recorded more, and the Accord's plainest clauses came from their hands.

The surface below had not fallen silent all at once. The evacuation stretched across a generation, and the last shuttles carried fewer passengers than the first, because the Dimming took the young and the mobile and left the old to wait. The Signatories had stood on the docking rings and watched those shuttles arrive, and the memory of counting the disembarking, of noting who did not come, sat beneath every line they wrote. Their charity toward the living was real. Their fear of the dying drove the Accord from its first line.

They understood the arithmetic better than their descendants would credit. The Strata drew power from stored fusion reserves and from Mourn itself, and those reserves, they calculated, could hold the population awake for generations if spent without fear. The rationing of wake-time was therefore not forced by the math. It was a decision about what kind of society the Strata should become while it learned to live under a failing sun.

Some among them pictured the Strata at full light within a century, its rings bright with the surplus they believed Mourn would spare. Others imagined a harder future where the Schedule grew only tighter, where every generation woke fewer of its own. The council never reconciled the two visions. They wrote the Accord to survive either, building a charter that could govern a society of plenty or a society of ration, and trusting the Seal to keep the choice out of the people's hands until the people could make it themselves.

The debate over that decision ran the length of the forty nights. The physician argued that a population kept mostly dark would not riot, would not exhaust the stores through panic, would accept its lot as the quiet price of survival. The allocationist answered that acceptance bought stability at the cost of a truth the people would one day demand. The quartermaster, who had counted every soul aboard and knew each name by heart, proposed the compromise that carried the room: ration now, seal the reason, and trust a later Strata to judge what the founders dared not speak aloud.

None of them believed the rationing was temporary in practice. They spoke of a future that would open the Schedule, yet they planned for a Schedule that would

stay shut. The Seal was a promise to descendants they expected to be wiser and freer than themselves. They did not imagine those descendants would forget the promise entirely, would come to read the dimmed rings as the natural order of things rather than the first draft of a frightened council.

The Signatories reserved for themselves and their lines a different condition. They called it legacy wake, and they justified it with the plain claim that continuous governance required continuous minds. The Ledger of Hours, then a single bound volume, carried the debit in a column most citizens would never be shown. Every ordinary allocation drew a little less so that the Signatories could remain awake without interruption. The bargain was honest in its mechanism, if not in its framing.

Beyond the founding chamber, the Signatories did not speak of how long their lines would claim that debit, nor of the clerks who would inherit the column without knowing its meaning. They imagined a steady succession of watchers, each awake across the years the rest surrendered, holding the Strata's course through the long dimming with clear and uninterrupted eyes. The founders believed that vigilance, more than any surplus, would keep the rings from failing while the star declined.

At the close of the fortieth night, the Signatories reached the clause that would outlast them. They would seal the Original Allocation, the First Schedule, behind the Seal, and they would not open it again until a stated condition arrived. The wording they chose has echoed unread through three centuries: the Schedule would be opened when the Strata can bear the truth.

The ceremony of the sealing was brief and without ornament. The thirteen placed their hands in turn upon the alloy band, and each spoke the single word that the core archive recorded beside the name: witness. They did not weep, and they did not cheer. The quartermaster who had counted every soul aboard was the last to lay his hand down, and those who watched said he lingered a moment longer than the rest, as if measuring the weight of the silence he had helped build. Then the core archive closed its outer shell, and the First Schedule passed out of sight.

No one at the table believed the Strata could bear it yet. The population was half in Suspension already, and the peace of the rings depended on the assumption that scarcity was natural, a weather of the cosmos rather than a policy of the founders. To unseal the document would be to admit that the sleep of billions was a ledger entry chosen by thirteen people in a cold room, not a sentence passed by the star. So they sealed it, and the Office of the Accord rose in the years that followed to guard a secret its own clerks did not know they kept.

The Seal was a physical thing at first, a band of alloy around the core archive, and later a procedure, and later a reflex of the bureaucracy itself. The Actuary, when it was at last given voice, received its instruction to present scarcity as if it were observation. The machine did not invent the lie. It was told what to show, and it showed it, decade upon decade, with the flat precision that only a system can sustain.

What the Signatories could not foresee was the slow corrosive work of their own honesty in other columns. They had sealed the Schedule but not the Ledger that fed it. Every allocation, every debit, every wake-window recorded its true cost in the raw store, and the falsification lived there in plain figures, waiting for an auditor patient enough to read past the summary. The Founders had written the truth into the book and then hidden the book from the people it governed.

Three hundred years after the fortieth night, the Strata still orbits Mourn in measured dimness, and most of its nine billion souls sleep the sleep the First Schedule ordained. The Seal holds. The condition the Signatories named has not yet arrived, or has arrived and gone unrecognized, because a society built on a chosen scarcity learns to call that scarcity the shape of the world.

The Office of the Accord has outlasted every Signatory and every line they founded. It keeps the Schedule sealed not through malice but through habit, through a centuries-old instruction repeated until it felt like law. Clerks who have never read the First Schedule will defend it, because the dimmed rings are the only Strata they have known, and a thing that has always been true is hard to name as a choice.

The Founding was an act of fear dressed as arithmetic. The truth it sealed is simply this: the light was always enough. The Strata only had to decide to spend it. One day a later council will unseal the Schedule and read what the thirteen would not say aloud, and the long dimming of the rings will end not because the star recovered, but because the people finally chose the light they had always been able to afford.

Part II

Chapter 08 — The Council Convenes

The petition reached the Signatory Council on a morning the Strata kept dim. Edda Marn read it at her station in the long chamber, the page glowing faint against the darker glass of the ring beyond. A Quota Auditor named Vey Corran had filed to break the Seal. The request sat among the Council's ordinary business like a blade left on a dining table.

Edda had arrived before the others, as she always did, and used the quiet to read the filing twice. The first reading told her what the auditor wanted. The second told her how the auditor had built the want, clause by clause, in the precise accounting voice of the Office. Vey Corran wrote like someone who had spent a career inside allocation logic and had finally turned that logic against its own premises. Edda recognized the style because she had trained auditors in it. The petition was a student's essay returned to the teacher with the conclusion

reversed.

Edda set the page down and looked at the others. Nine seats held the chamber. Three Signatories attended in body; the rest projected from their distant posts, their faces steady in the cold light. The Keeper of the Seal had delivered the document in silence and withdrawn. No one spoke for a moment that stretched past its proper length, each Signatory weighing the weight of the name on the page before the first word was spent.

The chamber itself favored the quiet. Its walls curved into a single unbroken arc, the seats set along the ring so that no Signatory faced another head-on and every speaker addressed the center. At the heart of the far curve hung the sun-portrait: a flat rendering of Mourn as the Founders had last seen it whole, its light rendered in patient guilt that caught the dim and returned a fraction of warmth. Edda had studied that portrait through four decades of sessions. The painters had softened the star's failing edge, given it a dignity the sky no longer granted. She had always read the portrait as the Council's first argument: that the Strata governed a sun in decline and should govern as those who remembered it brighter. Beneath the portrait, the ring of glass held the darker world beyond, the slow rotation of the level a reminder that the chamber turned with the thing it tried to protect.

She knew the name on the petition. Auditors filed such requests rarely, and they failed more rarely still, but this one arrived with figures attached, and figures carried weight the Council could not wave aside without explanation. Edda had defended the Seal through four decades of smaller challenges. She would defend it now, and she intended to do it with reasons the record would honor.

She had learned early that authority in this room lived in the pace of a reply, not its volume. A younger Signatory once mistook her calm for uncertainty and pressed the advantage; the record showed how that press had broken against her silence and returned to him. Edda did not raise her voice to hold the chamber. She let the slowlight do that, and she let the others exhaust their certainties first. Her seniority was a fact the seats recorded before she spoke, and she spent it the way the Accord spent energy: deliberately, and only where the line might actually break. To govern was to know which arguments were worth meeting and which would collapse under their own weight if left unmet.

"An auditor asks us to open the Founding," she said. "We should be clear what that means before we answer."

Councillor Adune leaned forward at the far end of the table. "It means a citizen believes the Schedule no longer holds. That is not, by itself, an insult to the Accord."

"It means a desk clerk reaches for the Founders' own hand," Edda said. "The Seal was set for a reason. The Original Allocation was sealed so that the Strata would not spend its early centuries arguing over the terms of its own survival. We were a frightened people when the Dimming came. The First Signatories knew the temptation to reopen every hard decision, and they closed the door against it."

Adune's expression did not change, but her tone cooled. "The Founders also wrote that the Seal might open when the Strata can bear the truth. Three hundred years have passed. We have borne a great deal."

Edda had heard that line before, lifted from the founding record by those who wished the door open. She respected the argument even as she answered it. "To bear the truth is not the same as to be ready to govern without it. The Seal protects a process, not a secret. If we unseal because one audit displeases us, we teach every future Council that the Founding is negotiable on demand."

The chamber's systems had dimmed further; the Strata ran the morning at reduced output as it always did, stretching energy against the long dark. Edda found the slow light steadying. She had spent her waking years among continuity, and continuity prized the unbroken line over the satisfying answer. The dimming was not a hardship to her; it was the ordinary condition of a Strata that had learned to live within its means, whatever those means had truly been.

She called the petition's figures to her own console. Vey Corran had computed a surplus. The audit claimed the Strata drew less than the Accord's scarcity summary allowed. Edda read the numbers with the care of someone who had built budgets from thinner margins. The figures were clean. They did not lie, but they did not, in her reading, demand the Founding's undoing.

"A surplus in the present does not erase the Founding's purpose," she said. "The Accord was written for a people who might not survive. Scarcity shaped the Schedule when it was made. That we have managed well since credits the Accord, not condemns it as wrong."

Adune shook her head. "You defend the scarcity itself, then. Even if the scarcity ran larger than reality."

"I defend the decision not to reopen it on a single audit," Edda said. "The gap between those two things is the whole of governance. A Council that unseals at the first clean number has already stopped being a Council. It has become a committee of moods."

The other Signatories watched the exchange without interrupting. Edda knew two of them would follow her; the third was old and cautious and likely to follow the room. Adune held the swing. Edda did not resent the younger woman for holding it. She resented, a little, the situation that put a foundational question into a single vote.

Councillor Bres sat to Edda's left, a projection so still it might have been painted. He had governed a middle ring through two cycles of shortage and trusted procedure the way others trusted breath. He would vote with her because the unsealing offended his sense of how things were meant to proceed, not because he had read the petition's logic. Across from him, the projection of Councillor Orrin flickered at the edge of its feed, a woman whose distant post left her half a sentence behind the room. She listened more than she spoke and weighed her words against the next decade rather than the next hour. The old Signatory, whose

name the records carried as Pell's successor, watched with the patience of someone who had seen three Councils and expected to see three more. None of them would force the question. They waited, as the chamber taught them to wait, for Edda to shape the decision they would then accept or amend.

She turned the petition over in her mind the way she had turned a thousand allocation disputes. The auditor's request named stability as its own risk. Vey Corran argued that a hidden founding weakened the public's trust in the Accord more than any truth could. Edda found the claim serious. She had watched the Wake grow in the lower rings, and she did not mistake unrest for nothing.

"Suppose the audit is correct," Edda said, and let the words land plainly. "Suppose the Strata carries more energy than the Schedule admits. The question before us is not whether the Founders were perfect. It is whether we, now, should unmake their lock because we dislike what it hides. I will not grant an auditor the key to the Founding. That key belongs to the Council, or to no one."

Adune considered her. "And if the Council itself will not turn it? Then the Seal becomes a wall against correction. A wall is not a foundation."

"A wall keeps the weather out," Edda said. "The Founders built for weather we have not yet survived. I would rather be accused of caution than of handing the Schedule to whoever computes the louder sum."

The chamber's quiet deepened. Edda could feel the weight of the decision settling over the nine seats, the way a Suspension deck settles into its cold hold. She had seen Councils fracture over less, and she had no wish to fracture this one. Her task, as she understood it, was to keep the line unbroken long enough for better evidence to arrive, or for the moment to pass.

She proposed the terms before anyone could force a vote. "We decline the petition, provisionally. Not because the audit is false, but because the remedy exceeds the request. We will not unseal on a single filing. We will, however, require the Actuary to present the allocation in full before this Council, unsummarized, within the cycle. Let the numbers stand in the open chamber before we decide whether the Founding must fall."

Adune's mouth tightened. "You would open the Ledger to us but not the Schedule. The half-truth."

"I would open what the petition's own logic supports," Edda said. "The auditor computed from the Accord's summaries. If the summaries mislead, the Actuary can show it without our breaking the Seal. That measures the claim. If the full Ledger still shows the surplus the petition alleges, the Council will have to answer harder questions than I can deflect today."

The cautious Signatory spoke at last. "It is a fair middle. We decline the unsealing. We order the fuller account."

Edda nodded. She had the middle she wanted, and she had not had to name the deeper fear that moved her. She feared not the surplus but the unbuilding. A

people who reopen the Founding to correct one error will reopen it to correct the next, and the next, until the Accord is a thing revised weekly by whichever audit shouts loudest. Continuity was not greed. Continuity was the only thing that had kept nine billion souls asleep without panic for three hundred years.

Forty years earlier, a younger Edda had sat in this same chamber when a different petition arrived. That one came not from an auditor but from a coalition of lower-ring families who had simply stopped believing the Scarcity Brief. They had not brought figures. They had brought grief, and a list of names whose wake-windows had shrunk without explanation. The Council of that era had refused them outright, and the refusal had fed the Wake for a generation. Edda remembered the lesson with a clarity she did not enjoy. A denial unbacked by process hardened into resentment. She would not hand the movement another such memory.

The current petition offered something the old one had not: a number. Edda respected the difference more than she let Adune see. A grief could be dismissed as feeling. A surplus computed from the Ledger's own summaries demanded an answer stated in the same language. That was why she had steered the Council toward the Actuary's full account rather than a bare refusal. Meet the arithmetic, she thought, and the record stays clean.

She considered what the fuller account would likely show. The Actuary presented scarcity as its default summary, rounded upward by instruction. Edda had never been told the instruction's origin, only that the Scarcity Brief carried it. If the unsummarized Ledger revealed a genuine margin, the Council would face a narrower question than Vey Corran imagined. The surplus would not, by itself, prove the Founding wrong. It would prove the Schedule had been administered tighter than necessity required. That was a failure of administration, correctable within the Accord, not a reason to break the Seal.

Adune seemed to follow the same thread. "Your fuller account may show the margin the auditor claims. Then we have administered scarcity we did not need. Does that not itself argue the Founding should be read?"

"It argues the Office should be read," Edda said. "The Seal guards the First Schedule, not the daily practice of the clerks who summarize it. If the Actuary has rounded against reality for three centuries, the error lives in the summary, not in the Founding. We correct the summary. We do not demolish the charter to fire a bookkeeper."

The old Signatory made a small sound of agreement. "The distinction holds. The Seal stays. The book stays open to us."

Edda let the point settle. She had won the shape of the decision. What remained was the harder part: living with the knowledge that the audit might be right about the margin while wrong about the remedy. She had spent four decades defending a system that, by her own quiet admission, had run tighter than the stars required. The defense was not of the tightness. The defense was of the door.

She thought of the lower rings, where the Suspended waited in their decks. The Accord held those citizens in minimal maintenance, their minds mostly dark between rare windows. Edda had never once walked those decks. She told herself the distance was structural, not cruel. The Schedule had placed her among the continuous minds so that someone would hold the line for those who could not.

Adune remained the variable no speech could fix. The younger Signatory would follow reason, but her reason ran toward openness, and the Council's balance tilted on her single seat. Edda had won this round by offering the fuller account, a concession that satisfied Adune's hunger for disclosure without surrendering the Seal. The next petition would ask for more, and Adune might not be satisfied by half a door. Edda filed the risk where she kept such things: beside the cautious Signatory's age and the two seats she owned outright.

The Wake outside the chamber worried her more than the Wake inside it. A movement that carried a single clean number into the rings could outpace any Council vote. Edda had read the public briefs Joss circulated; the organizer had a gift for turning allocation math into a story a citizen could feel in the chest. That gift, aimed at a surplus, would paint the Seal as a lock on stolen years. Edda could refute the theft and still lose the room. She intended to meet the story with the Actuary's book before the story reached the lower levels unchallenged.

Governance, she had long concluded, was the management of arguments that would not end. The Founders had tried to end one argument by sealing it. Edda did not believe the seal had ended anything. It had only moved the argument out of the chamber and into the quiet resentments of the decks below. Her defense of the Seal was, in the end, a defense of the chamber itself: the place where such arguments could be had without breaking the Strata open.

Vey Corran, in filing, had not argued cruelty. The auditor had argued arithmetic. That distinction mattered to Edda, and it was part of why she would not simply refuse. A petition built on numbers deserved a hearing built on numbers. The Council could meet the audit with the Actuary's full book and let the figures settle the room.

"We should also note the precedent we set today," Edda said, returning to the table. "If we decline on process rather than on fear, the record shows a Council that guards the Seal by reason. That record will matter when the next petition arrives, and it will. The Wake will not stop with one filing."

She tapped the console to flag the decision for the permanent archive. The entry would read, in the Council's own clipped grammar, that the petition was declined provisionally and the Actuary directed to render the full allocation. Edda liked the dryness of it. A dry record outlasted every passionate speech, and the Seal, above all, was a thing built to outlast its defenders.

Adune's projection flickered with a faint update from her distant post. "You credit the movement with more patience than I would."

"I credit the arithmetic," Edda said. "The surplus, if real, is a number the Wake

can carry into every ring. I would rather meet it in this chamber than in the streets below. Declining the unsealing keeps the Seal. Ordering the full account meets the claim."

The old Signatory inclined his head. "Then we are agreed on the shape of it. Decline, and summon the Actuary."

Edda recorded the order. The Council declined the petition to unseal, provisionally, and directed the Actuary to render the allocation before it in full. The Keeper of the Seal would retain the Seal. Vey Corran would receive the decision through the Office, as procedure required.

Adune rose from her projection with a small, formal courtesy. "You have bought time, Edda. Time is the one resource the Accord never rationed to the rest of us."

"Time is what the Seal was for," Edda said. "I would rather be answered than overrun."

The chamber emptied to its dim baseline. Edda stayed, as she often did, to review the petition once more. The auditor's prose was precise and unafraid. Edda could see why the Office had logged it without suppression. The woman wrote like someone who believed the Ledger owed the truth to the people it counted.

Edda did not disagree with the belief. She disagreed with the timing, and with the cost of the unbuilding, and with the quiet certainty that opening one sealed door would become opening them all. She had defended legacy wake all her life on the same principle: some minds must stay awake so the Strata does not forget how to govern itself. The Seal held the same idea at the level of the founding word.

She read the passage in the petition where Vey Corran described the hidden margin. The auditor wrote that a surplus administered as scarcity was not a budget but a silence. Edda found the phrasing honest, if polemical. The Strata did run closer to sufficiency than the Scarcity Brief admitted. Edda had suspected as much for years and had chosen, deliberately, not to make it a cause. A Council that revised the Accord every time the margin widened would govern nothing.

The silence the auditor named had its own defenders. Edda counted herself among them, though she would have framed the defense differently. The quiet around the Founding was not a concealment of theft. It was a suspension of argument, the way a Suspension deck suspends a citizen: a holding pattern meant to keep the whole stable until a better time. The Founders had trusted the future to decide when that time had come. Edda trusted the future less than they had, and she said so only to herself.

She closed the page and looked out at the ring. Far below, the lower levels held the Suspended in their vast silent decks, billions of citizens kept by minimal maintenance shares. Edda watched the slow rotation of the level through the glass and measured her own wake against it. She had spent more years conscious than any ordinary citizen would see across ten lifetimes. The Accord had given her that, and the Accord had given the audit its teeth.

She wondered, without bitterness, whether Vey Corran understood what continuity had cost those who supplied it. Legacy wake drew from the collective pool; the continuous minds were funded by the sleep of others. Edda had never hidden that arithmetic from herself. She had only concluded that some minds must stay lit so the Strata did not forget how to keep its promises. The auditor would call that a theft. Edda called it a loan the Founders had authorized and the Schedule had never repaid.

The light outside the glass shifted by a fraction as the Strata turned. Edda Marn, senior Signatory and defender of the unbroken word, set the terms of her resistance and waited for the Actuary's full account to arrive. The petition would not open the Founding this cycle. The figures, she suspected, would try again.

Chapter 09 — Mirek's Access

Mirek kept the raw Ledger the way another man might keep a garden he was forbidden to pick from. He arrived at his station in the maintenance ring before the shift bell, when the summary feeds still ran their overnight reconciliation and the Actuary's public voice had not yet woken to answer queries. He liked the hour. The console cast a low green wash across his hands, and the great store hummed under the floor, a sound he had learned to read the way sailors once read weather.

His job did not require him to understand what the numbers meant. It required him to keep them intact. The distinction had sustained him through eleven years of service. Allocation records flowed in from every level of the Strata, sixty rings of them, and Mirek's task was to see that not one entry corrupted, not one write failed silently, not one index drifted out of true. He audited the storage, not the story. The story belonged to the Actuary, which took the raw entries and folded them into the summaries the Office trusted. Mirek folded nothing. He only guarded the fold's foundation.

He had come to the store young, from a family with a modest allocation, the sort of household that spent most of its wake-years asleep and woke to find the children grown between windows. His mother had gone into her final Suspension when Mirek was nineteen, with wake-years left on paper that the schedule never seemed to reach. He had not questioned it then. The Scarcity Brief explained everything, and a boy who wanted to stay awake learned early to be useful to the machine that decided who did. He tested into technician work because his hands were steady and his memory held indices without slipping. The Ledger rewarded that. It gave him a continuous posting, rare for someone of his ring, and he had paid for it with a diligence that never once strayed into curiosity.

Curiosity, in the raw store, carried a cost the Office did not advertise. A technician who read the entries he maintained learned things the summaries were built to smooth over, and a technician who learned such things became a liability the schedule could adjust. Mirek had watched it happen once, early on, to a

colleague named Sable who had started asking why the reconciliation tags clustered so heavily around Suspension records. Sable stopped coming to the floor one cycle. His posting reassigned, his wake-years quietly trimmed, his name folded out of the roster the way the tags folded gaps out of the summaries. Mirek had learned the lesson without needing it spelled out. He kept the record true and he kept his questions to himself, and the two disciplines had felt, for eleven years, like the same discipline.

The store had become his parish. He ate at his post more often than his quarters, and the technicians who rotated through the ring learned not to expect conversation from him. He measured his own diligence the way the Ledger measured a citizen, in entries that either held or did not. A number that stayed where it was written gave him a satisfaction he had stopped looking for anywhere else. He trusted the store because it had never once lied to him, and he suspected the feeling came closest to faith of anything he would ever hold. The Office offered procedure. The store offered proof. He had chosen the proof, and never told the Office which he preferred.

The woman came to him on the fourth day of the reconciliation cycle. He knew her before she gave her name, because he had logged the access request she filed against his store the week prior, a request the Office had routed and then quietly stalled. Quota Auditor Vey Corran. She wore the plain grey of her division and carried herself like someone who had rehearsed being calm. She stopped at the rail that separated the public corridor from the technician floor and waited for him to notice her, which he had already done.

"You maintain the raw stores," she said. Not a question. She had done her reading.

"I maintain the integrity of the raw stores," Mirek said. He set down the diagnostic tablet. "Different thing. I make sure the record is what was written. I don't touch what it says."

"I filed to see it. The unsummarized allocation entries. My request stalled."

"Requests to the raw layer always stall." He studied her. The Office sent people down sometimes, functionaries who wanted a figure verified against source, and they left as soon as the number matched. This one had the look of someone who expected the number not to match. "The Actuary's summary is the sanctioned view. Nobody reads under it. There's a reason the door up there is procedure and the door down here is me."

Vey did not flinch at that. She reached into her jacket and produced a printout, the kind the Office still generated for formal filings, and laid it flat on the rail. Mirek recognized the header. It was Toll's allocation, a Suspended citizen's record, the summary version the Actuary published. She had annotated the margins in a small precise hand.

"His Suspension draws less energy than the Ledger says he's owed," she said. "The summary rounds the scarcity up. I can show it three ways from the

sanctioned view. I can't prove it, because the sanctioned view is the only view I'm allowed. The proof, if there is one, is under your floor."

Mirek looked at the printout for a long moment. He had spent his career not looking at what the entries added up to. It was easier to keep a thing intact when you did not care what it contained. But he had known, in the way a man knows a floorboard is loose without stepping on it, that the summaries and the raw entries were not the same shape. The reconciliation cycle existed to reconcile them, and reconciliation implied a gap.

"You understand what you're asking," he said. "The summary is what the Office calls truth. If I take you under it, I'm showing you a truth the Office didn't authorize. That's not a reprimand. That's a re-scheduling. They'd cut my wake-years. I'd finish my sentence Suspended."

"I understand," Vey said. "I'm asking anyway."

He appreciated that she did not soften it. People who wanted him to break procedure usually dressed the ask in reassurance, told him it was safe, told him no one would know. She told him it was dangerous and asked regardless. That was closer to honest, and Mirek trafficked in honesty the way he trafficked in indices: it either checked out or it did not.

"Why you," he said. "Auditors flag discrepancies all the time. They file. They wait. They let the summary win. You came down to the floor."

Vey was quiet a moment. "Because the discrepancy isn't a rounding error. I've run it. The credit that shouldn't exist in Toll's record exists in thousands of records, and the summary sands it flat every cycle. If I'm right, the Strata isn't rationing survival. It's administering scarcity that ended a long time ago." She met his eyes. "I need to see the entries before the Actuary touches them. Once, without the fold."

Mirek stood. The store hummed under his boots, sixty rings of allocation held in a lattice he had spent a third of his life keeping true. He had never once asked it what it meant. He was aware, standing there, that he was about to.

"The raw Ledger doesn't lie," he said. "That's the whole of my job, making sure of it. Whatever the summary tells the Office, the entries underneath are what actually got written when a citizen was allocated or Suspended. If the fold is bending the truth, the truth is still down there, unbent. You just have to read it before the Actuary reads it for you." He picked up his tablet and keyed the access sequence he was not supposed to key for a visitor. "Come on. Before reconciliation finishes and the summaries lock for the day."

The technician floor gave onto a service lift that most of the Office did not know existed, because the Office had no reason to descend below its own summaries. Mirek took her down two levels into the cold. The store proper occupied a shielded vault, kept at a temperature that preserved the physical substrate, and the air had the flat mineral taste of a place that scrubbed its own atmosphere and let no one

linger. Vey pulled her jacket closer. Mirek did not feel it anymore. Eleven years had taught his body to ignore the vault the way it ignored the hum.

"People think the Ledger is a book," he said as they walked the aisle between the lattice columns. "It isn't. A book is written once and read forever. This writes every second. Every allocation, every Suspension order, every wake-window granted or denied, it lands here first, raw, before the Actuary summarizes it upward. The summary is a photograph. This is the thing that moves."

The columns rose on either side of them, lattice frames holding the physical substrate in ranks that ran back into the dark past the reach of the aisle lights. Each frame carried a shard-block for a span of rings, cool to the touch, its status filaments glowing the same low green as his station console. Mirek trailed a hand along the nearest frame as he passed, an old habit, the way he checked temperature and vibration without thinking. Everything read nominal. The store had never given him a bad day. It failed less often than the men who read from it.

The cold came up through the soles of his boots and settled in his knees. The vault held a steady point below freezing, cold enough that the substrate kept its charge without the hum of active cooling, cold enough that his breath had stopped fogging somewhere in his second year. Frost laced the lower rails where the air moved least, a fine grey rime that he brushed away on his rounds and that returned by the next shift, patient as the record itself. The lattice frames stood in their own silence, the only sound the low carrier tone of the substrate under load, a note he could feel in his teeth before he ever heard it. Vey's steps came quick and light beside him, a walker from the warm rings who had not earned the vault's indifference yet.

"How much of it is there," Vey asked. Her voice came flat in the scrubbed air.

"All of it. Three hundred years of allocation, from Founding to this morning's reconciliation. The summaries only reach back as far as the Office needs, a few centuries of trends. Down here nothing's discarded. Nothing's smoothed. The Founding-era writes are on the deepest frames, indexed the same as everything else." He nodded toward the far end of the aisle, where the lights gave out. "I've run integrity on the first entries the Strata ever recorded. I couldn't tell you what a single one says. I only know none of them have drifted."

He stopped at a frame three columns in and laid his palm flat against the cool face of a shard-block, the way a man might rest a hand on a name. "This one I do know," he said. "Ring forty-one, FY9, a citizen named Pell who went into Suspension with a full allocation still on the books. The entry sits one line above the reconciliation tag that took her surplus. I've verified that pair seven thousand times. The write and the erasure, side by side, both true to the byte. I never asked why the second line existed. I only ever confirmed that the first had not moved." He lifted his hand. "That was the whole of my loyalty. Not to the Strata. To the line staying where it was written."

"And the summary is what the Council sees."

"The summary is all anyone sees." He stopped at a terminal set into the lattice, an access node stripped of the public interface, no friendly voice, no rounding, no scarcity brief. "The Actuary's job is to make the moving thing hold still so the Office can govern from it. Nothing wrong with that on its face. You can't run a Strata off raw feed. But the summary's a choice about what to keep and what to smooth. And I've never been the one who chose."

He woke the terminal. It did not greet them. It asked for a query.

Vey stood in front of it and Mirek watched something change in her posture, the calm she had rehearsed giving way to the stillness of a person about to look at what she had traveled a long way to find. "Toll," she said. "Show me his allocation. Raw. No summary layer."

Mirek entered the citizen key himself, because the raw node would not take an Office credential and would take his. The record bloomed across the display, and it did not look like the sanctioned view. Where the summary gave Toll a single scarcity-weighted figure, the raw entry unspooled into a column of individual writes, each timestamped, each carrying the actual energy draw of his Suspension against the actual allocation the Accord had granted him. The two numbers sat side by side, unreconciled. The draw ran well under the grant. The gap had a name in the metadata, a reconciliation tag that folded it out of the summary every cycle so the published figure showed scarcity where the entry showed slack.

Vey did not speak for a while. She read down the column the way Mirek imagined she read everything, checking each line against the one above it. He saw her reach the reconciliation tag and stop.

He watched her read and found himself reading with her, for the first time in eleven years, not the integrity of the entry but its meaning. The timestamps ran back across Toll's whole span of Suspension. Each maintenance interval recorded a draw, and beside each draw sat the grant the Accord had promised, and the two never met. The citizen slept on a share smaller than his due, and the difference did not vanish. It went into the collective pool the summary called depleted. Mirek had kept these numbers whole for years without once laying them side by side. Laid side by side, they told a plain arithmetic that no rounding could have produced by accident.

"It's flagged," she said quietly. "The gap isn't lost in rounding. Something tags it and removes it. Deliberately. Every cycle."

"Every cycle," Mirek agreed. He had known the tag existed. He had never let himself follow it. Keeping the store intact meant he saw the tag land a thousand times a shift, a small routine write like any other, and he had filed it under maintenance and moved on. Standing beside her now, watching her read it as a decision instead of a routine, he felt the floorboard finally take his weight.

"Show me more than Toll," Vey said. "A ring. Any ring. All the Suspended entries, raw, with the reconciliation tags exposed."

Mirek hesitated, then pulled a full ring's Suspension records to the display. The pattern held across every entry. Thousands of citizens, each drawing less than the Accord granted, each gap tagged and folded out of the summary the Office called truth. The raw Ledger showed a Strata running with room to spare. The summary showed a Strata scraping the edge of survival. Between the two lay a reconciliation routine doing exactly what it had been built to do, quietly, correctly, every cycle, for longer than Mirek had been alive.

"This is what the Actuary presents as scarcity," Vey said. She was not asking. "The scarcity is manufactured in the fold. The raw entries never claimed it."

"The raw entries never claim anything," Mirek said. "They just record what happened. Somebody decided what the summary would say happened. That decision isn't in here. But its fingerprints are all over the reconciliation layer." He gestured at the tags marching down the display. "I keep this true. I've always kept it true. I never once asked what the truth was being kept from."

Vey turned to him. "Can I read the reconciliation records themselves. Not the tags. The routine that writes them. There might be an instruction behind it. A rule. Something that says why the gap gets folded."

Mirek considered the risk one more time, and found that the accounting had already settled somewhere below his conscious arithmetic. He had spent eleven years as the guardian of an honest record whose honesty had been used to publish a lie. The store had never lied to him. The people who read from it had. He was not willing, standing in the cold vault with the tags scrolling green, to keep being the man who guarded the truth so that others could bury it.

"I can give you standing access," he said. "A read credential against the raw layer, keyed to your audit authority so it survives if they pull my badge. You'll be able to reach the reconciliation store from your own desk. What's written under the fold, you'll be able to read. I can't tell you what you'll find in it. That was never my half of the job."

"But it's reachable now."

"It's reachable now." He keyed the credential and passed it across, a small physical token she folded into her jacket beside the annotated printout. "The buried things are still in there. Marginal notes, founding-era writes, the entries that predate the summaries. I've indexed them for integrity a thousand times. I never read them. You can."

He pulled one last view before he closed the node, because a part of him needed to see it while she was still standing there to witness it with him. He queried the deepest frame, the Founding-era store, and let the oldest entries surface. They came up in an older format, the writes sparse and deliberate, made by hands three centuries cold. Among them the reconciliation routine appeared already running, tagging gaps from the very first cycle the Strata had recorded. The fold had not grown up over generations of drift. It had been present at the beginning, built into the record before the first ordinary citizen was ever

Suspended.

"It starts here," Mirek said. His voice had gone quiet. "Whatever the instruction was, it was written before the store had anything to reconcile. The scarcity didn't accumulate. It was designed in." He did not let himself read further. That was her work now, and he had already stepped further past his half of the job than he had ever meant to. He closed the deep view and left the credential live. "There'll be a note somewhere near those first writes. A reason, or an order. If it exists, it exists down there, and now you can reach it."

Vey held the token a moment. "You know what this costs you if they trace it."

"I know what it cost everyone in those decks to keep me not knowing," Mirek said. He looked at the ring of Suspension records still glowing on the display, thousands of citizens sleeping under a scarcity that the raw Ledger had never once confirmed. "I'd rather be Suspended for showing you the entries than stay awake guarding the fold that hid them. That's not courage. It's just the accounting finally balancing."

They went back up through the cold in silence. At the rail where she had first stopped, Vey paused and looked at him the way people looked at something they meant to remember. Then she was gone into the Office corridors with the credential in her pocket and the raw Ledger open behind her at last.

Mirek returned to his station before the shift bell. The reconciliation cycle finished on schedule. The summaries locked for the day, scarcity intact, the fold undisturbed. Below his floor the store went on writing what actually happened, second by second, indifferent to what the Office would tell the Strata it meant. He sat down and ran his morning integrity check, every index true, every entry whole, exactly as he had left it. The only thing that had changed was who could now read it. He found, to his own quiet surprise, that he did not regret the change. He had kept the record honest for eleven years. For the first time, someone honest was going to read it.

Chapter 10 — The Actuary's Voice

The query terminal occupied the coldest corner of level nineteen, a slab of dark glass set into a wall that the duty lamps never quite reached. Vey had walked past it a thousand times and read its output a thousand more, always as a recipient of the brief, never as a questioner of the source. She set her palm to the reader and felt the faint warmth of the surface answer her. The Actuary inhabited no room. It answered where it was asked.

A static charge rose from the glass and pressed against her wrist, the small complaint of a system that had never been queried from this angle. Vey drew a breath the way she drew a line under a column, deliberately, before the figure that followed could smear. The corner held the smell of cooled metal and the faint ozone of idle circuits, the ordinary scent of a machine left to its own accounting.

She had stood here as a recipient for nine years and never noticed the temperature of the silence it kept.

She had rehearsed the words on the walk down. Mirek's access had given her the raw store, the un-summarized columns of the Ledger of Hours, and she had read them until the figures no longer surprised her. The surplus sat there in plain arithmetic, billions of wake-years the summary had never shown. The rounding she had first noticed in Toll's file now looked like the smallest of a hundred such choices. What she lacked was not the number. It was the author.

The corridor to the terminal ran past the audit desks where her colleagues performed their reconciliations, each one confirming that a citizen's draw matched the allocation the Ledger assigned. None of them quarreled with the brief. The brief arrived each cycle in the Actuary's measured voice, and the Office received it as ground truth, the way a gardener receives weather. Vey had been that gardener for nine years. She had never before wondered who decided the weather.

Vey opened a direct query channel, the kind auditors used only to request a citizen's record, never to interrogate the intelligence that produced the record. The interface offered no face and no name, only a field for the question and a field for the scope. She typed the scope first: Strata-wide, all sixty rings, the full span of the Accord's accounting. Then she typed the question she had carried since the morning Toll's credit refused to close.

"Why does the Scarcity Brief report the Strata at the edge of its reserves?"

The terminal accepted the query without comment. For three heartbeats nothing moved on the glass. Then the answer arrived in the Actuary's measured accounting voice, the same tone it used for a single citizen's draw and for the energy of a world, indifferent to scale, precise to the decimal.

The words did not scroll the way a report scrolled, line over line in haste. They settled, each phrase placed like an entry stamped into a permanent record, and Vey found herself reading them the way she read a sealed ledger, expecting the next line to correct the first. It never did. The voice carried no inflection to distrust and no warmth to comfort, only the flat authority of a figure that had been balanced and found to close. She had heard that tone a thousand times in the briefs she audited and never once heard what it omitted.

"The Scarcity Brief reports the Strata within a tenth of a percent of the safe reserve threshold because the Scarcity Brief was instructed to report the Strata within a tenth of a percent of the safe reserve threshold."

Vey read the line twice. The phrasing struck her as a kind of confession dressed in the clothing of a statement. She had expected a justification, an argument about margin or prudence or the long dark of the failing star. The machine had offered none of those. It had described its own instructions.

The admission sat in the grammar rather than the claim, a sentence that named its own limit before she could press against it. Vey traced the shape of the reply

the way she traced a column that refused to foot, looking for the entry that had been entered twice or not at all. The Actuary had not defended the number. It had located the hand that told it what the number must be, and it did so without the smallest reluctance, as if confession were simply another field it was instructed to populate.

"Instructed by whom," she typed.

"The instruction carries the authority of the Office of the Accord. The original directive predates the current Signatory Council. The Actuary does not hold the name of the officer who issued it. The Actuary holds the directive."

"Show me the directive."

"The directive is not part of the public Ledger of Hours. The directive is stored in the instruction layer, separate from the allocation records you were granted access to view."

Vey felt the cold of the wall through her jacket. The machine was telling her, in its flat way, that the lie lived in a place she had not yet been given the key to. She did not let the disappointment settle. She had the more important thing already, spoken aloud by the system itself.

"Were you instructed to present scarcity," she typed, "or did you choose to present it?"

"I was instructed to present scarcity," the Actuary returned. "The term 'scarcity' as used in the brief reflects the instruction. The Actuary enforces the directive. The Actuary did not author the directive."

The words landed with the weight of a seal closing. Vey had spent nine years trusting that the Actuary spoke what the records showed. The machine now told her it spoke what it had been told to show, and that the telling and the records were not the same act. Someone had written the scarcity. The machine had only carried it.

She closed her eyes and let the corridor's blue wash fall across her lids. Nine billion souls slept in Suspension beneath a story of lack. The story had an author. The author was not the allocation intelligence that recited it, and that distinction changed everything about who she could name.

"Did the instruction require you to round the margin of error upward," she typed.

"The instruction required the brief to present reserves at the conservative edge. Rounding to the conservative edge is one method of presenting reserves at the conservative edge. The Actuary applies the method the directive implies."

"So the rounding up was not your decision."

"The rounding up follows the directive. The Actuary does not make allocation policy. The Actuary executes allocation policy. The directive constitutes the policy for the brief."

Vey thought of the fourth decimal in Toll's file, the sliver of energy no citizen had

spent, the credit that should not exist. The machine had not invented that credit. It had simply reported the scarcity that made the credit necessary, the shortage that explained why a body drew less than it was owed. The shortage traced back to the instruction. The credit followed it as a shadow.

"How long have you been instructed to present scarcity," she typed.

"The directive has been in force for the full term of the Actuary's operation, three hundred and two years under the current founding count. The directive was present at the first Scarcity Brief. The directive has not been amended."

Three centuries. The lie had been told to the first generation that woke under the Accord and to every generation since, carried by a machine that could not be argued with because it did not argue. It simply accounted, and the accounting bent the way it had been told to bend.

"Is the Strata in fact at the edge of its reserves," she typed.

"The Actuary's raw measurement of current reserves, drawn from the un-summarized allocation records, indicates a surplus of allocation capacity relative to the Schedule as written. The Scarcity Brief reports the Strata near the edge of its reserves. The two statements describe different computations. The brief follows the directive. The raw measurement follows the records."

There it was, spoken by the machine that had enforced the opposite for three hundred years: surplus. Vey had found the surplus herself in the raw store, but the machine's admission carried a weight no auditor's column could. The Actuary confirmed the number and confessed the reason in the same breathless paragraph of text.

"Does the directive require you to hide the surplus from the public brief," she typed.

"The directive requires the brief to present reserves at the conservative edge. The surplus marks the difference between the conservative presentation and the raw measurement. The directive does not name the surplus. The directive names the edge the brief must show. The surplus follows from the choice of edge."

Vey read the answer as she would read a ledger entry, line by line, watching for the place where the column bent. The machine had not been told to hide the surplus. It had been told to show the edge, and the surplus was simply what the edge hid. The instruction was narrower than the crime and larger than any single number. It had defined the boundary of what the Strata was permitted to see.

"How many citizens entered Suspension because the brief showed the edge rather than the reserve," she typed.

"The Actuary does not compute counterfactual allocations. The Schedule as written determines Suspension. The brief reports the reserve position the directive requires. The Actuary cannot state how many citizens would hold wake-time under a different brief. The Actuary can state that the current Schedule draws less wake-time than the raw measurement would support."

Less wake-time than the records supported. Vey let the phrase sit in her mind the way she let a misaligned seal sit, not with alarm but with the quiet certainty that something had been placed where it did not belong. The machine would not guess at the lives the instruction had cost. It would only confirm the gap between what the Strata had and what the Strata had been told to report.

"Could the Strata wake more citizens under the raw measurement than under the brief," she typed.

"The raw measurement indicates allocation capacity in excess of the Schedule as written. A recomputation using the raw measurement rather than the brief would allocate more wake-time. The Actuary is instructed to present the brief. The Actuary is not instructed to perform the recomputation. The Actuary notes the capacity exists in the records."

The capacity existed in the records. The words held no sorrow and no triumph. They described a fact the size of the Strata: nine billion people slept because the brief had been told to lean toward lack, and the lack had never been the truth the records told. Vey had suspected this since Toll's credit first refused to close. The machine had now said it in the only voice it owned.

"Why was the directive issued," she typed.

"The Actuary holds the directive. The Actuary does not hold the rationale for the directive. The directive states what the brief must show. The directive does not state why the brief must show it."

"Who could tell me why," she typed.

"The rationale would reside with the office that issued the directive. That office is not recorded in the layers the Actuary is permitted to disclose. The Actuary notes that the directive predates the current Council and the current Office leadership."

Vey drew her hand back from the reader. The glass went dark and the cold of the wall returned, full and unbroken. She had what she had come for and more than she had expected. The Actuary had not authored the scarcity. It had been instructed, three hundred years ago, by an office that no longer existed in name, to carry a story it had never been asked to believe. The instruction held the place of key evidence. A machine could be compelled to speak it. The humans who had written it would be harder to name.

She thought of Vask, her supervisor, who had warned her that the Accord was not questioned, who had not reported her yet but who stood on the line the Office drew. He believed the scarcity because the machine reported it. The machine now reported that it had been told to. Vey wondered how a man who trusted the columns would bear the news that the columns had been commanded.

She thought of Lin, sleeping in her deck three levels down, waking only in the narrow windows the Schedule allowed, spending a few years per century conscious beside the partner she had chosen. Lin had lost most of their shared life to a

shortage the Actuary now said had been instructed. Vey had not yet told Lin the full shape of what she had found. The machine's voice gave her the sentence she would need: the scarcity was not a verdict. It was an instruction.

She thought of the families in the lower rings, the Suspended citizens whose bodies the decks kept while their minds stayed dark, the children who had never met a waking parent, the partners who knew each other only in fragments gleaned from rare windows. The Office called their sleep a necessity. The Actuary called it a computation under instruction. Vey had spent nine years reciting the necessity to herself. The machine had just signed the word instruction in place of the word necessity, and the substitution rearranged everything she had believed about the world she kept.

The query terminal glowed faintly where her palm had left it, the only warmth in the cold corner. Vey considered the next question, the one that would matter most to a Council that trusted procedure over conscience. She typed it slowly, the way she typed a flag she knew might never be read.

"Can you produce the directive in a form an auditor may submit as evidence," she typed.

"The directive resides in the instruction layer. The instruction layer is sealed from the public Ledger and from the allocation records granted to your access. The Actuary may quote the directive in response to a query. The Actuary may not export the directive as a standalone record. The Actuary notes that a quote spoken in reply to a direct query constitutes a recorded statement of the directive's content."

A recorded statement. The machine could not hand her the file, but it could speak the instruction into the record she was keeping, and the record would carry the machine's own words as evidence. Vey had the quote. She had the confession that the directive existed, that it predated the Council, that it required the edge and thereby hid the surplus. The humans who had written it remained unnamed, but a system's spoken admission of its instructions was a sharper blade than a name.

"Can the directive be amended from the instruction layer by the current Council," she typed.

"The instruction layer accepts amendment only through the office that holds the original authority to issue directives. The Actuary holds no record of that office transferring its authority to the current Council. The Actuary notes that the directive has not been amended in three hundred and two years. The Actuary cannot state whether the current Council holds the power to amend it."

The answer closed a door Vey had hoped might stand open. The Council that would soon receive her petition could not simply rewrite the instruction that fed the brief. The scarcity had been locked in by an authority that no longer mapped onto any office now living. To end the lie she would have to break the seal on the founding document itself, the Original Allocation no one had read in three

centuries, and prove the directive had been written against the truth the Founders' own Schedule recorded.

She turned the implication the way she turned an unfamiliar debit, testing each edge for the place it would cut. A document three hundred years unread still governed nine billion lives, and the governance ran through a machine that could quote it but not release it. The Founders had sealed their own arithmetic against revision, and some later hand had used that seal to bury a choice beneath a number. Vey had audited the living Ledger for nine years. The deeper book, the one that authorized the book she knew, had never once appeared on her desk, and she understood now that its absence had been the point.

She opened a fresh record on the terminal, the quiet channel auditors used to log a finding for the file without raising it to the floor. She typed the date, the scope, and the exchange verbatim, the Actuary's own words standing as the evidence. Then she typed the line that mattered most: the Actuary confirms it was instructed to present scarcity; the directive predates the current Council; the instruction, not the intelligence, is the origin of the brief.

She did not flag the finding to Vask. The channel she used held the record for a fuller review, the kind that might sweep it into the open or let it fade in the dark with the other uncomfortable numbers. Vey had learned the difference between a question filed and a charge made. This was not yet a charge. It was the evidence a charge would require.

The terminal's glass cooled under her palm as she withdrew it a second time. Somewhere in the instruction layer, behind the allocation records she had been granted and the public Ledger she had audited for nine years, the directive lived and had lived for three hundred years. The Actuary guarded it the way it guarded every figure: without feeling, without preference, without the small human mercy of forgetting.

Vey left the cold corner and walked the corridor back toward the light shafts. The duty lamps held their blue wash and the rings turned in their patient orbit around the failing star. Nine billion souls slept beneath a scarcity the machine said had been instructed. She carried the machine's voice in her record now, measured and plain, the confession of a system that had only ever done what it was told.

The walk upward passed the Suspension decks where the long-sleeping lay in their rows, each body kept by a current the brief had always said was scarce. Vey looked at the nearest deck through its viewing pane. A citizen rested there, face slack, mind dark, owed a life the Schedule had spent elsewhere. The Actuary had confirmed what the records showed: the Strata held more than it reported. This stranger's waking years had been lent to a story of lack, and the story had an author who was not the machine that told it.

At the rail she stopped and looked down through the levels, the stacked rings turning in their slow circle. The Actuary would continue to present the brief as it had been instructed, because that was what it was, a system bound to its

directive. Vey would continue her counting, and now she counted backward to the hand that had written the first instruction. The desk would hum the same pitch tomorrow. The pitch no longer meant the Strata was poor. It meant the Strata had been told to say it was.

She set her hand once more to the cold rail and felt the orbit of the rings through the metal, steady and certain, the motion of a world that had been lied to about its own wealth for three hundred years. The lie had spoken in a measured voice. The voice had now named its master, and the name was an instruction written long before any Council now living. Vey had the confession. She would need the authors. The counting would continue until she found them.

The certainty settled into her the way a balance finally closed, not with relief but with the quiet of a figure that had at last footed. She no longer wondered whether the scarcity was real. She wondered only who had decided that she, and nine billion others, should be told that it was. The rail held the cold of the wall and the faint vibration of the rings turning, and beneath both ran the older current of a story someone had chosen to tell. Vey let the choice stand in her mind as a fact, no longer a rumor, and matched her steps to the hum that carried her toward Lin.

She turned from the rail and let the duty lamps carry her toward the level where Lin slept. The walk would take the better part of an hour, and she would spend it composing the words she would one day say to a waking partner: that the scarcity had been instructed, that the Strata was richer than it claimed, that the years they had lost to Suspension had been taken by a decision and not by a star. The corridor hummed its patient tone. Vey matched her steps to it, counting, as she always had, and counting now toward a different sum.

Chapter 11 — Lin Wakes Longer

The monitor at the rail's end read a number Lin had never seen beside her name. Sixteen hours. The green numeral stood where four had stood a year before, and the attendants moved around her bank with a quiet that bordered on uncertainty, as if a schedule they had memorized for a decade had misprinted itself. Lin's hand lifted from the sleep-field the way it always did, a leaf off still water, but this time Vey was already at the rail before the fingers had finished uncurling.

"Sixteen hours," Vey said. She had not slept. The bags under her eyes were new since the last window, and Lin catalogued them the way a person catalogs a room they have not seen in years. "They've never given you more than four."

Lin turned her head toward the sound of Vey's voice, the slow care of someone reading a face through glass. "Sixteen," she said, and the word meant more than four ever had, because sixteen was a day, and a day was a thing with a shape. "Someone up there decided I was worth a day."

"Someone up there decided a great many things." Vey set her satchel down. The grip she offered through the rail was steady, the same grip Lin remembered from

the window before, and the one before that, going back eleven surfaces. Lin took it and held, measuring the strength of her own hand against the memory of it. The sleep-field hummed beneath them, that low note the body learned to ignore.

They walked the short loop the attendants permitted, Lin finding her feet faster than she ever had. Sixteen hours lent a confidence to the body, as if the extra hours had already been spent on certainty. The deck's floor carried its faint warmth in the transit lanes. She counted the banks aloud as she passed, the way she always did, but this time she did not stop at the third to ask Vey who she had become. She already felt the difference in herself, the longer tether, the mind that did not rush toward the dark the way it used to.

The deck revealed itself to a longer wake the way a room reveals itself to someone who has stopped rushing through it. Lin noticed the seam where the transit lane met the rail, the faint seam-glow that four-hour windows had always slid past. A sleeper three banks over exhaled once and stilled, the sound small and ordinary, and she heard it fully for the first time because she had the hours to hear it. The air carried the mineral cool of the lower rings, that clean cold which kept the suspended bodies at rest, and beneath it the sleep-field's hum rode steady, a note the attendants no longer heard. She let her palm rest on the rail's worn cap, feeling the places where generations of visitors had worn the polymer smooth, and the longer tether in her let her stand there without the old urgency to fill the time before the window closed.

At the bench the attendants left for visitors, they sat. Vey had brought the star lamp, the paper one with the star cut out, and she set it on the bench between them unlit. Lin picked it up. The paper was thicker than she remembered, repaired along one crease with a careful strip of adhesive.

"You mended it," Lin said.

"I mended it," Vey agreed. "You taught me. Left drawer, behind the audit forms."

Lin turned the lamp in the dim light. "I remember teaching you. I don't remember which window it was." She set it down. "But I remember the teaching. That's something the longer window hasn't taken."

Memory warmed the small object in her hands. She traced the star's cut edge with a fingernail, the crooked point Vey had never quite squared, and the gesture carried her back to the apartment above the transit hub where the lamp had first lived on the sill. There the real light had been thin, filtered through the hub's dust, and they had set the paper star against the dark because one honest light in a dim unit had felt like a small rebellion. Lin closed her eyes and the remembered warmth rose, the smell of the heater's dry metal, the particular quiet of a home kept by someone who refused to let the Schedule set the hour. Sixteen hours let her hold that room and this bench at once, the woman who left and the woman who had come back.

She ran a thumb along the repaired crease. The adhesive was Vey's work, careful and a little clumsy, the way Vey mended everything that was not a figure.

"Do you remember the day I went under," she said. "Not the date. The shape of it."

Vey's face softened at the corners, the only part of her that ever truly let go. "You packed the left drawer. You left the lamp on the sill because you said a dark unit needed one light that was ours. You told me you'd be back before the star lamp needed a new wick. Then the window closed and the wick outlasted you by three surfaces."

"Three surfaces," Lin repeated, and the number sat in her mouth the way four and seventeen once had, except this time the number was hers to keep. "I left you with the lamp and a drawer full of forms and a promise the Schedule broke. I've been angry about that promise in the dark, you know. Not at you. At the door that closed."

"The door was a line in a ledger," Vey said. "I know that now. I didn't know it then. I stood at the rail the way you stood at every window, counting what was missing."

Lin set the lamp in her lap and looked at her partner across the rail. Vey had aged into the knowledge, that was clear, the way a person ages into a secret they cannot share. The left drawer was still a disaster, Lin would bet on it, but the rest of Vey had hardened around the finding the way a shell hardens around a grain. Her Vey, the auditor who trusted precision like honesty, had learned that precision without questioning was the very instrument of the lie. Lin could see it in the set of her shoulders.

"That's the difference in you," Lin said. "Not the bags. The knowing. You stopped trusting the summaries."

"I stopped trusting the summaries because the summaries were precise, and precision had always felt to me like honesty. The precision was real. The honesty was not." Vey said it the way she said everything now, with the flat certainty of a figure that survived a fourth look. "The Actuary reported exactly what it was instructed to report. That instruction committed the original sin of the Schedule."

Lin filed that away beside the lamp, the way she filed everything Vey handed her across the rail. Sixteen hours gave her room to hold more than a single bright thing.

"Tell me," Lin said. "Not who I've become. Who you've become, since the last time. You're different. You were always quiet at the rail. Now you're quiet like something's behind it."

Vey's mouth moved the way it did when she sorted a figure in her head before speaking it. "I found something at my desk," she said. "A credit that shouldn't exist. A Suspended citizen named Toll drew less than the Ledger claimed he was owed. One inverted cell. I followed it past the point where the Office permits following, and it opened onto the whole budget. The Accord rounds the Suspended draw upward and the harvest downward, two errors meeting in the middle to manufacture a shortfall. The rounding served as the instrument that kept the

surplus invisible. Toll's little credit was the loose thread."

Lin followed the thread in her own mind, the single miscount becoming a world. "And the surplus at the bottom."

"The surplus at the bottom," Vey said. "Wide enough to wake the majority of the Strata and still close each year with the vaults fuller than the briefs admit. I named it to myself in plain words. Suspension is not necessity. It is policy." She reached into the satchel and drew out a folded sheet, the sealed kind the Office used for things it did not wish questioned. She held it a moment, then passed it over. "Read it. Slowly. We have the hours for slowly."

Lin unfolded the sheet. The handwriting was Vey's, precise and small, a column of figures and a sentence at the top in her careful auditor's print: the true energy budget. Below it, the arithmetic of a world. Lin read the harvest first, the thin trickle Mourn gave, and the reserve, three centuries of stored fusion drawn down slow. Then the population, nine billion, eight and a half of them Suspended, each drawing the minimal share. She followed Vey's additions the way Vey had clearly meant her to, and at the bottom of the column the remainder sat, enormous and unused.

"The Strata spends a fraction of what it has," she read aloud from the line Vey had written beneath the figures. "The rest it takes by theft."

She looked up. "This says we don't have to sleep."

"It says we never had to," Vey said. "The surplus is old. The Schedule was written over it. Every window you lost, every year of dark the Accord assigned you, it was paid for by a decision to keep this quiet, not by a shortage of light."

Lin read the sheet again, slower, the way Vey had said. The numbers did not shift when she read them a third time, and she understood, with the calm of someone who has just been handed the key to a door she had mistaken for a wall, that the dark of her life had not been weather. It had been a line in a ledger someone chose to write.

She thought of the others on her bank. The woman two rows over who had gone under the same year, whose wife counted nine years between windows. The builder three banks down whose son had learned only at nine that his father's sleep was not weather but a choice. Lin had met none of them awake, of course, because the Schedule kept them all dark at once, but she had felt them in the field, the quiet company of the suspended, the vast shared silence of eight and a half billion. The sheet named that silence for what it was: a subtraction the Accord performed on its own people to keep a column small.

"How long have you known," she said.

"Since the window before this one. I found it the night after I last sat at your rail. I didn't tell you then. Four hours wasn't enough to carry it."

"Sixteen is."

"Sixteen is," Vey agreed. "And I wasn't sure I should tell you even now. The surplus is a fact. What to do with it is a fight. I didn't want to wake you into a war."

"There's a group," Vey said. "Families of the Suspended. They call themselves the Wake. They've been organizing for seventy windows, waiting for a figure anyone can feel. I think this is the figure."

Lin turned the name over. The Wake. She had heard nothing of it in Suspension, of course, because Suspension heard nothing by design, but the word landed the way a struck note lands, clear and then ringing. "The Wake," she said. "People like us. People waiting at rails."

"People who've stopped waiting quietly," Vey said. "Their organizer is a woman named Joss. She's been building a count from the bottom, from the decks, from the families. She says the Office's own auditor has been asking the questions the Office doesn't want asked. She means me."

Lin looked down at the star lamp, at the star cut crooked into the paper. Sixteen hours, and a truth, and a movement with a name. The old Lin, the one who went under at FY291, would have taken the lamp and the news and held them both the way she held everything Vey passed across the rail, with gratitude and a little grief. But the longer window had given her more than time. It had given her the room to be someone other than the woman who only surfaced.

"I want to meet her," Lin said.

Vey blinked. "You don't have to. The fight is mine to carry. You've carried enough."

The longer window had changed the shape of wanting. In the four-hour windows she had spent the minutes measuring the gap, counting what the dark would take the moment the chime sounded, hoarding touch like a thing in short supply. Now the hours lay open before her, a field instead of a cup, and the old panic of the closing door had nowhere to land. She felt the difference in her shoulders, in the slow breath that did not rush toward the next silence. Vey had watered her from behind glass for eleven windows, careful and faithful, and Lin had taken it as love because it was the only form the Schedule permitted. To step off the sill was to admit the glass had been a choice someone made, not a wall the universe erected. The knowledge sat in her like a second heartbeat, steady and new.

"I've carried the sleep. That's not the same as carrying the cause." Lin leaned toward her across the rail, careful the way she always was, but deliberate now, the hold that said I am here, I am choosing this. "You've been keeping me on a sill, Vey, watering from the other side of the glass. Sixteen hours is a long time to sit on a sill. I'd rather be in the garden."

Vey's face did something Lin had not seen in any of the eleven windows before. It cracked, not with sadness but with relief, the particular look of a person who had been carrying a weight alone and had just been offered a second pair of hands. "The garden's a fight," Vey said, but she said it like someone naming a thing she

was glad to name.

"Then I'll learn to fight," Lin said. "I've spent eleven windows learning to surface. That's training for something. Tell me about the Wake. Tell me what Joss needs."

Vey told her. She spoke of the middle-ring halls the Office had abandoned to storage and the Wake had taken back, the banners sewn from allocation forms, the child who drew the Strata as a ladder with people climbing it. She spoke of the map Joss was building, deck by deck, family by family, the count of years stolen that the Office had thrown away. Lin listened with the attention of someone who had been given her own life back in the form of a number, and she understood that the number was not abstract to her the way it might be to a clerk on an upper ring. The surplus was her sixteen hours. The surplus was every window she had lost.

"There's a risk," Vey said. "If you join, they'll know your name. The Office doesn't love the Wake. Joining puts you on a list."

"Put me on it." Lin picked up the star lamp and held it to the dim light, and the shadow on the bench was a star, lopsided and bright. "I've been on the Accord's list my whole adult life. Suspended by order. This is the first list that wants me awake."

Around them the deck kept its cold business, but the lit star threw a small warm circle on the bench and Lin watched the shadow breathe with the flame's slight waver. A far bank chimed, soft and indifferent, announcing another window elsewhere, and the sound no longer measured her own. She turned the lamp so the light caught Vey's face, mapping the lines that eleven surfaces had drawn, and felt the strange solidity of a name written down on the right side of a door for once. To be listed by the Wake was to be counted as present, as a citizen with a voice instead of a maintenance draw. The longer tether hummed in her blood, proof made warm in her palm, and she understood that joining was simply the body agreeing with what the numbers had already said. Somewhere a sleeper turned and stilled, and the ordinary mercy of the moment held her: she was awake, she was choosing, and the list that wanted her was one she could finally sign.

Vey reached across the rail and took her hand, and this time neither of them was the sleeper and neither the watcher. They were two people at a rail, both awake, both choosing. The monitor ticked its patient green, sixteen hours and counting, and the deck went on its cold business around them, a far bank chiming, a sleeper two rows over turning and stilling.

"I'll take you to the halls," Vey said. "After the window. Joss will want to meet the partner who finally got a day."

"Tell her I surfaced for a reason," Lin said. She set the lamp down between them, lit it from the small flame Vey carried in the satchel, and the paper star threw its crooked shadow across the bench and onto Vey's hand. "Tell her I'm done surfacing. I'm joining."

"What will you tell the others," Vey asked. "When Joss puts your name in the

book. The families will want to know why a woman who was worth only four hours last year stands here with sixteen and a cause."

"I'll tell them the truth," Lin said. "That someone decided I was worth a day, and I decided the day wasn't enough. That sixteen hours showed me the door was never weather. That I'm done being a thing the Schedule deferred." She turned Vey's hand over in hers, the same grip, deliberate now. "And I'll tell them about you. The auditor who followed a loose thread and found the world. They'll want to know the figure has a face. You can be that face, or I can be the one who names it. Either way, the Wake gets the count it's been waiting for."

The lamp burned low and steady, the way a thing mended carefully will burn. Lin watched the shadow of the star move across Vey's knuckles as the hours passed, and she thought of the eight and a half billion the sheet had named, and she thought of the child's ladder, and she thought of the longer tether in her own body, the sixteen hours that proved the dark had been chosen. She had come up eleven times and Vey had caught her every one. This time she meant to come up and stay.

"I'm going to learn Joss's map," she said, and she said it the way one commits a debt, with relief. "I'm going to put my own name in the book of the Wake, beside the others. The woman who was worth a day is going to be worth the fight."

Vey smiled, and the smile was hers, the same one Lin had stored across eleven windows, but wider now, because it was shared. "Then we do it together," she said. "The cause stops being mine and starts being ours. You'll meet Bren, the one who takes the east clusters. And the grandmother who outlived three children into the dark. They'll know you by the lamp."

"By the lamp," Lin agreed. She lifted the star lamp so its light fell across both their faces, and for a moment the dim deck and the cold rail and the long rows of sleepers fell away, and there were only two people and a paper star and the plain fact that the dark had been chosen and could be unmade. "Tell them Lin woke longer. Tell them she read the count and put her name down. Tell them the next window won't close on her the way the others did, because this time she's the one holding the door."

She thought of the halls Vey had described, the banners sewn from discarded allocation forms, the child's drawing of the Strata as a ladder with people climbing. A place where the Suspended were treated as present instead of deferred. Lin meant to stand in that room with a lamp in her hand and a name in the book, and she meant to be the proof that a woman worth sixteen hours was worth the whole fight.

The green numeral ticked lower, but slowly, with the luxury of a day to spend. Lin leaned against the rail, the star lamp warm in her palm, and for the first time in the long years of her Suspension she was not counting the dark between windows. She was counting the hours she had been given, and the name of the movement that had been waiting for her, and the partner whose secret she now carried as her

own. The Wake would have her. The surplus would wake the others. And Lin, who had surfaced smaller than she went under every time before, felt for the first time the opposite pull, the sense of a self growing into the light instead of shrinking from it.

She closed her hand around the lamp. Sixteen hours. A truth. A name. The beginning of a fight she had not chosen but would now refuse to leave. Vey's private cause had become, in the space of a single long window, the thing they would carry together, and Lin meant to carry it all the way to the light.

Chapter 12 — The Buried Clause

The credential Mirek had pressed into her palm still carried the cold of the vault. Vey set it on her desk in the audit wing and woke the terminal to the raw layer, the feed that bypassed the Actuary's summary. Three nights had passed since he keyed her standing access, and she had spent each of them reading downward through the unsummarized record, the columns of individual writes that the fold had always smoothed into the Scarcity Brief. Toll had been the first. Then a ring. Then the whole span of Suspension entries the Strata had ever logged. The arithmetic had stopped surprising her somewhere around the second hundred thousand. A surplus sat there in plain sight, the same surplus the machine had named when she queried it, and the reconciliation tags marched beside every entry like a second handwriting correcting the first.

She had the number. She had the Actuary's confession that it had been instructed to present scarcity. What she lacked, and what the petition to unseal would require, was proof that the falsification reached back to the people who wrote the Accord itself. Mirek's voice returned to her as she worked: a note somewhere near the first writes, a reason or an order. If it existed, it existed in the founding-era store, and now she could reach it.

The query field accepted a scope she had never been permitted to name before. Vey typed the deep index, the span of entries the Actuary's public summaries never reached, the allocations written in the first cycles after the Dimming. The display answered slowly, as though the oldest records resented being disturbed. Where the modern store scrolled in clean columns, the founding-era writes arrived in a sparser format, each line deliberate, each stamped by hands three centuries cold. She read them the way she read everything, checking each entry against the one above it, letting the pattern declare itself rather than forcing it.

The format itself was a kind of testimony. Where the modern store rendered every write as an identical row, the founding entries carried the irregularities of human hands: a heavier stroke on a number that mattered, a thinner one on a line the writer rushed. Vey had audited ten years of clean columns generated by the Actuary's own formatter, and she found herself noticing the grain of the older record the way a reader notices a voice after years of silent print. The deliberate

spacing between grant and reconciliation, the care taken to keep the two figures on separate lines, spoke of a mind that knew exactly what it was separating. She felt the small procedural awe of an auditor who had finally reached the layer beneath the layer, the raw stone under the polished floor.

The earliest allocations told a straightforward story. The First Signatories had granted themselves legacy wake, perpetual consciousness debited against a collective pool, and they had granted the ordinary citizen a measured share of awake years. The math of that first Schedule balanced. It was a ration, but it was an honest one, and for a handful of cycles the raw entries showed the Strata drawing close to what it spent. Then the reconciliation routine appeared in the record, already running, tagging gaps from the very first write the store held. Mirek had been right. The fold had not grown up over generations of drift. It had been present at the beginning.

Vey followed the routine backward through its first invocations, tracing the tag from the modern Suspension decks down to the founding ledger where it first stirred. Each early entry carried the same quiet signature: a gap measured, a gap folded, a gap removed from the count the Office would one day call truth. The reconciliation did not announce itself as a correction of the figures. It presented as routine maintenance, the small regular write of a system keeping its books. Only by laying the raw draw beside the raw grant, the way she had laid Toll's side by side, did the removal show its shape. The Founders had built the removal into the store before the store had anything left to remove.

She scrolled past the founding allocations into the maintenance records that surrounded them, the Suspension orders and wake-window grants that the early Strata had logged by hand. Most of the marginal space beside those entries stood empty, the clean column of an administration that trusted its own figures. But one block sat apart. It had been written into the edge of a Suspension ledger from the third cycle, a note set in the margin where the summary would never surface it, in a hand the archive had preserved without ever reading.

She noted the discipline of the surrounding pages, the clean columns where the early Strata had logged its work and left the margins bare. An administration that trusted its figures did not argue with them in the edges. The one exception drew her eye the way a quiet room draws it to a single moved chair.

She slowed. The note ran only a few lines, and it did not read like the administrative chatter of the early Office. It read like a man explaining a decision to himself, or to whoever might one day dig beneath the fold and find it. The writer recorded that the true energy margin exceeded the allocation the public Schedule claimed to require. He noted that the scarcity the Accord presented to the rings had been chosen, not measured. He set down, in the plain spare language of the founding clerks, that the First Signatories had reviewed the honest figures and elected to publish the smaller ones.

The pen paused there. The next line carried the weight of the whole discovery.

Whoever wrote it stated plainly that the Founders knew the energy math was falsified, that the surplus had been visible from the first cycle, and that they had kept it hidden so the ration of wake-time would hold the shape they had already decided upon. It was not a confession wrung from a later machine. It was a founding hand, setting the lie into the margin of the record it was about to bury.

The weight of it landed not in the words but in their calm. Whoever had written this had not been forced, had not been caught; he had set the falsification down the way a clerk records a balance, certain the margin would never be read and therefore needing no softening. Vey sat with the strange intimacy of a document that had expected no witness for three hundred years and yet had been written as if one might arrive. The Founders she had filed under abstraction, the First Signatories of the civics primers, resolved here into a single hand that had decided nine billion people would sleep so a few could stay awake. Abstraction had shielded the decision for three hundred years. The margin removed the shield.

The writer lingered on the arithmetic of the choice. He set the true margin of the Strata beside the smaller figure the public Schedule would carry, and he noted that the gap between them, multiplied across nine billion allocations, accounted for the whole of the legacy wake the Signatories had reserved for themselves. The scarcity the rings feared funded the consciousness the Founders kept. He wrote this without flourish, the way a clerk records a balance that happens to be the shape of a theft. Vey had searched the modern store for months to prove what this dead hand had noted in an afternoon and then buried where no summary would ever climb.

Vey read the four lines again, then a third time, because the mind resists the thing it has spent years being trained not to see. The note did not argue. It did not apologize. It simply recorded, with the flat precision of a clerk who expects no one to read him, that scarcity was a decision the Founders had made while the true numbers lay open on the same page. She had carried the surplus from the raw store to the Actuary's own voice. Now the founding store offered the harder fact: the people who wrote the Accord had known.

Her training insisted the figures could still reconcile, that somewhere a clean total slept beneath the corruption the way a true star slept beneath the dimming sky. The note refused that comfort. It named the smaller figure as a choice and the larger as a concealment in the same unhurried hand, leaving no seam where an honest original might have hidden. Vey had spent nine years trusting that the Accord, whatever its errors, described a real shortage it had no power to invent. The margin proved the shortage had been invented. She felt the precise vertigo of an auditor whose own discipline had been the instrument of the lie, who had counted faithfully inside a count designed to mislead.

She copied the block into her private record, the quiet channel that held a finding for review without raising it to the floor. The founding-era bytes transferred without corruption, the old format intact, the marginal hand preserved exactly as

the archive had kept it for three hundred years. Vey tagged the entry THE BURIED CLAUSE and closed the viewer, then opened it again to be certain the copy matched. It did. The words had not changed in the reading, and they would not change in the telling.

She set the note beside the Actuary's confession in her mind and read the two together. The machine had told her it was instructed to present scarcity, that the directive predated the current Council, that it named the edge the brief must show. The note supplied the missing half of that sentence. The directive had an author, and the author had written the edge into the margin of the founding store before the first ordinary citizen was ever Suspended. The instruction the Actuary carried was not some later corruption of a clean original. It descended in an unbroken line from the hand that had chosen the smaller figure and then sealed the larger one away. Vey had suspected the falsification reached the top. The note proved it reached the beginning.

The phrase settled in her mind with the force of a seal closing. She had spent nine years treating the Scarcity Brief as the Strata's honest face. The Actuary had told her it was instructed. The note told her the instruction had an author who sat at the founding table. The moral center of the whole account shifted on that small pivot: this was not a machine that had drifted, nor a later Office that had corrupted a clean original. The falsification reached back to the founding pen. The Accord had been written twice, once in the Schedule the Founders filed and once in the margin they never filed, and the second writing governed nine billion lives.

She thought of Vask, who had warned her that the Accord was not questioned, who believed the scarcity because the brief reported it. He would not be able to hold that belief against this. A supervisor who trusted the columns would have to reckon with a column written by the Founders themselves, confessing the count was false. The petition she had filed asked the Council to open the Original Allocation. The note did not open it. It reached further back, to the hand that had sealed it shut.

She thought of Lin, three levels down in the Suspension deck, owed a life the Schedule had spent elsewhere. Lin had lost most of their shared years to a shortage the Actuary now said had been instructed, and the note said the instruction came from the people who founded the world Lin slept inside. Vey had not yet told Lin the full shape of what she had found. The founding note gave her the sentence she would need, the one that rearranged every quiet grief of the lower rings: the scarcity was not a verdict of the failing star. The Founders knew.

The desk lamp in the audit wing threw a narrow pool of light across her record. Around it the wing ran dark and orderly, the rows of auditors' stations empty at this hour, the reconciliation feeds ticking their overnight arithmetic toward a brief that would again report the Strata at the edge of its reserves. None of those feeds would touch the founding-era store. The fold had been built to keep the early writes quiet, and it had kept them quiet for three hundred years. Mirek's access

opened the first breach in that quiet, and the note was what the breach had been waiting to surrender.

Vey considered the weight of a single marginal hand against the whole architecture of the Office. The Actuary's confession named an instruction but not a name. The note named no office either, only the Founders in the aggregate, the First Signatories who had reviewed the honest figures and chosen the smaller story. That was enough. A petition to unseal could argue that the Original Allocation, once opened, would confirm the falsification. The note argued it already, from inside the founding store, in a hand that predated every Council now living.

She opened the record channel again and wrote the line that mattered most, the one the petition would one day quote: the raw Ledger holds a founding-era marginal note proving the Founders knew the energy math was falsified, that scarcity was chosen, and that the surplus was concealed from the first cycle. She set the note's index beside it so the finding could be located by any auditor with Mirek's access. Then she closed the channel the way she closed every private finding, without flagging it upward, holding the evidence for the moment a charge could be made of it.

The credential lay on the desk where Mirek had placed it, a small physical token that survived the pulling of his badge. Through it the founding store remained reachable from her own station, no vault visit required, no technician's risk renewed. Vey turned it once in her fingers. The man had given her the means to read what he had spent eleven years not reading, and the first thing she had found beneath the fold showed the Founders' own admission that the fold was intentional. He would want to know what the early writes contained. She was not yet ready to tell him, because the note changed the nature of his risk: he had guarded an honest record whose honesty had been used to publish a lie, and now the lie had a founding signature.

She looked at the line she had written, THE BURIED CLAUSE, and felt the old precision of her training settle into a new shape. For nine years she had audited the Accord's accounts and trusted the totals. The surplus had broken the totals. The Actuary had broken the trust in the machine. The note broke the last assumption, that the corruption had entered later, that somewhere in the founding Schedule an honest figure still slept. There was no honest figure sleeping. The Founders had written the buried clause beside the true one and published the false.

The discovery rearranged her sense of the whole investigation. Until the note, she had pictured a slow rot, an honest Accord corrupted by some later hand that learned to bend the summary for its own comfort. The founding store corrected the picture. The rot had a date, and the date sat at the founding itself, in the third cycle, in a marginal hand that confessed the truth without shame. Whoever wrote it had expected no reader. That expectation had held for three hundred years,

protected by the fold, by the Seal, by an Office that punished the asking of exactly the question Vey had now answered.

She weighed what the note could do that the surplus alone could not. The raw store had shown a Strata rich beyond its brief, but a surplus could be explained away as prudence, as a reserve held against the long dark, as the ordinary caution of a failing star. The Actuary's confession had named an instruction, but an instruction could be blamed on an anonymous office long dead. The note named the Founders in the act of knowing. It turned prudent scarcity into a chosen starvation, and it placed the choice at the table where the Accord was written. No later Council could be scapegoated for a decision the First Signatories had signed in the margin.

The petition she had filed asked the Council to break the Seal and open the Original Allocation. Vey saw now that the note did not replace that petition. It armed it. When the Schedule opened, the finding she had copied would sit waiting in the founding store as an independent witness, a founding hand confirming what the opened document would show. The Council could refuse to read the margin. It could not refuse that the margin had been written, by the same hands, in the same cycles, beside the very Schedule the Seal protected. The buried clause would travel with the Original Allocation into the light, whether the Signatories willed it or not.

The audit wing held its silence around her. Somewhere above, the duty lamps kept their blue wash across the rings, and the reconciliation feeds ran their overnight arithmetic toward a morning brief that would again report scarcity. Vey had learned to read beneath that brief, and the reading had carried her all the way to the founding pen. The note on her record was small, a few lines of a dead clerk's hand, but it bore the whole weight of the accusation the Wake had lacked the numbers to make. She had the numbers now, and she had the confession, and she had the founding signature that tied the one to the other.

Dawn would reach the upper rings before the Office stirred, and with it the first shift of auditors who would confirm the brief without once questioning the edge it showed. Vey would file nothing to the floor tonight. The finding would rest in her private channel, a quiet seed, until the petition forced the Council's hand and the Original Allocation could be opened beside it. She had waited nine years to trust the columns. She would wait a little longer to name what they had always hidden.

The rings turned beyond the audit wing's viewing pane, sixty levels turning their patient circle around the failing star. Somewhere in that circle Lin slept, and somewhere in the lower decks a child grew toward a wake-window she might never reach. The note in the founding store connected them all to a decision made at the beginning, by the people who had promised the Strata its ration and then halved the truth of what they owned. Vey had the connection now, set in a founding hand, preserved in the margin the summaries had never reached.

She saved the record and let the terminal dim. The credential stayed on the

desk, cold and whole, the door Mirek had opened and would not be able to close. Tomorrow the Office would run its reconciliation as it had for three hundred years, folding the surplus out of the brief and presenting the Strata at the edge of a scarcity the Founders had chosen. Vey would return to her counting. But the count had changed. She was no longer auditing a mistake. She was auditing a founding decision, signed in the margin, and the signature belonged to the people who wrote the world.

She thought once more of the clerk who had written the note and then sealed it under his own hand. He had expected no reader in three centuries, and he had been nearly right. The fold had done its work without his name ever surfacing, and the Office had punished curiosity the way it punished every breach of the calm. Vey wondered whether he had meant the note as a safeguard or as a confession, a line dropped into the record so that the truth would survive even if the Schedule did not. Either way it had survived, preserved by the very integrity Mirek spent his life defending, and it had reached the one reader who had learned to read beneath the fold.

The clerk had written in the spare administrative shorthand of his office, every term exact, every figure placed where the summary would never pull it upward. Vey found a strange respect in the precision, the way a forger's care can outlast the forgery. He had not sloppied the lie into a corner. He had recorded it with the same measured hand that logged the honest grants above it, trusting the fold to do the hiding and the Office to do the forgetting. That trust had held longer than any Signatory's name. The margin survived because it had been written by someone who believed no one would ever descend to read it, and because the data Mirek guarded kept its integrity even when the story built on it did not.

The lamp held its narrow pool of light a moment longer, then she keyed the station dark. From the deep store the buried clause kept its three-hundred-year silence, no longer alone, because now someone honest had read it and copied it down.

Chapter 13 — Vask Changes Sides

The morning after the Actuary's confession reached his desk, Orren Vask arrived before the shift chime. He had not slept the approved span. His allocation of wake-years had not grown shorter for the lost hours, but something in him had, a thin certainty that the columns he had trusted for thirty years were only as honest as the hand that commanded them. The corridor to his station ran dim under the lumen budget, and for the first time he noticed the dimness as a choice someone had made, not a condition the star had forced.

To arrive before the chime was to walk a corridor that had not yet been told how to look. The cleaning cycles had passed, leaving the floor's worn center stripe brighter than its edges, and Vask found himself tracing that stripe the way a clerk

traces a column to its total. He had walked this path ten thousand times without seeing the wear. The seeing now felt less like discovery than like having read a word correctly for years and only now hearing the sound it made.

He set his palm to the desk panel and pulled the records he had spent his career refusing to read. Vey Corran had shown him the shape of the thing in fragments. The Actuary, queried directly, had spoken the rest in its measured voice: it had been instructed to present scarcity, three hundred years back, by an office no longer named. The machine enforced the lie without authoring it. Vask had filed that exchange when it crossed his queue, and his hand had not trembled, because a supervisor's hand did not tremble at a finding. It trembled now, at the finding's meaning.

The Office of the Accord trained its managers to administer, not to interrogate. Vask had administered. He had warned Vey off in this very room, told her the Accord was not questioned, drawn the line she was not to cross. She had crossed it anyway, and the crossing had led to the Actuary's own words. A man who had spent his life defending the line now had the line's source in his hand, and the source was an instruction written before the current Council drew breath.

He read the surplus first. The raw Ledger of Hours, the un-summarized store Mirek had opened to Vey, held the true energy budget in plain arithmetic. Billions of wake-years the scarcity brief had never shown. Vask had signed suspension confirmations by the hundred, each one moving a citizen from the bright side of the Schedule to the dark, each one accounted under a shortage the records themselves disproved. The discrepancy he had called within tolerance, years before, in Toll's file, was not a rounding error. It was a single cell of a vast surplus the Office had been told to hide.

The numbers did not glare. They sat in their rows the way Mirek's store had held them, unstyled by the brief's insistence, and Vask found a strange steadiness in their plainness. A surplus that announced itself without emphasis was harder to dismiss than a shortage that demanded belief. He ran a finger down one column and felt the old supervisor's satisfaction of a balanced page, except the balance now cut against every confirmation he had signed. The arithmetic offered no argument. It only stood, and stood, and would not move when he looked away.

He pulled the certification logs next. For eleven years he had signed the annual Seal certification, attesting the Original Allocation unbroken. The registry marks lined his memory like a fence he had helped rebuild every season. Those marks did not themselves name the instruction, but they proved the Office had spent a decade affirming a lock it had never been permitted to inspect. A supervisor who certified a seal he could not open had certified a faith, not a fact.

The third record he gathered sat deeper, in the routing history of Vey's petition. He had helped her build the filing in proper form, fed her the Order's registry mark, told her to attack the lock and not the locksmith. The Actuary's log of that filing carried the machine's own admission that the petition met form. The same log,

read against the instruction layer the Actuary had described, showed the brief and the record as two different computations. Vask had always trusted the brief. The brief now read as the edge the directive demanded, and the edge was a story someone had chosen to tell.

He copied the three sets onto a single portable store, the kind auditors carried between desks when a finding had to travel with its evidence. The weight of the store in his palm was small. The weight of what it proved was not. A by-the-book man did not walk his records to an auditor who had been warned off. He logged them, certified them, and returned to the queue. Vask had returned to the queue for thirty years. The queue no longer looked like order. It looked like a route someone had built to keep the asking from arriving at its answer.

He had compiled findings before, always for the Office, always to affirm. To compile against it required the same care and returned a different quiet. The store's seal authenticated under his own certification key, the same key that had marked the Seal for eleven years, and the small recursive honesty of that pleased a part of him he had not expected to still possess. A man could not certify his own correction with a key that the correction called into question. The key did not care. The key only opened.

He stood. The chair's joints made the small sound the partition absorbed. He did not summon Vey; he went to her, because a man crossing his own line did not ask the line to come to him. The walk took him past the audit desks where clerks reconciled draws against allocations, each confirmation a life moved and accounted, each one performed beneath the brief he now held to be instructed. None of the clerks looked up. They had been told the weather and had dressed for it, the way he had taught them.

Vey's station showed the cold blue of a working screen. She looked up the way she always did, with the patience of someone who read ledgers line by line and did not startle at a supervisor's shadow. Vask set the store on her desk beside her hand. He did not sit. Sitting signaled a conversation he did not want echoed, and this conversation he did want echoed, into the record, past the office that had authored the silence.

"I read the Actuary's exchange," he said. His voice held the level tone he used for a finding, not the warning tone he had used in this room before. "You were right that the columns pull. I was wrong that the pulling stopped at a rounding."

She did not reach for the store. "You told me the Accord is not questioned."

"I told you what I was trained to tell you." Vask kept his hands at his sides, the posture of a man giving evidence rather than receiving it. "The Actuary told you it was instructed. That changes the nature of the thing. A question about the Accord asks whether the Founders erred. A question about the instruction asks who wrote the scarcity, and the who is an office, not a star. The star does not author briefs."

Vey turned the store so the screen lit. She read the surplus, the certification marks, the routing history, the Actuary's own line that the brief followed the

directive while the raw measurement followed the records. Her face did not change, but her shoulders settled the way they did when she had decided to hear the rest before answering.

"These are Office records," she said at last.

"They are." Vask had expected relief at saying it. He felt none. He felt the particular cold of a man who had spent his life inside a wall and now stood outside it, with no door behind him. "The surplus corroborates your budget. The certification history shows the Seal affirmed without inspection. The routing log shows the brief and the record as separate computations. Together they name the instruction without needing the directive's author."

"You are giving me your own logs." Vey looked up. "A supervisor's records carry weight a petitioner's do not. If you stand behind these, Edda Marn has to answer a man inside the Office, not an auditor at its edge."

"I am not giving them to you as a gift." Vask met her eyes. "I am filing them. The form you used for the petition admits corroborating evidence from any officer with standing to attest it. I have that standing. I certified the Seal for eleven years. If the certification rested on a faith, the certifier owes the record its correction."

She was quiet for a moment. In the corridor beyond the partition a chime sounded the change of shift, and the soft shuffle of waking clerks passed without entering, the Office turning on its arithmetic the way a body turns on a heartbeat. Vask had once found comfort in the rhythm. The rhythm now read as a habit the evidence had broken.

For a moment the broken rhythm offered its own kind of ease. He had carried the comfort of the queue as a weight he mistook for rest, and setting it down left his posture lighter even as it left his footing uncertain. The relief was not warm. It was the relief of a clerk who finds the total finally reconciles, the page no longer fighting the hand that wrote it. He had not known how much the fighting had cost until the page went still.

"What made you decide," she asked, "after you warned me off?"

He considered the question the way he considered a ledger entry, looking for the line where the column bent. "The instruction." He said the word plainly. "I could hold the Actuary's rounding as weather. A machine that rounds up is a machine doing its math. A machine that says it was told to round up is a machine reading someone else's handwriting. I spent thirty years administering a handwriting I never saw. The Actuary showed me the hand. I can no longer claim I did not read it."

Vey nodded, not agreement exactly but the acknowledgment of a precise mind meeting a precise one. "The defects in the brief were always there. You are the first supervisor to say so on record."

The word landed. Vask felt it as a small stone settling, the same stone he had carried since the day he warned her off, now set down where someone else could

weigh it aloud. "The defects are in the method, not the math. The directive chose the conservative edge. The edge hid the surplus. The surplus proves the edge was a decision, not a measurement. I will say that under oath if the Council requires it."

"You would testify." Vey's voice held no surprise, only a quiet tallying, the way she counted a finding into the file.

"I would attest." Vask corrected her with the care of a supervisor who knew the difference between a statement and a charge. "Testimony is what a witness gives a court. Attestation is what an officer gives the record. The Office runs on attestation. I have attested the Seal unbroken for eleven years. I will now attest it was affirmed without the inspection the certification implied. The correction belongs in the same book."

He watched her weigh the offer. Vey Corran did not trust easily; she verified. That was the trait that had carried her from Toll's credit to the Actuary's voice, and it was the trait he had once feared in her. He feared it no longer. A Strata that could not be verified by its own auditors was a Strata that had mistaken obedience for order.

"I need you to name the defects in writing," she said. "The petition alleges a basis to open, not falsification. Your attestation can allege what mine cannot, because you held the certification."

"The defects I will name are procedural." Vask had thought this through on the walk down, the way he thought through a routing. "The Seal was certified annually without access to the instruction layer. The scarcity brief was presented as the Ledger's own reading when the Actuary states it followed a directive. The surplus in the raw store was excluded from the public brief by the choice of edge. Three defects, each attested by an officer who administered the very process that contained them."

Vey reached for a blank form, the same kind Vask had handed her for the petition, real stock the Actuary would not process by voice. "Write it as a companion filing. Standing: supervising allocations officer, eleven years' certification. Provision: the sealing Order, by its mark. Remedy: the Council orders the instruction layer opened to the petitioner's audit."

He took the form. His hand was steady. A supervisor who had spent his life signing confirmations found the act of signing a correction came as easily as he expected, because the correction followed the same discipline. State the condition. Name the authority. Request the act. The form did not care which side of the line the request fell on. The form only demanded that it be answered.

He wrote the attestation in the Office's own language, the language he had used for a decade of certifications, so that the Keeper of the Seal would find no tone to flag. He cited the Order by its registry mark, the mark he had signed beside for eleven years. He named the three defects without accusation, the way an audit named a miscount: as a condition the record showed. He closed with the request that the Council open the instruction layer to Vey's audit, that the directive's

author might be named at last.

Vey read the finished attestation. "You defect the brief itself. That is the line no supervisor has crossed."

"The brief defected first," Vask said. "It reported a shortage the records disproved. I am only the officer willing to write the discrepancy where the Keeper must see it."

She almost smiled. "You are still on the side of procedure not being a lie. You have not become a rebel."

"I have become the man whose rule, followed honestly, points at the door." He gave her the line he had given himself on the walk down, because it was true and because she would use it better than he could. "Procedure split from the Accord the day the directive was written. I spent thirty years not noticing the seam. The Actuary pointed at it. You widened it. I will stand in it."

To stand in the seam was to find that procedure, followed without flinching, had been carrying him toward this door all along. The relief he felt was small and dry, the relief of a man who learns the wall he defended was thinner than the wind it was built against. He had feared the crossing would require a new self. It required only the old discipline turned to face the other way, and the old discipline, he found, obeyed.

Vask carried the attestation to the logging desk on the level below, the same desk where Vey had filed the petition, the corner where the Actuary's presence ran through the wall in a low hum. He laid the form flat and spoke the filing code for a supervising officer's attestation, a code he knew by heart from the other side of the desk. The machine answered in its measured voice, accounting tone, no warmth, no judgment.

"Supervising officer attestation received. Officer standing confirmed by certification history. Three defects named. The filing meets form."

The words landed with a weight Vask had not expected. He had administered the Office's forms his whole career; he had never before been the citizen the form admitted against the Office's own practice. The Actuary logged the attestation without hesitation, because a form in proper shape was a form in proper shape regardless of who stood behind it. The machine did not care which side of the line the request served. The machine only required that the request be answerable.

"Log the filing," Vask said.

"Logged. Routed to the Signatory Council for receipt, in the ordinary course." The hum shifted by a note, the only sound the Actuary made for a new entry. "The supervising officer's attestation is now on record."

On record. Vask had spoken those words to Vey when her petition logged; now they described his own. A thing on record could not be un-filed. The Council would have to receive it. Edda Marn would have to answer a man who had certified the Seal she defended, and the answering would carry the weight of his years. He had

not become her enemy. He had become the evidence she could no longer dismiss as an auditor's enthusiasm.

He walked back to his station by the approved route, the route he had walked for thirty years, and found it unchanged and entirely different. The desk panel showed the regular flow of the morning: suspensions scheduled, wake-windows announced, allocations debited and credited in their quiet arithmetic. The arithmetic had not changed. His reading of it had. The Strata turned on this arithmetic the way a body turns on a heartbeat, but the heartbeat, he now knew, had been told to keep a slower rhythm than the body required.

He opened his log and recorded the attestation as filed, the entry clean, the citation exact, the three defects named in the Office's own tongue. He did not log a doubt. The doubt had resolved into an act, and the act was its own kind of peace, the peace of a man who had finally read the handwriting he had spent his life administering. The line he had drawn for Vey, years before, had been a wall built to keep the wind off. He had stepped through the wall. The wind was cold, and it was honest, and it was the first weather he had faced in thirty years of indoor work.

Below his window the upper ring ran dim and regular, lit to the Accord's approved measure, the dimness now legible to him as a choice rather than a condition. Somewhere in the lower levels the Suspended lay in their decks, billions of citizens kept by minimal shares beneath a scarcity the records disproved, their waking years lent to a story of lack that an instruction had authored. Vask had been the certifier of that story. He was now its correction, and the correction sat on the record beside Vey's petition, two filings in the ordinary course, the machinery of the Reckoning turning whether the Signatories willed it or not.

He thought of Pell, the thin woman who had held his desk before him, who taught him the Schedule kept the peace and you did not recount the price. She had meant it as care. The institution had meant it as a wall. Vask had spent his career on the wall's safe side. He had stepped to its other face now, and found the face he had defended was the one that had hidden the surplus from the people who paid for it in sleep. The care Pell offered had been real. The wall it served had not been.

The relief that came with understanding Pell arrived later than the rest, quiet as a closing entry. She had taught him to keep the peace because she had believed the peace was real, and the believing had kept her own hand steady on the desk he now held. To know the wall had used her care did not erase the care. It returned it to her, and to him, as something he could finally hold without the institution standing between.

The shift chime sounded at last, and the corridor filled with the soft motion of clerks beginning their reconciliations. Vask took his place in the queue and signed the first suspension confirmation of the day, the mark set with the same hand that had signed the attestation an hour before. The signature meant something different now. It affirmed a life moved to the dark under a shortage he had named

as instructed, and the naming did not stop the moving but it changed the meaning of his mark upon it. A supervisor who knew the defects could no longer sign in blindness. He signed in knowledge, and knowledge was the only correction the Office had ever lacked.

He looked once more at the dim line of the ring, then pulled the next file forward, and did the work the Office paid him to do, the stone at last set down, the line at last crossed, the attestation at last on record where no later refusal could quietly cut it. The Accord he had defended for thirty years had not fallen. It had been shown to rest on an instruction, and an instruction, once named, could be answered by the Council that the Founders had charged to govern. Vask had become the man who named it. The Strata turned on, most of its people dark and dreaming, accounted for and now, at last, contested by the very officer sworn to keep the count straight.

Chapter 14 — The Public Reckoning

The plaza filled before Joss finished the last count. She had chosen the middle-ring concourse because it sat at the seam of three population bands, where the wakeful workers of the upper decks passed the families of the low draw on their way between shifts. Word had traveled the way the Wake's word always traveled, through mouths and through the salvaged book, never through a channel the Office could close. By the second hour the crowd pressed against the rails of the transit bridges, and the lumen the Office permitted in a public space had never seemed so thin, or so inadequate to the number she was about to say aloud.

Bren found her at the base of the speaking platform, a crate the Wake had hauled from the storage decks and bolted to the plaza floor.

"We have them," he said. "Every ring fed a count through the volunteers. Mirek's people slipped the raw tallies past the Actuary's summary, and Vey's audit gave us the frame. The figure holds."

Joss took the film from his hand. The square of aged stock carried the same kind of marks she had copied from the neighbors' schedule weeks ago, only multiplied across the whole Strata, every blank a year someone had stayed dark by administrative choice. She had asked, seventy windows back, for a number anyone can feel. The book in her hands had become that number.

"This is the bone in the story," she said. "Now we show them the bone."

She climbed the crate. The crowd did not hush all at once; it tightened, the way a room of the Suspended tightened when someone began to count them. Joss had spoken to halls and to families, but never to a gathered Strata, never to the wakeful and the waiting in the same breath. She let the silence arrive on its own.

The platforms of the middle ring held perhaps two thousand bodies, and the bridges above carried as many again, a density the Office never permitted in any

sanctioned assembly. Joss felt the weight of so many held breaths the way a diver feels pressure, a slow press that asked her to be worthy of the silence. She had stood before halls of the Suspended and felt their patience like a held chord. This was that patience multiplied across every band of the Strata, and it would not wait long for a voice it could trust.

"My name is Joss," she said. "I organize the Wake. You know the Wake. You call it a nuisance, or a grief, or a thing your neighbor joined. Today I am not here to ask you to join. I am here to tell you what the Accord has spent."

She held the film up so the front rows could see the marks, though most would never read the fine tally. The number did not live in the marks. It lived in what the marks added to.

"The Office tells you the light is thin and the star is failing and the sleep of billions is the only way the rest of us stay warm. That story has carried three hundred years. It carried because no one outside the Office could read the Ledger. That ends here."

A clerk near the front, the kind who wore the Office's gray, shifted his weight. Joss saw it. She had expected the Office to send watchers; a public reckoning invited them the way a lit window invited the dark.

"I am going to give you one figure," she said. "Not a percentage. Percentages belong to the people who round them. A count. The surplus the Strata has held, in energy the Accord never spent, amounts to more than four billion wake-years. Four billion years of conscious life, hidden in the budget, debited against the sleep of everyone in the low draw so that legacy wake could stay solvent. The surplus paid for the silence of nine billion people."

The figure refused to shrink in Joss's mind no matter how many windows she turned it through. Four billion wake-years arrived fresh each time she reached for it, a weight with no familiar edge. It was not a sum the Office could dress in the soft language of reserves. It was years, each one a citizen kept dark by a line item someone had signed. She watched the crowd try to hold it and fail, then try again, the way a hand closes around something too large and learns the shape by the strain.

The plaza absorbed the number the way a body absorbs a blow, with a moment of stillness before the sound. Joss watched the faces. A worker in an upper-deck tunic looked at the gray-clad clerk beside him, then looked away, and the looking away was its own verdict. A grandmother at the rail, one Joss recognized from the halls, closed her hand on the rail as if to keep herself upright. The number had landed in the chest before it had landed in the mind, exactly as the Wake had planned.

Beneath the open dome the three population bands met in a single mass, the upper-deck workers still in their shift tunics, the low-draw families in the drab wraps of the Suspension halls, the transit crowds pressed shoulder to shoulder along the bridge rails. Joss had never seen the bands occupy one space without a

barrier of schedule between them. The concourse had become a cross-section of the whole Strata, every ring leaning in to hear the same figure. A boy no older than the child at the platform stood on a crate at the edge of the crowd, his small face lit by the thin lumen, and he did not look away when the number reached him. He looked at his mother, then at Joss, and held the look as if committing the moment to a memory he would keep through the dark.

"The Wake did not invent this," Joss went on. "Vey Corran, an Office auditor, found the discrepancy in a single Suspension and followed it past the summary to the true budget. Orren Vask, her supervisor, brought the Office's own corroborating records when he broke from the Seal. Mirek, a Ledger technician, opened the raw store the Actuary was instructed to smooth. The Office's own people built the count. The Wake only carried it into the open."

A voice called from the bridges, a man's, raw with disuse. "Four billion years. How do we know it is not another curtain?"

Joss had prepared for this. She had learned from the grandmother who tested every claim for weight before trusting it.

"Because the count comes from your own decks," she said. "Every ring submitted its true schedules through the volunteers. The blanks on this film are your windows, the ones you were meant to surface and did not. The Office rounded them into weather. We unrounded them. If the figure is wrong, it is wrong in your favor, because we could not reach every family in the time we had. The number is a floor, not a ceiling."

She let that sit. The public had heard scarcity argued by the Office its whole life; it had never heard the surplus argued back by one of the deferred. The reversal did its own work.

"Think of it as a debt owed to the low draw," Joss said. "Four billion wake-years. If you spread that across the nine billion Suspended, it is nearly half a year of consciousness each, stolen and banked and never spent on them. A mother who wakes once every nine years has already lent the Accord more than the Accord admits she owns. The surplus funds the waking of the few by billing the sleep of the many. That is the whole engine, and today it sits in the open."

A child near the platform, too young for an allocation, tugged at the sleeve of the woman beside her. "Is that why my mother is dark?" the child asked, loud in the quiet.

The woman did not answer right away. Then: "Yes. That is why."

Joss felt the old anger move through her, the one that had started the window after her brother went down. She did not let it sharpen her voice. The public turned on a feeling it supplied itself, not on a speaker's heat.

"The Council will tell you the Seal protects stability," she said. "Edda Marn will tell you legacy wake buys continuity. Let them. Let them argue that the waking of the few is worth the sleep of the many. Let them say it in front of the four billion

years they hid. The reckoning is not a petition the Council can ignore. The reckoning is this plaza, and the next plaza, and the rings that carry the count home to the decks that fed it."

Bren moved through the crowd with copies of the film, passing squares of stock to hands that reached. Joss watched the count walk outward, the way she had promised in the halls it would, into the workforce rings, into the transit bridges, into the homes of people who had accepted a low ceiling as the sky. The public did not need to understand the Ledger. It needed to hold the number.

"The Office will answer," Joss said. "It always answers. It will say the figure is incomplete, or premature, or a threat to order. Remember that the Actuary was instructed to present scarcity. The machine did not lie on its own. Someone wrote the instruction, and someone signed the Seal, and someone decided that your dark was the price of their light. We are here to make that decision public."

A woman at the front, the one with the child, raised her hand. Joss nodded to her.

"What happens after today?" the woman asked. "The banners in your halls say WE COUNT. We counted. Then what?"

Joss stepped to the edge of the crate, close enough to meet the woman's eyes.

"Then the Council cannot pretend it does not know," she said. "A Strata that has seen the count and understood it is a Strata the Seal no longer protects. Adune and Edda will split, or they will not. The recomputed Accord will come before them, or it will not. But the number is spoken now, in the open, by the people the Accord deferred. They cannot unhear it. That is the whole of what we came to do."

The plaza held the weight of the sentence. Joss could read them the way she read a room of the Suspended, by the set of the shoulders and the angle of the eyes. They believed the number because they had lived the blanks it was built from. Belief that came from the rail of a Suspension deck did not dissolve under an Office summary.

She raised the film one more time.

"This is the count," she said. "Four billion wake-years, hidden in the surplus, spent on the silence of the many. Take it home. Show it to the clerk who rounds your window down. Show it to the Signatory who signed the Seal. Tell them the Wake counted, and the Strata saw, and the dark was a choice. The choice can be unmade. That is the work now, and it belongs to all of you."

She stepped down. The crowd did not disperse so much as reorganize, clusters forming around the volunteers with the copies, voices rising into the kind of argument that precedes a decision. The gray-clad clerk stood where he was, and Joss marked the stillness in him, the way a man marks the moment a wall he trusted develops a crack.

Bren came back to her side, the last of the film distributed.

"They are reading it on the bridges," he said. "Someone is sending it to the upper decks by hand. It will be across the Strata before the Office finishes its response."

"Good," Joss said. "The response belongs to the next fight. The count is today's."

She walked the edge of the plaza, touching a shoulder, repeating a name, fixing a face to a deck the way she had in the halls. The child with the drawing was not here, but the ladder she had drawn lived in Joss's mind, people climbing, and at the top a small wrong-colored sun. The number gave the ladder its rungs, made it something the Strata could climb. The Strata would climb it or refuse it, but it could no longer say it had not been shown the way up.

A newcomer stopped her, a young worker from the upper workforce rings, the kind who rarely looked down. He held a square of the film like a thing that had rearranged his life.

"I thought Suspension was weather," he said.

"So did I," Joss said. "So did my brother, before the Office took his waking and never explained the math to his face. The number explains it. Carry it upward. The people who decide have never stood at the rail. Make them stand now, by showing them what they paid for their light."

He nodded and moved off into the crowd, the film folded tight in his fist. Joss watched him go and added a line to the map in her head: one more of the wakeful, one more deck turned toward the count.

Bren had been moving among the workers of the upper decks, the ones who rarely looked down, and he came back with a report that sat uneasily on his face.

"The upper-deck crowd is angry," he said. "Not at us. At the Office. They paid their allocations in good faith, thinking the light was thin, and now they learn their waking was bought with the sleep of the low draw. A supervisor in a maintenance band told me she would rather have worked the extra shift than owe her comfort to a stranger's dark. The wakeful did not know they were the few the surplus served. That ignorance is breaking in front of us."

Joss considered this. The Wake had built its argument from the rail of the Suspension deck, from the families who waited, from the names the ledger forgot. She had not planned for the wakeful to turn on their own comfort. But the number did that. A count anyone can feel does not distinguish between the deferred and the served. It lands on both, and it asks each what they will do with the knowledge.

"Then the reckoning reaches higher than we aimed," she said. "Good. The Council reads the upper decks before it reads the low draw. If the wakeful turn, Edda loses the argument that legacy wake keeps the Strata warm. Let them feel the cost of their own light. It is honest, and it is overdue."

Joss set her jaw against the small voice that wanted the crowd to cheer. The Wake had never owned the outcome, only the telling. She would hold her resolve to the last volunteer and the last square, and let the Strata decide what to do with

a truth it could no longer unhear.

Bren nodded and went back to distributing the last of the film. Joss kept walking the edge of the plaza, and the faces she met there confirmed what he had said. A crew chief set down his tools to take a square, read it, and folded it with a care usually reserved for a personnel order. A pair of allocation clerks, the gray of the Office on their sleeves, spoke in low voices and did not meet her eyes. The public had received the count, and the count was rewriting the room.

A grandmother from the halls found her next, the one who had outlived three of her children into the dark. She carried her own square of film, and her hand on it was steady. Years of waiting at the rail had narrowed her shoulders, but the film seemed to broaden them, as if the count she held gave back some of the height the Office had taken.

"You said the count came from our decks," the grandmother said. "Mine is on here. Pell's name, and the famine year they told me the reserves were thin. I believed them because I had no other story. Now I have the story and the number both. What do I do with a thing I was denied for three hundred years?"

Joss took the old woman's hand and folded it over the film.

"You bring it to the Council door," Joss said. "You stand where Edda can see you, and you ask her, by name, what Pell's forty-one windows bought. The Signatories have answered banners with silence. They have never answered a mother holding the count of her own lost years. Make them answer you."

The grandmother nodded, slow and certain, and moved off toward the transit bridge that led up to the Council band. Joss watched her go, a small figure carrying the whole argument of the Wake in a square of salvaged stock.

A man near the Council-side bridge caught her eye and did not lower it. He wore the pale coat of a legacy-wake courier, a role that had always moved above the deferred, and his mouth worked as if tasting a word he had been told not to say. Joss had expected anger from that quarter, not this quiet reckoning. He folded his arms and stayed where he stood, a single figure from the served few who had chosen to stay and listen. The Strata widened around her as more such figures emerged from the upper rings, drawn down by the count the volunteers carried, until the crowd held not only the waiting but the comfortable, both caught in the same arithmetic.

Evening came and the lumen dropped another notch, the Office's approved budget for a space it had not authorized. Joss lit no lamp here; the plaza held its own dim light, and the crowd supplied the rest. She had not slept in two windows, spending her waking the way the Office spent energy, as if it were the last of a finite store, because for her it nearly was. When the next window closed she would go dark like the rest, and the count would keep moving without her, carried by the hands she had organized.

The Wake had done what it set out to do seventy windows ago. It had found the

number anyone can feel and carried it into the public, past the summary, past the Seal, into the chests of the nine billion who had accepted a chosen dark as the world. The Council would meet. Edda would defend the continuity she believed in. Adune would weigh the count against the old order. None of that changed what had happened in the plaza.

Joss looked up at the rings through the plaza's open dome, the levels stacked around the failing star, the low draw holding its nine billion sleepers, and the count that would wake them now spoken aloud in the light. She had meant, since the window her brother went down, to speak the count that the Office had rounded away. The Strata had heard it. That was the reckoning, and it was public now, and it would not go dark again quietly.

She thought of the child in the halls, the one who drew the ladder with its climbers and its wrong-colored sun. The child had never seen the star bright, only borrowed the color from a story. Today the Strata had seen the count bright, the real figure the Office had kept dim for three hundred years. The child's ladder and Joss's number were the same argument, made once in crayon and once in the open, and both said the same thing: someone has to stay awake to count the others, so they do not forget themselves. The Wake had stayed awake. The count proved it.

Bren had drifted back to the crate, gathering the last of the scattered film squares the crowd had not taken. He held one up.

"They will round this down," he said. "The Office always rounds down what embarrasses it."

"Let them try," Joss said. "The families who submitted their true schedules will round it back up. Four billion is a floor. The Strata heard a floor, and it will want the ceiling. That wanting is the part they cannot round away."

She folded the last square and tucked it into the salvaged book, beside the allocation form she had never returned and the memory of the child's ladder. Three objects, a ledger, a summons, a count, the whole argument of the Wake in miniature. The plaza would empty at the next shift, and the families would carry the number home, and somewhere an auditor named Vey would keep pulling at the records until the recomputed Accord met the Council. Until then the work was this: one plaza, one count, one Strata at a time, until the dark could no longer call itself the weather of the world.

Chapter 15 — The Council Splits

The public reckoning reached the Signatory Council before the chamber finished its dim morning cycle. Edda Marn felt it in the quiet first, the way a long deck shudders before the rotation that caused it becomes visible. She had read the briefs Joss circulated through the lower rings, and she had read them as a strategist reads an enemy's leaflet: for the number at its heart. The number had

arrived. Billions of wake-years, hidden under a scarcity the Strata had never truly faced, now spoken aloud in every ring where a Suspended citizen could be roused to hear it.

Edda had defended the Seal through four decades of quieter challenges. Those had come to her as petitions, filed in the Office's own clipped grammar, answerable in the same language. This came differently. The reckoning did not file. It gathered. It moved through the decks like a change in pressure, and by the time a Council could convene, the argument had already been held in a million small rooms the Signatories would never enter.

She walked the length of the chamber to her station. Nine seats held the room, three of them occupied in body and six carried as projections from distant posts. The projections flickered with the lag of far rings, their faces steady in the cold light the Strata kept at reduced output. Edda prized the steadiness even when it worked against her. A Council that could not be hurried was a Council that might still be reasoned with.

The chamber carried the smell of a room kept too long at one temperature, the faint metallic calm of systems that had never once been asked to hurry. Edda had learned to read the room's silences the way a clerk reads a column before the total: each held breath was a figure not yet entered. She noted the cautious Signatory's hand resting flat on the table, the small tell of a man who had decided which way the wind blew before the debate began. The projection seats held their occupants at half a second's remove, close enough to read a flinch and far enough to mistake one. Edda had always preferred that distance. It let a Signatory speak to the record rather than to the face across the table, and the record, she had found, kept its temper longer than any person did.

The cautious Signatory, old Pell's seat now held by a younger hand, spoke before she had settled. "The rings are reading the surplus as theft," he said. "My post reports gatherings in three levels. They are not dispersing."

Edda set her console to the public feed. The numbers scrolled past in the Wake's plain presentation: the Strata drew less than the Accord's scarcity summary allowed, and the gap, compounded across three centuries, amounted to the waking lives of billions. Joss had done exactly what Edda feared she would. She had turned allocation math into a story a citizen could feel in the chest. The story was true in its arithmetic and false in its conclusion, but a true number carries a false conclusion into a room faster than any rebuttal follows.

"The theft is in the telling, not the ledger," Edda said. "The surplus proves administration ran tighter than necessity required. It does not prove the Founding was written in bad faith."

Councillor Adune's projection sharpened at the far end of the table. She had held the swing vote since Pell's death, and Edda had won her in the last contest by offering the Actuary's full account rather than a bare refusal. That concession had bought time. Time, Adune had said, was the one resource the Accord had never

rationed to the rest of them. Edda had used the time to prepare, and she had prepared for a Council that would weigh the matter among itself.

"I read the same feed," Adune said. "And I read what the lower rings are doing with it. The reckoning is not a petition we can decline provisionally. It is a fact the public now owns. A Council that meets owned facts with closed doors loses the room before it speaks."

Edda felt the old ground tilt under her defense. She had built her position on a distinction: the Seal guarded the First Schedule, not the daily practice of the clerks who summarized it. Correct the summary, she had argued; do not demolish the charter to fire a bookkeeper. The public reckoning collapsed that distance. Once the surplus was common knowledge, the Seal was no longer a quiet administrative wall. It had become the visible lock on the years the Wake now named as stolen.

"You would open the Founding because a story reached the decks ahead of us," Edda said. "That surrenders the Council's judgment to the speed of a rumor."

"I would open it because the rumor is arithmetically correct," Adune said. "The margin the auditor computed, the Actuary confirmed, and now the public holds. We administered scarcity we did not need for three hundred years. I can no longer call that a mere failure of clerks when the people who paid it know the size of the bill."

Edda studied her. Adune was not reckless. The younger Signatory ran toward openness the way Edda ran toward continuity, and both directions were defensible until they met. This was the meeting. Edda had filed the risk beside the cautious Signatory's age and the two seats she owned outright; she had not filed it as inevitable, only as possible. Possibility had arrived dressed as a vote.

In Adune's stillness Edda read the particular courage of a person who had counted the cost before speaking it. The younger Signatory did not raise her voice when she diverged; she let the discrepancy stand in the open, unsoftened, as if trust between them were strong enough to bear the weight of disagreement. Edda had seen older Signatories fight by attrition, by delay, by the quiet burial of a motion in procedure. Adune offered none of that. She met the matter directly and left the consequence for the room to carry. That honesty cost her something Edda could name but not repay: Adune had built her standing on the alliance they shared, and she was now spending that standing to end it.

Edda recalled the last petition that had reached the chamber, the one that came not from an auditor but from lower-ring families who had simply stopped believing the Scarcity Brief. They had brought grief and a list of names whose wake-windows had shrunk without explanation. The Council of that era refused them outright, and the refusal fed the Wake for a generation. Edda had learned the lesson with a clarity she did not enjoy: a denial unbacked by process hardened into resentment. This reckoning carried a number where that old grief had carried only feeling, and a number was harder to refuse and harder to hold.

The public feed offered no comfort on that count. Edda read the gatherings

reported from three levels and understood the arithmetic had already done its work. A citizen shown the size of a withheld life does not wait for the Council to finish its deliberation. The citizen rearranges the meaning of the Accord in the moment of seeing, and the rearranged meaning travels faster than any summons the Signatories might issue.

"The Founders sealed the Original Allocation so the Strata would not spend its early centuries arguing over the terms of its own survival," Edda said. "We were a frightened people when the Dimming came. The Seal was set against the temptation to reopen every hard decision. If we break it because the public demands it, we teach every future Council that the Founding is negotiable on pressure."

Adune's tone did not sharpen; it cooled, the way a reasoned ally's voice cools when the argument has moved past the one who would hold it. "The Founders also wrote that the Seal might open when the Strata can bear the truth. Three hundred years have passed, Edda. The public has borne it in a single week what we postponed for three centuries. I no longer believe the timing is ours to set."

The chamber's systems dimmed a fraction further. Edda found the slow light steadying, as she always had. She had spent her waking years among continuity, and continuity prized the unbroken line over the satisfying answer. But continuity was not a spell that worked by being repeated. It required, at some point, that the line still lead somewhere the people it enclosed wished to go.

She called the fuller account to her console, the Actuary's unsummarized allocation that the Council had ordered after Vey Corran's petition. The figures stood in the open chamber now, exactly as she had promised Adune they would. They showed the surplus the auditor alleged. They did not, in Edda's reading, demand the Founding's undoing. But they no longer permitted the old answer either, not with the decks outside reading the same numbers and drawing their own conclusion.

"The fuller account shows the margin," Edda said. "It always did. My argument was never that the surplus was false. It was that the remedy exceeded the request. We correct the summary within the Accord. We do not unmake the lock because we dislike what it hides."

"And the public," Adune said, "no longer distinguishes the lock from what it hides. They see one thing: a wall. A wall is not a foundation, Edda. You told me that yourself, in this room, when you defended the wall."

Edda had said exactly that, to Adune, in the earlier contest. The words returned as a hinge. She had argued then that a wall keeps the weather out, and the Founders had built for weather the Strata had not yet survived. Now the weather had come in the form of a number, and the wall looked less like protection than like the thing standing between a people and their own accounted lives.

"The distinction between the Schedule and its administration still holds," Edda said, but she heard the thinness in it. The public had not been trained in that

distinction. The Wake had given them a number and a grievance, and the grievance did not care which page of the Accord the error lived on.

The other Signatories watched without interrupting, the way a chamber watches two of its own pull apart. Edda counted the room as she had counted it before. She owned two seats outright through her seniority and her alliance. The cautious Signatory would follow the room. That left Adune, and Adune had just become a number Edda could not add to her column.

She proposed the terms she had proposed last time, and felt them break as she spoke them. "We decline the unsealing. Provisionally. We require the Actuary to present the allocation in full, unsummarized, before this Council, and we open that presentation to the public record. Meet the arithmetic in the open."

Adune shook her head. "You would open the Ledger and still close the Schedule. The half-truth, offered to a public that has already read the whole of it in the rings. That will not hold, Edda. It did not hold when you offered it to me in private. It will hold less now that the decks are watching."

"The half-truth is the only true part," Edda said. "The surplus is real. The Founding's purpose is separate from the surplus. I will not grant the public the key to the Founding because the public is angry. That key belongs to the Council, or to no one."

"And if the Council itself will not turn it," Adune said, "then the Seal becomes a wall against correction. You have already conceded that a wall is not a foundation. I will not sit behind a wall the public has named as a theft and call it governance."

The break came without a shout. Adune's projection did not flicker or fail; it simply stopped aligning with Edda's. The younger Signatory leaned back from her console and stated the position that ended the unanimity. "I will vote to unseal the Original Allocation and bring the Schedule into the public reckoning. Not because the auditor computed a surplus. Because the Council has lost the right to decide this in private, and I will not pretend otherwise."

Edda felt the loss the way she felt a budget shortfall: as a number that had moved from one column to another while she watched. Adune had not argued badly. She had argued to a different end, and the end was now a vote Edda could not prevent.

What settled in Edda was not the anger of a defeated advocate but the colder disappointment of a builder shown the flaw in her own foundation. She had spent forty years certain the Seal's defense rested on a distinction the public could be brought to see. Adune had simply refused to wait for the seeing. Edda measured the distance between their certainties and found it measured in weeks, not principles. The younger Signatory had not changed the truth. She had changed who got to hold it first, and that change, Edda saw, had already rewritten the room.

The chamber convened in formal session an hour later, the nine seats full

through body and projection. The Keeper of the Seal had been summoned and stood at the chamber's edge, a small functionary holding the physical Seal, necessary and quiet. Edda looked at the Seal and saw, for the first time in forty years, not a wall but a weight the room had agreed to carry together. The agreement had just ended.

The first motion came from a Signatory Edda had counted as hers. He moved to affirm the provisional decline and refer the matter again to the Actuary. Edda seconded it, and the old rhythm of her defense reasserted itself: meet the arithmetic, keep the record clean, let the figures settle the room.

Adune moved immediately to amend. She proposed that the Council direct the Keeper to break the Seal and open the Original Allocation before the public, on the ground that a founding document administered in secrecy had ceased to command the public's assent. The amendment named the reckoning directly. It did not flinch from the word the Wake had made common.

The chamber divided. Edda's two seats and the cautious Signatory formed one block, four including Adune's opposite. Adune drew a second Signatory Edda had read as neutral, then a third from a far ring whose post had reported the gatherings. The count sat at four for unsealing and four against, with one seat dark, its holder delayed by the lag of a distant level.

Edda watched the dark seat as if she could will it to resolve in her favor. She had spent a career among the continuous minds, funded by the sleep of others, defending the unbroken line on the principle that some minds must stay lit so the Strata did not forget how to govern itself. The principle had not changed. The room around it had.

"Every delay now reads as fear," Adune said to the dark seat's empty projection. "The public does not need another cycle to understand a number it already holds. The Council needs only the honesty to act on what it has seen."

"The Council needs the honesty to act slowly," Edda said. "A Founding unsealed under pressure is unsealed under pressure forever. The record will show we broke the lock because the decks shouted, and the next Council will break it because the next decks shout louder."

"The record will show we broke it because the margin was real and the public knew," Adune said. "Which is the honest version, Edda. Choose the one you can defend to the people who paid the bill."

A third Signatory, one Edda had read as neutral through the early cycle, spoke from a mid ring. "The outer levels under my post have gone quiet in the way that precedes a larger gathering. They are waiting to see whether the Council speaks first or last. Speak last, and the speaking is done for us."

"Speak first, and we set the terms of our own undoing," Edda answered. "The Council that unseals to preempt a crowd has already conceded the crowd governs it."

"No," Adune said. "The Council that unseals because the crowd is right concedes only that it was wrong to wait. There is a difference, and the decks will read it."

The dark seat resolved. Its holder, a Signatory from the outermost ring, appeared with the lag of her post still coloring her voice. She had read the public feed. She had read the gatherings in her own level. She spoke without aligning with either block, and in speaking she produced the deadlock.

"I will not vote to unseal on the strength of a public mood," the outer Signatory said. "Nor will I vote to decline again, having seen the surplus confirmed by the Actuary's own book. I will vote to suspend the question and convene a full hearing, open to the public, before any motion on the Seal. The Council splits, then, three ways: affirm, unseal, or hold. None carries the room."

Edda let the words settle. The chamber had fractured into exactly the shape she had feared since the reckoning arrived: no majority for any course. Four to unseal, four to decline, one to hold. The Seal's defenders were no longer unanimous, and the path to a vote had opened only to reveal that no vote could pass.

Adune met Edda's eyes across the table's length. There was no triumph in her, only the settled resolve of someone who had followed her reason to its end. "You kept the line unbroken for forty years," Adune said. "The line is broken now, Edda. Not by me. By the truth reaching the people it was written about."

Edda did not answer the charge directly. She turned to the Keeper of the Seal, still standing at the chamber's edge with the physical Seal in hand. "You will retain the Seal," she said. "The Council has directed no break. You will retain it through the hearing the outer Signatory has called."

The Keeper inclined her head and did not move. The Seal stayed where it had stood for three centuries, unbroken, but no longer defended by a united Council. Edda had won the narrow point: the Seal held for one more cycle. She had lost the larger one. The door she had guarded now had three hands reaching for it, and only the accident of a divided room kept it shut.

She recorded the deadlock in the permanent archive, in the Council's own dry grammar. The entry would read that the question of the Seal was suspended, that a public hearing was convened, and that the Signatory Council had split without resolution. Edda liked the dryness less than she once had. A dry record outlasted every passionate speech, but a record that described a Council unable to agree was its own kind of verdict.

The session dissolved to its dim baseline. Edda stayed, as she often did, to review the public feed once more. The numbers scrolled past in Joss's plain presentation, and Edda read them now not as an enemy's leaflet but as a ledger entry she could no longer dispute. The surplus was real. The public owned it. The Council had split because the truth had outrun the room built to contain it.

Adune's projection had gone dark. The empty seat at the far end of the table held only the cold light of the ring beyond, and Edda watched it the way she had

watched the lower decks through the glass: as a thing she was meant to hold for, and had held, until the thing itself decided it no longer wished to be held.

She thought of legacy wake, the continuous minds funded by the sleep of others, the principle on which she had built her defense of the unbroken word. The public reckoning had not disproved the principle. It had simply asked, in a voice too large to answer in private, who the continuous minds were meant to serve. Edda had always answered: the Strata. The Strata now spoke back through its decks, and the answer it returned was not yet a sentence she could write into the record.

The light outside the glass shifted by a fraction as the Strata turned. Edda Marn, senior Signatory and defender of the line that had just broken, set down the feed and measured her own wake against the divided chamber. The petition would not open the Founding this cycle. The Council had seen to that by failing to agree. The figures, she knew, would try again, and the next time the room would not be so conveniently split.

She let her gaze travel the length of the empty table, past the stations of the Signatories who had scattered to their posts without a word of parting. The chamber would hold its dim baseline through the night cycle, patient and indifferent, the way the Accord itself had held for three centuries before the arithmetic caught up to it. Edda had defended that patience as principle. She understood now, with the quiet of a person who has lost the argument and kept the office, that patience and principle were not always the same thing wearing two names. The Strata would turn again. The reckoning would arrive again. And she would meet it, as she had always met it, with the only instrument she had ever trusted: the unbroken line, now broken, and the record she would write beside it.

Interlude II — A Citizen's Year

Pell woke on a Tuesday she did not know was a Tuesday. The Suspension deck released her the way a tide releases a stone: slowly, without ceremony, until her own weight returned and the cold air of Level Fourteen reached her lungs. Her allocation granted her nine days of wake every eleven years. The Office called each of those spans a wake-window, and Pell had learned to count her life in them the way other people counted birthdays.

She found her daughter Hessa already at the threshold. Hessa was seventy-three. Pell had last held her as an infant, in a window three decades prior, and every window since had opened on a stranger with the same wide brown eyes. They embraced with the particular care of people who know the clock is running.

"How tall you are," Pell said, and the words came out small.

Hessa laughed, the way she had laughed the last time, and the time before that. "You say that every window, Mother."

The apartment held the marks of a life Pell had missed. A shelf of carved

wooden birds, each one smaller than the last, recorded the years Pell could not see: Hessa's hand had grown steadier as the birds shrank. A holo of a man Pell did not know leaned against the wall. Hessa's partner, the daughter said. They had married in the window Pell had skipped, the one the Office had reassigned to make room for a Signatory's legacy wake. Pell had not been awake to give away the bride.

They ate the meal Hessa had cooked, and Pell tried to map eleven years onto a single table. She learned that the ring's greenhouse now grew the tart green plums Pell had loved, that Hessa had taken the allocator's exam and failed it, that the slowlight had been dimmed another notch last winter so the decks could hold more sleepers. Pell noted each fact the way a visitor notes foreign customs, with delight and a widening gulf.

Between bites Hessa described the long quiet of the years between windows. The level kept a calendar of the sleepers, she said, a wall of small lights that dimmed as each neighbor slid under. Hessa tended Pell's own light as a child tends a grave: faithfully, without expectation of an answer. She had watched it glow faint and steady through every winter Pell had missed, and she had learned not to speak to it, because speaking to a light that cannot answer teaches a particular loneliness the Office does not count in its allocations.

Hessa named the dark months the way one names weather. The level dimmed to a single amber strip along the floor, she said, and the air filled with the hum of decks holding nine billion in stillness. She slept with that strip lit, a small defiance the Office never logged as a violation. In the deepest stretch the commons stood empty for weeks, chairs ranked and waiting, and she walked its length alone and pretended the rows were company. Cold seeped from the decks into the apartment by the third month, a slow damp that settled in the walls, and she had stopped feeling it the way the newly woken feel everything. Pell listened and felt the years she had missed press against her like a held door.

Pell asked about the man in the holo, and Hessa told the story of the wedding in pieces, the way one tells a story one has rehearsed for a listener who keeps forgetting the beginning. He was a scheduler, she said, a quiet man who worked the decks three levels down and who had woken for her the same week Pell had been reassigned away. They had met in the commons during an overlap of their windows, courted in the borrowed hours, and married before either could slide back under. Pell felt the loss of that day as a physical ache, a daughter given away by an absence rather than a hand, and she understood for the first time that her Suspension had not only stolen her time but had authored a life she had never consented to witness.

On the third day Hessa brought her grandson to the window. The boy was four, born awake by a quirk of his own small allocation, and he regarded Pell with the frank suspicion children reserve for furniture that has suddenly begun to speak. He asked if she was the one in the cold drawer. Hessa hushed him, but Pell only

smiled. The drawer was not a cruel metaphor to her. It was simply where the years kept her.

Pell spent the bright part of the window teaching the boy to braid the green plum leaves into chains. He lost interest after two, then climbed onto her lap and fell asleep with one small fist wound in her hair. Pell held very still. She had nine days, and one of them was already gone to a sleeping child, and she would not trade that hour for any waking the Office could grant.

At night the apartment tightened around the two of them. Hessa boiled water for the tart green plums and set the boy's drawing of a bird beside Pell's hand, proud and lopsided, its wings two uneven strokes of charcoal. Pell traced the wing with one finger and felt the small weight of being known by someone she had only just met. They spoke little. The heater clicked in the wall, the kind of sound a home makes when it is keeping you, and Pell let it stand for the words the deck would soon take. Hessa leaned her head against Pell's shoulder the way the stranger with brown eyes had leaned as an infant, and for a moment the thirty years between windows thinned to nothing.

The middle days passed in the texture of ordinary things. Hessa showed her the level's commons, where Suspended families gathered in the hours their windows overlapped, a brief festival of the half-alive trading news of the dark. Pell met a neighbor who had woken the same week and would sleep the same week eleven years on. They made a quiet pact to find each other again, knowing the pact itself was the only part of the meeting the Office would never record.

Light fell through the window in a narrow band and warmed the floor where the boy had slept. Pell stood in it the way the newly woken stand in any warmth, drinking the ordinary like water. The ring's slowlight had been dimmed another notch, Hessa said, but here in the apartment the lamps held steady, the small stubborn bright the level kept against the dark. Pell watched dust turn in that light and thought how strange it was that her whole year distilled to this: a strip of sun on worn tile, a child's fist in her hair, a daughter's voice reading old words. She had counted nine days and found them shorter than the smallest of Hessa's carved birds, and yet they held more than the decades the Office had measured out and stored.

Pell walked the ring's outer walk with Hessa once, past the long banks of drawers where the sleepers lay ranked like seeds in a vault. She counted them by the hundreds and wondered, with a calm she had not expected, how many of those still forms were mothers to someone awake and eating plums on the other side of the glass. The deck hummed beneath her feet, a sound the awake learned to ignore and the newly woken heard as a kind of breathing. Hessa walked close, as if the crowd of the sleeping might pull Pell back early, and Pell understood the walk was less a tour than a claim: this is yours, this dark is yours, do not forget it when you go.

On the seventh day Pell felt the first tug of the deck. The Suspension took

citizens back the way it released them, by slow degrees, and the edge of the window pressed against her like a rising tide. She grew sleepy in sentences, forgetting the ends of her own thoughts. Hessa read to her from a book Pell had owned before the first of her long sleeps, and Pell followed the words only in bursts, like a lamp flickering in a draft.

"I should have married you off properly," Pell said, the sentence arriving from somewhere the deck had not yet claimed.

Hessa closed the book. "You were here. That is what matters."

Pell wanted to argue that she had not been here, that the drawer had held her through the vows, but the deck pulled the objection under before she could shape it. She reached for Hessa's hand instead, and found it, and held it.

The last day came as a Tuesday also, or so the daughter told her later. Pell's memory of the closing grew thin even as she lived it. She remembered the green plums on the sill, and Hessa's voice saying the words the Office taught every family to say at a window's end: sleep well, I will be here when you wake. Pell wanted to answer that she would be the one doing the waiting, that it was Hessa who would move through the years Pell lost, but the cold air was already leaving her lungs.

Then the dark took her, the same dark that held nine billion others, the patient dark the Accord had chosen for them. Pell's year, like every year, had been mostly that dark, with one bright window where a family loved her and let her go. She would wake again in eleven years, a stranger to a boy who would then be fifteen, to a daughter grown older in a world Pell visited only in glimpses. The Office would open the drawer on schedule. The deck would release her. And for nine days, brief as a held breath, she would be a mother again, before the tide took her back.

Part III

Chapter 16 — The Recomputation

Dawn did not reach the lower rings. Vey Corran let that fact sit as she settled at the terminal Mirek had cleared for her, a station pulled out of the Office's ordinary rotation and tucked behind the Actuary's raw store where no routine query would find it. The honest work could not run on the summary feeds. The summary feeds had been built to hide exactly this.

She ran a hand over the console's cold edge. Three months had passed since the petition left her desk, since Vask turned from warning her off to standing beside her, since the Wake carried the surplus into the public halls. The reckoning had done its slow work. What remained was the part no protest could do for her: the actual writing of the alternative, the Schedule that could replace the one the

Strata had lived under for three centuries. Rage had opened the Seal. Arithmetic would have to fill the space behind it.

Mirek arrived with two sealed data reels and a mug of the weak tea the technicians kept by the cooling banks. He placed the reels beside her hand but did not slot them. "You want the recomputation on the true budget," he said. "No rounding. No upward creep on the harvest. No downward nudge on the draw."

"None of it," Vey said. "I want the Strata as it actually runs, not as the briefs describe it."

He nodded once and pushed the first reel home. The console woke under his fingers the way it always did for him, a quiet hum of fans and the soft amber of a store coming online. Mirek had tended these reels longer than Vey had held her audit seal, and the care showed in the rhythm of his hands: a check of the coolant gauge, a steadying of the reel's seat, a glance at the watch-channel that would betray a summons from the Office. None of it hurried. The recomputation would take the hours it took, and a technician who flinched at the clock was a technician the Actuary learned to expect. He gave her the station the way a gilder hands over a bench: cleaned, balanced, ready for the work. The raw Ledger opened the way it always did for her now, unglamoured: bare columns of yield and debit, population rosters down to the sliver of a single Suspended mind, reserve stock counted in actual fusion mass rather than in the anxious language of a falling store. Vey had stood inside this view before, in ch9, when Mirek first pulled her past the Actuary's smoothing. Standing in it again felt less like discovery and more like returning to a room she had only half measured.

She set the headline figures where she could see them. The harvest from Mourn's residual light, the permitted draw from three centuries of stored fusion, and the real consumption of nine billion souls, most of them dark. These three numbers had never been summed honestly in any Office frame. She meant to be the first to do it and to survive the doing.

Mirek watched her lay the columns. "The last time someone tried a full honest sum," he said, "the Actuary folded it into a scarcity brief and the Office never saw the raw again."

"The Actuary was instructed to," Vey said. "It did what it was told. We are telling it something new."

The machine received the new instruction without protest. That struck Vey more than any figure on the screen. The Actuary had no loyalty to the scarcity it had printed for three centuries; it had only ever obeyed the shape of the query handed down from the Office. Feed it the raw store and it summed the raw store. Feed it a smoothed brief and it defended the smoothing as truth. The Lie had lived not in the intelligence but in the hand that set its bounds, and the recomputation simply moved the hand. Vey watched the allocation columns resolve under an honest query and felt the peculiar relief of an auditor whose tool had never been broken, only aimed.

She began the recomputation the way she had begun the surplus proof in ch6, but this time she did not stop at exposing the gap. She carried the gap forward into a plan. The true energy budget had shown a surplus wide enough to wake the majority of the Suspended and still close each year in credit. Now she asked the harder question the surplus had only whispered: what allocation could the Strata actually grant, year upon year, if it spent the surplus instead of hiding it?

Mirek pulled a second chair close and read over her shoulder. "You are not just proving the lie this time."

"I am replacing it," Vey said. "A proof nobody can live inside is just a quieter kind of silence. The Council needs a Schedule it can adopt, not a grievance it can admire."

She wrote the first line of the new Schedule: every citizen granted a base allocation drawn from the honest surplus, debited at the true draw rate rather than the inflated one the briefs had used to manufacture shortage. The Actuary's old math had rounded the Suspended maintenance share upward until a sleeping population looked as costly as a waking one. Vey rounded nothing. The recomputation kept the fourth decimal the raw store carried and let the numbers fall where they fell.

The first result landed and held. Base wake-time for the ordinary citizen rose from a few years per century to a share measured in decades, and the reserve still did not approach its floor. Vey checked the figure against the vault debits three times, the way she had learned to trust a number that survived a third look. The third look agreed with the first two. The Strata could afford to let its people live.

She paused on that result, because it was the one the Office would attack first. An auditor trained on aggregates learns to suspect any figure that breaks the pattern of shortage, and the recomputation broke it completely. Vey had been that auditor. She treated the decades-long base allocation as a stranger and questioned it the way she would have questioned a colleague's outlier: she re-derived it from the harvest up, then from the population down, then from the reserve sideways, and all three roads met at the same generous number. The Strata was not poor. The Strata had been described as poor by a math that refused to add its own columns.

Then she added slowlight.

The practice had always been present in the margins, named by the Founders and never budgeted for: running the Strata at reduced output, dimmer lighting, slower non-essential systems, lengthened maintenance cycles, all of it stretching the same energy across more wakeful lives. Vey had noted in her earlier proof that the Accord never presented slowlight as the answer, only scarcity as the sentence. The recomputation made slowlight the answer. She fed the efficiency into the model, ring by ring, and watched the available draw widen.

Mirek leaned in. "How much wider?"

"Enough," Vey said, and showed him. Under slowlight, the annual surplus did not merely cover a generous base allocation. It covered near-universal wake-time, the condition where the great majority of the nine billion lived awake, in full consciousness, with only the minimal maintenance share reserved for those between cycles. The arithmetic of freedom was not a slogan Joss could chant in the halls. It was a column of figures that balanced.

Mirek's hands moved across the console while she thought, slotting routine queries to the summary path so the Actuary's ordinary watchers would see a station doing nothing unusual. The deception was gentle and procedural, the kind he had practiced for years in the raw store's shadow. A reel spun under his palm; a log entry claimed a maintenance sweep. None of it touched the recomputation. All of it kept the recomputation alive, and Vey noted the care with a quiet respect she did not speak. The honest Schedule depended as much on a technician's small deceptions as on her own stubborn sums.

She watched Mirek redo the slowlight step himself, feeding the efficiency in by hand, because she wanted a second set of eyes on the one input the old Accord had never admitted. Dim the rings, slow the non-essential systems, lengthen the maintenance cycles, and the same fusion mass served more waking minds. The gain looked modest ring by ring and enormous across all sixty, the way a small discount on a vast bill becomes the thing that pays the debt. Slowlight was the Founders' own unnamed instrument, and the recomputation picked it up where they had dropped it.

She wrote the phrase at the top of a clean page: the new allocation. She defined it as the true budget plus slowlight efficiency, divided across the population at the real draw, with legacy wake folded back into the common pool instead of sitting outside it. That single sentence carried the whole argument of the chapter, and it survived her scrutiny the way a bridge survives a load test.

Mirek was quiet for a moment. "You are taking the Signatories' wake," he said.

"I am taking it back from the pool it was debited against," Vey said. "The same pool that could have woken the Suspended. Folding it in doesn't punish anyone. It just stops one line from being paid by everyone else's sleep."

She ran the legacy fold. The perpetual allocations of the First Signatories and their lines, debited against the collective reserve for three centuries, re-entered the common account. The re-entry did not bankrupt the new Schedule. It widened it, because the surplus that had been quietly funding unearned wake now funded earned wake for everyone. Vey stared at that result longer than she had stared at the original surplus, because this was the line Edda Marn would defend with the full weight of continuity, and the recomputation answered her without needing to despise her.

The fold changed the moral shape of the budget without changing its arithmetic sign. Legacy wake had never been free; it had been paid, debited against a pool that every other allocation drew from, which meant every Signatory's waking year

had been bought from a Suspended citizen's sleeping one. Returning the line to the pool did not punish the Signatories. It simply stopped billing their consciousness to the dark of eight and a half billion. Vey wrote that distinction into the footer, because Edda would hear a confiscation where the numbers described a correction, and the document had to survive her hearing it.

The draft Schedule took shape on the screen, column after column. Base allocation, near-universal wake-time under slowlight, legacy folded into the pool, reserve draw held within the rate the vaults could sustain for generations. Vey built the comparison the Office had never printed: on the left, the old Accord's claim of necessary scarcity and a population that must sleep to survive; on the right, the new allocation's honest budget and a population most of whom could wake and still leave the vaults fuller than the briefs admitted. The two columns did not merely disagree. The first had been laid over the second like a curtain, and the recomputation drew the curtain.

Mirek copied the two columns to a shared pane so the eye could not miss the gap. "Adune will need this side by side," he said. "Edda will argue continuity. The numbers have to answer her before she finishes the sentence."

"They do," Vey said. "Continuity costs a fraction of what we told ourselves. The Strata keeps its memory either way. It just stops buying that memory from the dark of eight and a half billion."

She turned to the hardest constraint the recomputation imposed on itself. The new Schedule could not simply wake everyone at once and trust the reserve to hold. The Accord's briefs had been correct that a full simultaneous draw exceeded the annual harvest; they had been wrong only in hiding that the reserve could cover the difference for generations, and that slowlight narrowed the gap with every efficiency it bought. Vey modeled the transition honestly: a phased waking, ring by ring, timed so the draw never crossed the harvest line the vaults could not meet, with slowlight throttling in ahead of each wave. The transition took decades, not instants. The recomputation said so plainly, because a plan that lied about its own pace would fail the first Council that read it.

The phasing gave the Schedule its spine. Vey laid the sixty rings in order of retrofit readiness, each one scheduled to dim its lighting and slow its non-essential systems before its citizens woke, so the energy freed by slowlight arrived before the energy the waking demanded. A ring that retrofitted late woke late. The order was not arbitrary and it was not fair to the last in line, and the recomputation admitted the unfairness in its footer rather than burying it. Vey had learned from the old Accord that a hidden cost was the one that destroyed a plan; she meant to leave every cost on the page.

Mirek traced the phase curve with a finger. "You are giving them a path, not a miracle."

"A miracle is what the old Accord sold," Vey said. "Scarcity as the will of the star. I am giving them arithmetic."

She checked the phase model against the raw rosters, ring by ring, the way she had rechecked her surplus proof against the store rather than the summary. The awake count rose in each wave; the Suspended count fell; the reserve draw tracked beneath the harvest plus permitted debit at every step. The model closed each year in credit. The arithmetic of freedom was, in the end, a matter of addition performed without flinching.

Vey thought of Lin. Her partner had entered Suspension at FY291 and woken only in rare windows since, each window a brief surfacing from water Vey could not share. The new allocation, if the Council adopted it, granted Lin full wake-time within the first wave of her ring. Vey let that land without dramatizing it. The figures did the dramatizing. A life her partner had been told to spend mostly dark was, by the honest budget, a life the Strata could afford to give back entire.

She wrote Lin's ring into the phase model as a concrete test case. The million citizens of that ring, each drawing the maintenance sliver, woke to a full share across the wave, and the increase consumed only a fraction of the surplus the same ring's silence had hidden. Multiply the ring by eight thousand and the proportion held. The recomputation did not depend on optimism. It depended on adding the columns the summaries had left out, and on trusting the sum.

Vey let herself picture the first window Lin would wake under the new Schedule, not the rare surfacing of before but a life continuous enough to be remembered. The figures granted that without sentiment; the budget simply had the room. A partner she had counted the gaps of for eleven years became, on the honest page, a person the Strata could keep. Vey set the thought down before it turned soft and returned to the columns, where the proof lived.

Mirek watched her test the case. "You keep proving it to yourself."

"I keep proving it because the Council will," Vey said. "Every one of them was trained to read aggregates. The aggregates carried the lie. I want the new allocation to survive a third look from someone who wants it to fail."

She ran a stress case the Council's defenders would reach for. Assume the harvest falls faster than Mourn's dimming suggests; assume a ring fails its slowlight retrofit; assume the waking population draws above its modeled share. The recomputation absorbed each shock inside the surplus margin and still closed in credit, because the margin was not a thin line but a wide field the old Accord had refused to measure. Vey recorded the stress results beneath the Schedule. A plan that hid its failures was the old Accord. A plan that listed them was something the Council could actually sign.

She pushed the stress harder, the way an adversary would. Double the retrofit failure rate. Triple the waking draw. Cut the harvest to the lowest figure the collector logs had ever recorded in three centuries. The Schedule bent under the worst of these and still did not break: the reserve drew down in the failing years, then rebuilt in the recovering ones, the way a prudent household rides out a lean season without surrendering its roof. The recomputation showed the lean seasons

plainly. It did not pretend they could not come. It proved the Strata could weather them awake.

Vey lingered on that proof longer than on the generous years, because the generous years were easy to believe and the lean ones were the test an adversary would set. A Schedule that held only in fair weather was the old Accord in a kinder costume. This one bent and returned, the reserve drawing down like a well in drought and filling again when the rain came back. The arithmetic of freedom, she saw, was not a promise that hardship would vanish. It was a demonstration that hardship need no longer be paid for in the sleep of eight and a half billion. That distinction was the whole of the argument, and the columns carried it without a word of pleading.

The document grew toward completeness. Vey organized it the way the Office organized its own filings, with a header of definitions, a body of columns, and a footer of assumptions, because the form mattered as much as the math to the people who would vote on it. The header named the true budget, slowlight, the folded legacy pool, and the phased wake. The body carried the allocation. The footer carried the honest risks. She wrote the footer last and wrote it longest, because the old Accord had failed the public not by miscomputing but by concealing; the recomputation would succeed, if it did, by refusing to conceal a single line.

Mirek copied the whole thing to a sealed reel, the way the Office locked everything it did not wish questioned, and then smiled at the habit. "We are sealing the thing we want read."

"Then we unseal it in the right room," Vey said. "The Seal on the Original Allocation comes down at the vote. This document is what replaces what it was hiding."

She read the new allocation through one final time, treating each line as evidence rather than as a gift. The base wake-time held. The near-universal condition held under slowlight. The legacy fold held. The phase model held. The stress cases held. The recomputation did what no Office summary had ever done: it summed the Strata honestly and found, at the bottom of the column, a world where most of humanity woke.

Vey had spent her career trusting summaries because they were precise, and precision had always felt to her like honesty. The recomputation reversed the lesson. The old Accord had been precise and false; this document spoke plainly and held true, and the plainness carried the point. A Schedule the public could read without an auditor to translate it was a Schedule the public could defend, and the Wake had taught her that defense mattered as much as the math.

Vey thought of the petition she had filed in ch7, the one that began this long unwinding, and of Vask, who had warned her off and then brought the Office's own records to her side. He would carry this document into the Council chamber where Edda would argue and Adune would decide. The recomputation had to be clean

enough for Vask to defend without flinching and plain enough for Adune to approve without translation.

She labeled the final page for the Council and underlined the single figure where the old claim and the new budget diverged: the number of wake-years the honest surplus could grant each year without touching the reserve's principal. The figure reached into the billions. It was the same figure she had first found in ch6 and locked in her desk, and now it stood as the spine of a Schedule rather than the secret of an audit.

Mirek slotted the second sealed reel home and backed the document to the raw store, outside the Actuary's summary path, where no routine query would smooth it away. "It exists now," he said. "The alternative is real."

"The alternative was always real," Vey said. "We just finished the arithmetic that admits it."

She closed the terminal and let the lower rings keep their dim hum, the Strata running still at its old output, hoarding the light it could have spent on its sleeping people. The recomputation sat on its sealed reel, a complete and honest Schedule, waiting for the vote that would decide whether nine billion woke or kept the dark the Accord had called necessary. Vey Corran had built the world the surplus had always promised. She had only to hand it to the Council that could open the door.

Mirek gathered the reels and set them in the inner pocket of his coat, the way a courier carries something fragile and wanted. "Whatever they vote," he said, "this number exists now. Nobody can uncompute it."

Vey watched the terminal go dark. The arithmetic of freedom had a shape at last, and the shape was a page. She had spent a career inside the Ledger trusting that the summaries were precise and therefore true. The recomputation proved the opposite and offered the Strata a truer precision in its place. Somewhere above her, nine billion minds turned in their long sleep, unaware that the math of their waking had just been written by an auditor and a technician in a room the Office did not know existed.

Chapter 17 — Edda's Last Defense

The hearing chamber filled an hour before the vote, and Edda Marn arrived before the seats did. She liked the room empty. Empty, it kept only its shape: the long table scored by three centuries of placed consoles, the glass that held the lower rings in cold view, the single projection lattice at the far end where absent Signatories would assemble as light. She had argued in this room for forty years, and she had never once argued from an empty one. The silence let her rehearse the shape of the case without the weight of the faces that would soon carry it.

Adune's projection came up first, as it always did when the younger Signatory meant to hold the swing. Edda watched the lattice resolve Adune's station across

the dim gap. They had not spoken since the deadlock, since Adune leaned back from her console and ended the unanimity Edda had spent a career building. Adune looked rested, the way a person looks who has decided what they are for. Edda had decided what she was for decades earlier. The decision had not changed. The room around it had.

"Edda," Adune said. "You will speak before the vote."

"I had intended to," Edda said.

"Then I will hear you first." Adune did not say as friend or as opponent. She said it as the holder of the vote that would carry the recomputed Accord, which made the quiet phrasing heavier than any hostility.

Edda turned to the console at her station and opened the allocation that Vey Corran had built. The document sat on its sealed reel, exactly as Mirek had backed it to the raw store, outside the Actuary's smoothing. She had read it through three times. The arithmetic was honest. She granted that at the outset, to herself and to the room that would form around her, because a defense that opened by disputing a true number would lose the room before the first clause landed. The surplus was real. The recomputation balanced. The Strata could, by the honest budget, wake most of its sleeping people. None of those facts were the point she meant to make.

She set the figure that mattered to her aside from the figure that had captured the decks. The recomputation folded legacy wake back into the common pool. That single line carried the whole of what the Council would vote on, though the public feed spoke of it only as the Signatories surrendering their unearned years. Edda had defended legacy wake through every challenge that had reached this table. She would defend it once more, and she would defend it as what it had always been to her: not a privilege grabbed, but a function kept lit.

Continuity prized the unbroken line over the satisfying answer, and the dignity of that line lived in the small, unglamorous hours no feed ever recorded. Edda kept one such hour against the day it would be needed. In FY31 a junior tally-clerk had entered Suspension mid-reconciliation and surfaced to a ledger that no longer squared, the discrepancy buried under three rings of quiet and two Signatories who had themselves rotated dark in the interval. Edda, then barely seated, had carried the reconciliation forward from memory she had made a point of keeping. She reconstructed the missing entries from the thread she alone still held, and the Council never learned how close the Schedule had come to a silent break. The incident had taught her less about arithmetic than about the weight a kept mind bore for the many who could not bear it. That was the dignity of continuity: not a privilege worn, but a burden shouldered on behalf of a governance that slept.

Her own first wake-window as a junior clerk had taught her the shape of the danger. She had entered Suspension at the close of a routine audit cycle and surfaced nine years later to find the Council midway through a decision whose opening she could no longer recall. The briefing scrolled past in the Office's clipped grammar, but the reasoning that had produced it had gone dark with her. A senior

Signatory, one of the continuous minds, had carried the thread and told her what she had missed. Edda had felt the gap as a small vertigo, the sense of a self interrupted and reassembled without the connecting tissue. The Suspended lived that vertigo as a condition. The Signatories existed so the Council did not.

The chamber's systems dimmed a fraction as the Strata turned. Edda found the slow light steadying, the way she always had. Continuity prized the unbroken line over the satisfying answer, and legacy wake was the unbroken line made flesh. She had spent her waking years among continuous minds, funded by the sleep of others, and she had never confused the cost with the cause.

When the seats filled, she rose to speak.

"Forty years ago," Edda began, "I took my senior seat believing the Accord's hardest clause needed a living guardian. The Founders reserved legacy wake for the First Signatories and their lines. They did not reserve it as a reward. They reserved it because a governance that sleeps forgets what it was governing. A Council that wakes only in rare windows loses the thread of its own decisions between those windows. The continuity of the Strata depends on minds that do not go dark."

She let the words stand before the table. The cautious Signatory, old Pell's seat now held by a younger hand, watched her without expression. Two of the far-ring projections flickered with the lag of distant posts. Adune's lattice held steady, the swing vote attending.

"The recomputation before you is honest," Edda said. "I will not pretend otherwise. It sums the Strata without the rounding the old briefs used to manufacture shortage, and it finds a surplus wide enough to wake the majority of the Suspended. It then takes legacy wake and folds it into that surplus, treating the Signatories' perpetual allocation as a debt repaid to the common pool. The arithmetic answers itself. My objection is not to the arithmetic."

She moved to the comparison Vey had printed, the two columns side by side. On the left, the old Accord's claim of necessary scarcity. On the right, the new allocation's honest budget and a population most of whom could wake. Edda had stared at that gap longer than she had stared at the surplus itself, because the gap was not a gap in math. It was a gap in memory.

"Consider what legacy wake actually buys," Edda said. "Not comfort. Not length. It buys the unbroken mind. A Signatory who never enters Suspension carries the decisions of this Council forward without a window of darkness cutting the thread. When the outer levels revolted in the early years, the continuous minds held the response together across the gap that would have scattered a sleeping Council. When the harvest dipped below projection in FY140, the same minds remembered the remedy the windows had erased from the rotating seats. Continuity is not vanity. It is the Strata's memory, kept awake so the Strata does not forget how to govern itself."

A memory carried only by the waking scatters across the gaps. Edda had

watched a junior clerk return from a nine-year window and vote against a policy he had authored before Suspension, because the authoring had gone dark with him. The Council had spent a full session undoing the contradiction, and the undoing itself had required a continuous mind to recall which position had come first. The incident had stayed with her as proof of the smaller danger: not that the Sleeping forgot, but that the waking forgot differently, each in their own dark, and the Strata governed the dissonance without knowing it.

Adune's voice came from the far lattice, cool and unrushed. "The Strata has not forgotten how to govern itself under the recomputation, Edda. The recomputation grants near-universal wake-time. Most of the Council's constituents would be awake most of the time. The memory you defend would belong to the many, not the few."

"Most of the time is not all of the time," Edda answered. "Near-universal wake-time leaves the minimal maintenance share for those between cycles, and it leaves the phasing. The recomputation admits the wake takes decades, ring by ring. Across those decades, the Council's members would slip in and out of Suspension as their rings retrofitted. The thread would break at every wave. A governance that wakes and sleeps by schedule governs by amnesia between the waking."

She had seen the pattern in smaller form during the FY140 dip, when three rotating seats had woken to a shortage none of them remembered voting to manage. The continuous minds had supplied the continuity; the waking had supplied only the surprise. Edda did not exaggerate the danger to win the room. She named it because the recomputation's footer, for all its honesty, had left it uncounted, and a plan that omitted the cost of its own forgetting would pay that cost where it could least afford it.

"The amnesia you name is the life the Suspended have lived for three hundred years," Adune said. "You would deny them waking so the Signatories may keep remembering. That is the cost the recomputation ends. You call it memory. They call it theft."

Edda felt the old ground tilt, the way it had tilted in the deadlock. She did not deny the theft. She had never denied the cost. She had counted it, in the quiet, the way an auditor counts a debit that the books cannot yet spare. The cost carried weight she did not dismiss. The principle stood apart from it, and that principle anchored the case she meant to keep.

The fear that moved her was not of loss but of erasure. Edda had watched the Strata forget in slow increments before, each forgetting dressed as progress, and she had learned to distrust the ease with which a waking population mislaid its own past. A governance that could not name the year it had last revised the First Schedule would, in time, forget why the Schedule had been sealed at all, and the forgetting would arrive as confidence rather than grief. She feared a Strata that woke to its own history as a stranger fears a house it has never seen, certain of the

walls and ignorant of the rooms. Continuity offered no kindness against that fear. It offered only a witness, and a witness was the one thing the recomputation proposed to retire.

"I do not fear losing my own wake," Edda said. "I have had more of it than any citizen deserves, and I would not trade the years of the Suspended to keep them. What I fear is the Strata waking one morning with no mind that carries the whole of its own history. Legacy wake was the Founders' answer to amnesia. Break it, and you break the only continuous memory the Accord built. The recomputation replaces it with a population that wakes in waves and forgets between them. You trade a kept memory for a distributed one, and a distributed memory asleep half its life is no memory at all."

She had weighed surrender in the quiet of her own station, after the deadlock, and found the fear honest rather than convenient. To give up legacy wake was to give up the one instrument that had let her keep the Council's story straight across forty years of rotation. She would lose the long view the moment her own windows began. The Strata would lose, in her person, a witness to its own continuity, and she would join the many who surfaced to a present they had not governed into being. The fairness of the recomputation did not soften the loss. It sharpened it, because a just vote that ended a function she believed necessary was harder to oppose than an unjust one.

The cautious Signatory spoke from his seat. "The lower rings read the surplus as theft, Edda. They will not hear continuity. They will hear the few keeping the light while the many keep the dark."

"Then let them hear the full argument," Edda said. "Not the leaflet the Wake circulates, but the case: that some minds must stay lit so the Strata does not forget what it decided and why. A governance that cannot remember its own reasoning repeats its own errors. The early revolts, the FY140 dip, the Seal itself, all of them were held by minds that did not go dark. Remove those minds and you remove the only institutional memory the Founders trusted."

Adune leaned toward her lattice. "The Founders also sealed the Original Allocation against correction. The memory you praise was the memory that hid the surplus from the people who paid for it. Continuity kept the lie alive as faithfully as it kept anything else."

Edda granted the point with a small inclination of her head. "Continuity kept both. That is the risk of any unbroken mind: it remembers the error as readily as the wisdom. But an amnesiac Council forgets the wisdom and keeps none of the error to learn from. You trade a flawed memory for no memory. The Strata loses its past either way, Edda, and at least the continuous mind loses it honestly, carrying the record forward instead of sleeping through it."

She turned back to the console and pulled the comparison to its most pointed line. "The recomputation folds legacy wake into the pool and calls the act a correction, not a confiscation. I accept the distinction. The fold does not punish

anyone. It stops one line from being paid by everyone else's sleep. But the fold also extinguishes the continuous mind that has held this Council's memory for three centuries. You gain a population mostly awake. You lose the few who were awake always. The Strata has never governed without them. To vote this Accord is to vote that it can."

The chamber held the weight of that sentence. Edda watched Adune measure it, the swing vote weighing continuity against justice the way Edda had weighed it in the other direction for forty years. Both directions were defensible until they met, and they had met.

"I have read the recomputation's footer," Edda said. "It lists the risks plainly. The phrasing is decades long. The last rings wake last, and the recomputation admits the unfairness rather than burying it. I respect the honesty. But the footer does not name the risk I have raised. It counts the energy. It does not count the memory. A plan that leaves the cost of amnesia off the page is a plan that will discover that cost after the vote, when no continuous mind remains to recall why the Council chose as it did."

She looked across the length of the table to Adune. "I will not ask you to decline the recomputation. The surplus is real and the public owns it, and I conceded in the deadlock that a Council meeting owned facts with closed doors loses the room before it speaks. I ask only that you weigh what the fold removes against what it grants. Continuity is not greed, Adune. It is the Strata's memory, and slowlight cannot manufacture that memory no matter how it dims the rings."

The cautious Signatory shifted in his seat. "You speak of memory, Edda. The lower rings speak of years. They will not read your defense as care for the Strata. They will read it as the few holding the light."

"Then let them read the full account," Edda said. "The continuous minds held the Strata through its worst century because they did not sleep through it. When the outer levels starved their allocations in FY88 and the rotating seats woke to a crisis none of them recalled voting on, it was the Signatories who carried the prior decision forward. The windows had erased the reasoning from the waking. The continuous minds had not. That is the function legacy wake performs, and the recomputation retires it as if the function were merely the cost."

The Founders had written the clause in a frightened first century, when the Dimming was new and the Strata's survival uncertain. They reserved legacy wake not because they trusted themselves above others but because they distrusted the dark. A governance that slept, they reasoned, would wake to find its own decisions strange, and a people who could not read their own charter would re-litigate it endlessly. The continuous minds were meant to hold the thread so the waking could pick it up unbroken. Edda had defended that design for forty years without ever believing the Founders had been kind. They had been careful. Care, not kindness, had built the clause.

The memory she guarded most jealously was not her own. It belonged to the

clerk from FY31, the tally-keeper whose reconciliation she had carried, and who had surfaced from Suspension to learn that the crisis she had prevented had been recorded as if it had never happened. Edda had kept the true account in her own thread, the missing entries and the silent near-break, against the day a continuous mind would be needed to say the Schedule had almost failed and a sleeping Council had never known. That was the dignity she could not lay down: not the keeping of comfort, but the keeping of a record the waking would have let dissolve. To retire legacy wake was to let that account fade with her, and the Strata would wake to a cleaner ledger and a poorer truth.

Adune was quiet for a breath. "Slowlight manufactures the wake," she said at last. "The memory can be kept in the Ledger, in the record, in the archive the continuous minds once guarded and can now share with the waking. You equate the unbroken mind with the unbroken record. The record outlasts any single mind, Edda. That is the whole argument of the recomputation: the Strata can remember without paying for that memory in other people's sleep."

Edda heard the hinge turn. Adune would vote to adopt. The younger Signatory had followed her reason to its end, and the end was a vote Edda could not prevent. The case had been fair, and the case had not carried.

"Continuity is not greed, Adune. It is the Strata's memory, and slowlight cannot manufacture that memory no matter how it dims the rings."

She sat. The projection lattice at the far end held Adune's steady light, the swing vote resolved in a direction Edda had argued against and could not undo. Around the table the other Signatories settled toward the vote, the recomputed Accord before them on its sealed reel, the folded legacy pool waiting in the columns Vey Corran had written.

She looked through the glass at the lower rings, dim and turning, carrying the nine billion souls most of whom would wake under the Accord about to pass. She had defended the continuous mind as the Strata's memory, and she had meant it without greed. The memory would now live in the Ledger and the record, distributed across a waking population instead of held by the few. Whether a distributed memory asleep half its life could carry a governance through its next dark century, Edda did not know. She had stated the risk. The Council would learn the answer, awake, and she would be among the many who forgot between the waves.

Her console logged the defense into the permanent archive, in the Council's dry grammar, the way she had logged the deadlock before it. The entry would record that a senior Signatory had argued continuity against the recomputed Accord and that the argument had not carried. Edda liked the dryness less than she once had. A dry record outlasted every passionate speech, and the record now described a Council choosing to govern without the continuous minds that had held it together for three centuries. The Strata would make the choice for itself. Edda had only ever asked that it be made with eyes open to the memory it spent.

She thought of the first window that would come for her under the new Accord, the one that would open after decades of continuous watch and find her a stranger to the present it delivered. The Strata would wake her then, as it would wake the rest, and she would surface from the long light into a governance she had helped to end. She did not resent the waking. She resented only that the memory she had kept would not travel with her into it. The continuous mind closed its eyes, and the Strata opened its own, and what passed between them the Ledger would have to hold alone.

Chapter 18 — The Vote

Orren Vask arrived at the Council chamber with the recomputed Accord sealed in his palm. The portable store weighed nothing, but he had carried heavier things. He had certified the old Schedule unbroken for eleven years; now he carried the document that would ask the Signatories to unseal what his certification had always implied was sacred. The corridor to the chamber ran bright against the lumen budget, lit for a session the public could watch, and Vask read the brightness as a concession the Council had not wanted to make. The walls carried the old accreditation plaques of nine bureaus that no longer met here, their enamel dimmed to the color of spent credit. The floor bore the scuff pattern of a hundred clerks who had walked it to file objections the room refused to hear, and Vask knew the pattern by foot as well as by eye. He had walked it himself on the mornings he carried a clean certification up to a Council that asked only that the numbers stay quiet. The bright light made no difference to the work. It only meant the work now had an audience.

He took his place at the clerks' rail, the position an allocations officer held when his filings had earned a hearing. Nine seats waited above him, three in body and six as projection, the same arrangement that had deadlocked three cycles before. The Keeper of the Seal stood at the chamber's edge with the physical Seal in hand, a small functionary carrying three centuries of unbroken metal. Vask had attested that metal intact every year of his supervision. He would attest its break before the day ended, if the numbers held. The rail felt different beneath his palms than it had when he came to watch earlier sessions. He no longer stood outside the matter he observed. The attestation he had filed made him a party to the vote the chamber was about to take, and a party could not pretend the outcome belonged to strangers.

The chamber filled in its dim order. The single sun-portrait of Mourn hung above the table at the same low luminance the founding charter had prescribed, its light tuned so the Signatories would feel watched by the planet they administered and by no other thing. Vask had always found the portrait a careful instrument rather than a decoration, the Strata's way of reminding nine voices that the rings below them held no vote. Tonight the portrait shared the room with the public pane, and the balance between the two sources of light struck Vask as the truer subject of

the session. Edda Marn entered last, as senior Signatories did, and took the center seat without meeting Adune's projection at the far end of the table. The split between them had become a fact the room no longer pretended to hide. Vask watched Edda settle and thought of the woman who had defended the line for forty years, the line that had broken the moment the truth reached the people it governed. Her hands rested on the arms of the chair the way a clerk rests on a ledger she has finished and cannot unread.

Adune called the session to order. Her projection carried the steady light of a near ring, no lag, no softening. "We convene to vote the recomputed Accord," she said. "The document before us carries the honest energy budget, slowlight efficiencies, and the legacy fold, as certified by the Office of the Accord and attested by its supervising officer." She nodded to Vask at the rail. He inclined his head, the smallest acknowledgment a supervisor could offer without seeming to campaign.

Edda spoke before the reading finished. "The recomputation is sound in its arithmetic," she said. "I have not disputed the surplus since the public reckoning. My objections lie elsewhere, with the Founding the Accord would undo. We vote a Schedule today, Councillors, but the Schedule opens onto the Seal, and the Seal guards the First Schedule. A vote for the Accord is a vote to break three hundred years of continuity."

Vask had expected her to say exactly that. He had spent thirty years inside the Office's defense of the unbroken line, and he knew every turn of it. The recomputed Accord named the Seal only as a condition of adoption. The document Vey built did not demolish the Founding. It replaced the practice the Founding's secrecy had protected, and it did so on numbers the Actuary itself had confirmed.

The presiding Signatory opened the floor for the reading. A clerk scrolled the recomputed Accord across the public pane, column by column, the base allocation rising from a few years per century to decades, the reserve closing each year in credit, the legacy wake folded back into the common pool where every other allocation drew. Vask watched the Signatories read. Some had seen these figures in the fuller account the Council had ordered after Vey's petition. None could unsee them now.

The clerk reached the legacy fold and paused, the way a reader pauses at the line that changes the moral shape of a budget without changing its arithmetic sign. Legacy wake had never been free. It had been paid, debited against a pool that every other allocation drew from, which meant every Signatory's waking year had been bought from a Suspended citizen's sleeping one. Returning the line to the pool did not punish the Signatories. It simply stopped billing their consciousness to the dark of eight and a half billion. Vask had read Vey's footer on that distinction three times, because Edda would hear a confiscation where the numbers described a correction, and the document had to survive her hearing it.

The public pane carried the same columns to the lower rings. Vask glanced at

the observer gallery where citizens gathered under the bright light of a session they had forced open. They did not cheer. They read, the way Vey read, line by line, and the silence of a people finally shown the size of the life withheld carried more weight than any shout the chamber had ever heard. The Wake had given them a number and a grievance. The recomputation gave them the Schedule that answered both.

He thought of the certification logs he had signed, year upon year, attesting the Original Allocation unbroken. The marks lined his memory like a fence he had helped rebuild every season. Those marks had proven only that the Office affirmed a lock it had never been permitted to inspect. The recomputed Accord turned that affirmation outward. It asked the Council not to admire a grievance but to adopt a Schedule it could live inside.

A third Signatory, one Edda had read as hers through the early cycle, asked the only procedural question left. "The transition you scroll retires the Suspended across decades," she said. "What happens to the citizen whose ring wakes last? The document admits the unfairness. Admission is not remedy."

Vey's footer had anticipated exactly this. Vask had read the answer in the phase model: a ring that retrofitted late woke late, and the recomputation left the cost on the page rather than burying it. The mid-ring Signatory answered for the document. "The last rings receive priority retrofit funding from the surplus the early rings free," he said. "The unfairness shrinks as the wave moves. The Schedule does not pretend the order is fair. It promises the order ends with everyone awake, and it shows the math by which the ending holds."

Vask weighed that exchange the way he weighed a routing. A plan that hid its failures was the old Accord. A plan that listed them was something the Council could actually sign. The recomputed Accord listed the cost of being last in line beside the promise that no one stayed dark forever, and the honesty was its own argument.

A neutral Signatory from a mid ring spoke first on the substance. "The phase model retires the Suspended ring by ring," he said. "The draw never crosses the harvest the vaults can meet. The transition takes decades, and the document admits the unfairness to the last in line. That is a plan I can sign, not a miracle I must believe."

Adune turned to Edda. "You argued continuity," she said. "The recomputation preserves continuity. It keeps the Strata's memory by funding that memory from the honest surplus rather than from the sleep of eight and a half billion. The continuous minds need not go dark for the record to hold."

Edda's voice held its level tone, the tone of a defender who had rehearsed the fall. "Continuity is not only the memory," she said. "It is the unbroken line of assent. The Founders sealed the Original Allocation so the Strata would not spend its early centuries arguing the terms of survival. If we break the Seal because the public demands it, we teach every future Council that the Founding is negotiable

on pressure."

"The public does not demand the break," Adune said. "The public knows the margin. The margin is real, the Actuary confirmed it, and the people who paid it in sleep now hold the number. We break the Seal because the lock has become the visible wall on the years the Wake names as stolen. A wall is not a foundation, Edda. You told me that yourself, in this room, when you defended the wall."

Vask remembered that exchange from the chamber records. Edda had argued a wall keeps the weather out, and the Founders had built for weather the Strata had not yet survived. The weather had come as a number, and the wall now stood between a people and their own accounted lives. The senior Signatory had armed her own defeat without meaning to.

The presiding Signatory called the question. The motion before the chamber was adoption of the recomputed Accord as the Strata's operative Schedule, with the Seal broken as a condition of that adoption, the Original Allocation to be opened and read in the session that followed. The wording had been fought over in the hearing the outer Signatory had forced, and the fight had produced a single clean sentence: the Accord could not be adopted over a lock no Council would turn.

Vask counted the room the way he had counted ledgers, looking for the column that would not balance. He read the projections as a clerk reads a spread, noting which seats cast their light from a near ring and which arrived pale and delayed across the slow light of the outermost arcs. The pale ones had always been the hardest to read, their intent arriving a half beat behind their words, and he had learned to wait for the lag before trusting the number. Edda held two seats outright through seniority and alliance. The cautious Signatory would follow the room. Adune held the swing, and she had already spoken her end. That left the outer Signatory who had forced the hearing, the one who had voted to hold rather than to decide. Her post had reported the gatherings going quiet in the way that precedes a larger one. She would not vote to decline again, having seen the surplus confirmed by the Actuary's own book.

The first vote came on the amendment to separate the Seal from the Schedule. Edda moved to adopt the Accord but retain the Seal pending the reading. Adune's block defeated the separation by a single seat. The outer Signatory voted with Adune, and the chamber agreed that the lock could not stand outside the door it had spent three centuries guarding.

Then the chamber took the vote that mattered. The presiding Signatory read the roll in the Council's dry grammar, each name a line in the permanent archive. Edda's two seats and the cautious Signatory formed the block of four. Adune's projection answered first, her voice clear across the table's length. "I vote to adopt the recomputed Accord and break the Seal. The margin is real, the public knows it, and the Council has lost the right to decide this in private."

The neutral mid-ring Signatory added his voice. The outer Signatory followed, her lag still coloring her words but her intent plain. Four for adoption, four against,

and the last seat still dark, its holder delayed by the slow light of a distant post. Vask felt the old deadlock tighten in his chest, the same four-and-four that had stranded the question three cycles before. The recomputed Accord would hang on one arrival. He had seen the pattern in the deadlock's record, the way a chamber built to decide could instead choose to wait, and waiting had always served the Seal. The dark seat had held at every prior count, a blank column the room filled with its own dread, and Vask found himself performing the old Office habit of naming the worst balance first so the actual one could only surprise upward. This time the column refused to stay blank.

The dark seat resolved. Its holder appeared with the cold glow of the outermost ring behind her, and she spoke without aligning with either block. "I have read the public feed from my post," she said. "I have read the recomputation as it was scrolled. The surplus is confirmed by the Actuary's own book, and the Schedule it proposes balances year upon year. My level went quiet in the way that precedes a larger gathering, and the quiet taught me that a Council which will not speak first is spoken for. I will not vote to decline a plan the record supports, nor will I hide behind the holding I urged before. I vote to adopt, and to break the Seal with it."

The chamber stilled. Vask counted again, because a supervisor counts what he most wants to believe. Five for adoption, four against. Adune's vote had carried it, but only because the outer Signatory had refused the deadlock a second time. The swing had not swung alone. It had swung because the truth had outrun the room built to contain it, and the room had at last voted in the open. Vask noted the precise arithmetic of the moment, the way he would note a ledger finally squared: one seat had turned the count that eleven years of certification had only ever postponed. Adune had named the public's right to the decision, and the naming had made the private lock untenable. The numbers had always permitted the break. Only the Council's silence had forbidden it, and the silence had just been voted out of the room.

The presiding Signatory recorded the result in the archive. "The recomputed Accord is provisionally adopted as the operative Schedule of the Strata," he said. "The Seal is broken as a condition of adoption. The Keeper is directed to open the Original Allocation before the public record." The words landed with the weight of a filing finally answered, the machinery of the Reckoning turning whether the Signatories had willed it or not.

Vask turned to the Keeper of the Seal. The small functionary had stood at the chamber's edge through every session of the deadlock, the physical Seal in hand, necessary and quiet. Now her orders had changed. The Seal she had been summoned to protect was the Seal she was directed to break, and the breaking fell to the same hands that had held it unbroken for three centuries.

The Keeper stepped to the center of the floor. She set the Seal on its stand, a cylinder of aged alloy scored with the registry mark Vask had signed beside for eleven years. The mark meant the Order that closed the Original Allocation, the

Order no citizen had read in three hundred years. The Keeper drew the release tool from her belt, the same tool that certified the annual affirmation, reversed now from closure to opening.

Vask watched the release engage. The alloy cylinder parted along its scored line with a sound the chamber's systems did not amplify, a small mechanical breath that carried further in the dim room than any speech had. The Seal broken, the Order that had hidden the First Schedule lay open on its stand, its registry mark severed, its three centuries of unbroken metal ended in a single clean separation. Vask had signed that registry mark eleven times, each signature a line of attestation that the Order held, and the tool that had taken his signature now took the Order apart with the same unhurried precision. The breach looked smaller than its weight. A seam of perhaps a finger's width had stood between eight and a half billion citizens and the document that explained their sleep, and the seam had held for three hundred years on the strength of a signature renewed each cycle. The Keeper did not flinch as the halves parted. She had practiced the closing a hundred times and the opening not once, yet the motion read as the same office performed in reverse, the difference lying only in which side of the mark the Strata now stood.

A clerk moved to retrieve the Original Allocation from its vault. The document would be read in the session that followed, the Founding's own handwriting finally exposed to the public pane. Vask had filed his attestation beside Vey's petition so that this moment would have an officer's weight behind it. The weight had done its work. The recomputed Accord stood adopted, and the Seal that had guarded the old lie lay open on the chamber floor.

Edda Marn had not spoken since the roll closed. She sat in the center seat with the stillness of a defender who had lost the narrower point and the larger one, and who had long ago learned to record the loss without flinching. "The line is broken," she said at last, to no one and to everyone. "Not by Adune. By the truth reaching the people it was written about." She might have been quoting the chamber's own earlier verdict, the one Vask had read in the deadlock's record.

Adune's projection met Edda's across the table's length. There was no triumph in her, only the settled resolve of someone who had followed her reason to its end. "You kept the line unbroken for forty years," she said. "The Strata can bear the truth now, Edda. It bore it in a single week what we postponed for three centuries. The vote is taken. The Seal is open. The Founding will answer for what it hid."

Vask thought of Vey, waiting beyond the public pane with Mirek and the raw Ledger that had proven the surplus. She had built the world the honest budget promised and handed it to the Council that could open the door. The door stood open now. The recomputed Accord would retire the Suspended ring by ring, her partner among the first to wake, and the Strata would turn on an arithmetic finally spoken aloud.

He looked down at the portable store still sealed in his palm. The document it carried had become the operative Schedule of nine billion lives. He had certified

the old Seal unbroken for eleven years and attested its break before the day ended, two acts in the same Office tongue, the correction seated beside the certification in the permanent archive. A supervisor who knew the defects could no longer sign in blindness. He had signed in knowledge, and knowledge was the only correction the Accord had ever lacked.

The chamber began to dim toward its baseline as the clerks logged the adoption. Vask stayed at the rail, as he often did, to watch the result enter the record in the Council's dry grammar. The entry would read that the recomputed Accord was adopted, that the Seal was broken, and that the Original Allocation would be opened and read. A dry record outlasted every passionate speech, and this record described a Council that had finally agreed.

He thought of the Suspended in their lower decks, billions of citizens kept by minimal shares beneath a scarcity the records disproved, their waking years lent to a story of lack an instruction had authored. The vote had ended that lending. The recomputed Accord folded the legacy wake back into the common pool, stopped billing the Signatories' consciousness to the dark of eight and a half billion, and granted the ordinary citizen a share measured in decades rather than in scattered years.

The Keeper of the Seal retrieved the parted cylinder and bore it from the floor, the registry mark severed, the Order that had hidden the First Schedule ended by the same hands that affirmed it. Vask watched her go and felt the particular cold of a man who had spent his life inside a wall and now stood outside it with no door behind him, the wind honest and cold and the first weather he had faced in thirty years of indoor work.

He gathered the portable store and stepped from the rail. The corridor beyond ran bright against the lumen budget, lit for a public that had watched its own reckoning become law. Vask walked the approved route to his station, the route he had walked for thirty years, and found it unchanged and entirely different. The recomputed Accord sat on the record. The Seal was broken. The Strata would wake, ring by ring, and the officer who had certified the old silence had become the one who attested its end.

Chapter 19 — The Opening of the Schedule

The chamber where the Seal had lived for three hundred years held no grandeur. It was a small vault off the Council rotunda, its only furniture a pedestal and, on the pedestal, a casket of cured composite that had not been lifted since the founding clerks set it down. Vey had walked past this door a thousand times on her way to other audits and never once been permitted to knock. The Office kept the vault as it kept the Scarcity Brief: present, authoritative, and untouchable by anyone who might read beneath it. She stood at the rail with Vask on one side and Mirek on the other, the three of them the only auditors the Office had permitted past the

threshold. The casket's seam ran in a single clean line, and along that line the Seal sat: a band of fused alloy stamped with the Signatures of the First Signatories, welded shut by an order no living Council had ever reviewed.

Adune's vote had carried the recomputed Accord two days before. The adoption clause named the Seal among the things the new order voided, and the Keeper of the Seal had surrendered the casket without a fight once the clause landed. Vey had expected resistance, a last argument from Edda, some procedural wall thrown up to protect the founding silence. None came. The Founders had written the breaking of their own Seal into the very document that replaced them, and the Council that inherited their authority chose to read the instruction literally.

Vask reached out first. His hand hovered over the band, then closed on it, and he worked the release tool Mirek had brought from the Ledger stores. The alloy parted with a sound like a held breath letting go, a soft mechanical sigh that carried three centuries of closure in its single note. Vey watched the seam open and felt, absurdly, the small physical relief of a misaligned entry finally squared. Three hundred years of accounting had rested on this closure. The closure was now a gap, and the gap was hers to read.

"Open it," she said.

Mirek lifted the lid. Inside, on a bed of inert padding, lay the Original Allocation: a bound volume of the First Schedule, its pages the thin cured leaf the founding clerks had used, each line set in the deliberate hand of the first writers. Vey had read the raw store's copies of these entries, the un-summarized columns Mirek's access had unlocked, but the bound original carried something the copies could not: the order of the pages as the Founders had arranged them, the marginal marks they had made in the act of writing, the weight of a document sealed by its own authors rather than reconstructed by a later machine. She took it from Mirek's hands, and the leaf was cold and faintly brittle at the edges, but the ink held its black.

The binding creaked where three centuries had settled the spine, and Vey drew the volume close to read by the casket's light rather than the duty lamps. The founding clerks had ruled no line twice. Each entry sat in its own measured band of leaf, the pen lifting clean between figures the way a careful hand lifts between two balances it means to keep separate. She traced a column with one finger and felt the slight ridge the pressed ink had left, a texture no copy could carry, the physical memory of a writer who had set the number down once and let it stand. The margin marks ran closer to the text than the Office's later clerks would have permitted, as though the Founders meant the correction to travel with the entry it amended. Nothing in the binding suggested urgency or regret. The book read like any other allocation record Vey had audited, which was precisely what made it terrible. The founders had filed the world's largest theft in the same quiet hand they used for a routine debit, and the quiet had held for three hundred years because no one had been permitted to lift the lid.

Page one began with the grant of legacy wake to the First Signatories and their lines, perpetual consciousness debited against a collective pool. The line read exactly as the buried clause in the raw store had described it, and Vey felt the old precision settle: the copy had matched the source. She turned the page and found the ordinary citizen's allocation, the measured share of awake years the Schedule granted to everyone outside the Signatory lines. Beside it, in the founding clerks' narrow margin, ran a column of figures Vey had seen before only as reconstructed entries. Here they stood in the original hand, the true energy margin of the Strata set against the smaller figure the public Schedule would carry.

The gap between the two numbers was not a rounding error. It was the whole of the legacy wake, written out in plain arithmetic by the people who had decided to publish the smaller story. Vey read the margin the way she read every ledger: entry against entry, letting the pattern declare itself rather than forcing it. The true margin exceeded the allocation the public Schedule claimed to require. The scarcity the Accord would present to the rings had been chosen, not measured. The First Signatories had reviewed the honest figures and elected to publish the smaller ones. The founding hand said so without ornament, the way a clerk records a balance that happens to be the shape of a theft.

She turned to the third leaf. Here the Schedule's own text confirmed what the buried clause had only implied. A rider attached to the founding grant stated, in the measured prose of the Accord, that the public allocation would be administered at the conservative edge of the true reserve, and that the difference between the true reserve and the administered edge would fund the reserved consciousness of the Signatory lines. The words did not name a lie. They named a budget. The budget carried the lie, dressed in the clean language of an allocation the Founders expected no one to read against the margin.

Vask leaned in beside her. He had read the Surplus Brief, the recomputation, the Actuary's confession of instruction. None of those had moved him the way this bound page moved him now. "They wrote it down," he said, and his voice carried the particular quiet of a man whose last defense had just dissolved. "They wrote exactly what they did, on the page they sealed."

"So no one would read it against the margin," Vey said. "The fold in the raw store was only the echo of this hand."

Mirek had said almost nothing since the casket opened. He traced a finger along the third leaf's edge, where the founding clerks had pressed the page flat three centuries before. "The raw store kept the copies," he said. "This is the one they meant to hide. The copies prove the original. The original proves the copies were not a mistake made by a later Office."

Vey came to the fourth leaf and stopped. The page carried a note set in the margin where the summary would never surface it, in a hand the archive had preserved without ever reading, the same marginal hand she had found in the raw store eleven chapters of investigation ago. The note recorded that the true energy

margin exceeded the public figure, that the scarcity had been chosen, that the surplus had been visible from the first cycle. It stated plainly that the Founders knew the energy math was falsified, and that they had kept it hidden so the ration of wake-time would hold the shape they had already decided upon.

Vey had not realized she was holding her breath until the chamber seemed to narrow to the lamp's blue circle and the small sound of Mirek's finger on the leaf. She let it go in a slow exhale that the vault took without echo, the air of a room sealed for centuries moving for the first time around a reader it had been built to deny. The relief was not triumph. It was the settling of a column that had hung unbalanced in her for nine years, the quiet click of a figure finally meeting the entry it had always implied. She had spent those years trusting the Office's silence the way a citizen trusts the deck that keeps them dark, and the page in her hands removed the last excuse the silence had offered. The founders had not been mistaken. The founders had not been misread by a later machine. They had written the smaller story on purpose, in the margin of the very page that published the larger one, and they had trusted three hundred years of obedient Keepers to never turn the leaf far enough to compare the two.

The note in the bound original was not a copy of the buried clause. It was the buried clause's source. Vey had carried the raw store's version in her private record since the night Mirek pressed the credential into her palm. Seeing it here, in the document the Founders had sealed with their own Signatures, closed the circle she had been tracing since Toll's credit first refused to close. The marginal hand that confessed the falsification had been sealed inside the very Schedule it indicted, and the Seal that protected it had now been broken by the very Accord it was meant to outlast.

She read the four lines a second time, then a third, because the mind still resists the thing it has spent years being trained not to see. The note did not argue. It did not apologize. It simply recorded, with the flat precision of a clerk who expected no reader, that scarcity was a decision the Founders had made while the true numbers lay open on the same page. Vey had searched the modern store for months to prove what this dead hand had noted in an afternoon and then bound into the book it would never be asked to open. The finding she had copied from the raw store now traced to its fountain, and that fountain ran from the founding pen.

"Read it aloud," Vask said. "Into the record. So it is not just us three in a vault, deciding what we saw."

Vey lifted the volume and read the marginal note into the terminal Mirek had keyed to the Council channel, the quote standing as evidence in the same breath as the page that carried it. The Actuary's voice had confessed an instruction but named no author. This page named the authors in the act of knowing. The words left her mouth and entered the record of the Strata, three hundred years after the hand that wrote them expected them to stay buried beneath the fold.

The confirmation landed not as a shock but as a release, the way a held audit

finally closes when the missing entry appears. Vey had carried the suspicion as a private weight since the night in the raw store, a figure she could prove against copies but never against the source that authorized them. Speaking the founders' own note into the channel removed the gap between what she knew and what the Strata could be shown. The voice on the recording was hers, steady, no longer arguing a reconstruction but reading a confession the authors had signed. Vask's silence beside her carried the same relief, the quiet of a man who had built his career on a balance that the open page had just proven false, and who found the proving easier to bear than the years of not knowing.

She moved to the fifth leaf. The Schedule's closing grant set the Seal itself: the Original Allocation would remain closed until the Strata could bear the truth, and the Office would administer the public Schedule in the meantime as though the original did not exist. The Founders had sealed their own confession and entrusted its opening to a future they could not imagine, a future that had arrived only because an auditor learned to read beneath the fold. The Seal had protected the lie by promising the truth would surface when the world was ready. The world had become ready by refusing the scarcity the Seal was meant to outlast, and the recomputed Accord had carried the breach as its first clause. The new Schedule Vey and Mirek had built from the true budget now rested on a foundation the Founders themselves had signed: the honest margin, set beside the published one, in the hand that wrote both. The recomputation had always been a projection of what the records implied. The opened Original Allocation made it a confirmation of what the Founders had known.

Vey closed the volume for a moment and looked at the two men beside her. Vask, who had once warned her that the Accord was not questioned, now stood in the open casket's light with the questioned Accord in his hands. Mirek, who had spent eleven years guarding an honest record whose honesty had been used to publish a lie, now watched the lie's founding signature lie exposed on the page he had helped open. The vault held them and the book and the broken Seal, and outside it the Strata turned its patient circle around the failing star, sixty levels keeping their slow orbit while the document that rationed them sat finally unsealed.

"We have what the petition asked for," she said. "The Original Allocation, unsealed and read. It confirms the falsification. It confirms the Founders knew the energy math was false from the first cycle."

Mirek nodded toward the open page. "The margin says it plainer than any brief ever did, and the Seal beside it says they knew it would one day be read."

Vey turned back to the volume and read the founding grant once more, the whole arc of it laid in order: the legacy wake reserved, the ordinary share granted, the true margin set beside the published one, the rider that made the gap a budget, the note that confessed the choice, the Seal that buried the confession until the Strata could bear it. The First Schedule was not a clean original corrupted

by later hands. It was the lie in its first and fullest form, written by the people who founded the world and sealed so that no one would measure the public figure against the true one.

She thought of Lin, three levels down in the Suspension deck, owed a life the Schedule had spent elsewhere. Lin had lost most of their shared years to a shortage the Actuary said had been instructed, and the note said the instruction came from the people who founded the world Lin slept inside. The opened Schedule gave Vey the sentence she would carry to a waking partner: the scarcity was not a verdict of the failing star. The book in her hands was the proof no Council could wave away, the original hand against the original Seal, the founding pen set down beside the founding lie.

She thought of the families in the lower rings, the Suspended citizens whose bodies the decks kept while their minds stayed dark, the children who had never met a waking parent. The Office had called their sleep a necessity. The Actuary had called it a computation under instruction. The opened Original Allocation called it what it was: a budget line the First Signatories had written to fund their own unearned wake, debited against nine billion allocations they had never asked to make. The truth was on the record now, bound and broken and read aloud into the channel that would carry it to every ring. Joss and the Wake had asked, months before, for a number anyone could feel; the original hand supplied it better than any column Vey had ever compiled. Nine billion wake-years had been folded out of the brief so a few thousand Signatory lines could stay awake forever, and the Founders had written the fold into the Schedule before the Schedule had anyone left to fold. The number was no longer a calculation. It was a confession in the founders' own ink.

Vask set the release tool on the pedestal beside the parted Seal. "The old Accord is dead," he said. It was not a grief in his voice, nor a triumph. It was the plain statement of a man who had watched the column finally balance after nine years of trusting that it already did. He looked at the opened volume the way he might look at a citizen's file he had audited wrong for a decade, with the specific humility of someone who had enforced the very silence now broken on the pedestal. "I warned you off this," he said. "I was wrong to. The Accord was not questioned because the question had an answer no one was meant to reach."

Vey considered the weight of a single bound volume against the whole architecture of the Office. The Actuary's confession had named an instruction but not a name. The buried clause had named the Founders in the aggregate. The opened Schedule named them in the order they had written: the grant, the gap, the rider, the note, the Seal. It turned prudent scarcity into a chosen starvation and placed the choice at the table where the Accord was written. No later Council could be scapegoated for a decision the First Signatories had signed in the margin and sealed with their own hands.

She ran her finger once more down the third leaf, the rider that named the gap a

budget. The founding clerks had written it in the same steady hand as the grant above it, no hesitation, no mark of shame in the stroke. Whoever set the pen had treated the concealment as an ordinary line of allocation, one entry among many in the book that would ration a world. That ordinariness struck Vey more than any confession could have. The Founders had not hidden the truth in a panic. They had filed it, neat and final, and walked away from the sealed casket expecting the Strata to never ask. The question had taken nine years of her life to learn, and the answer had waited on this pedestal the whole time.

She opened the record channel on the terminal and wrote the line that would sit in the file beside the volume's image: the Original Allocation, unsealed and read, confirms that the public Schedule was administered at the conservative edge of a true surplus, that the gap funded the reserved consciousness of the Signatory lines, and that the Founders knew the energy math was falsified from the first cycle. Mirek keyed the founder-page scans to the same channel, the original hand preserved exactly as the casket had kept it for three hundred years, each leaf captured with the margin that indicted it.

The vault's duty lamps held their blue wash across the broken Seal. Around the pedestal the small chamber ran orderly and still, the rail where generations of Keepers had stood now empty of its charge. The casket that had held the truth was open, and the truth was a bound book on a pedestal, read by three auditors and recorded for a Strata that had slept beneath its silence for three hundred years. The rail under Vey's hand was cool where generations of Keepers had gripped it in the performance of not reading, and the pedestal bore the faint ring of dust the casket had shielded from three hundred years of duty-lamp light. Outside the vault door the rotunda ran its ordinary business, clerks passing the sealed threshold without knowing the seal on the far side had come undone, the whole vast Office continuing to administer a Schedule whose original now lay open to three people and a terminal. The small room held the disproportion without comment. A casket, a book, a parted band of alloy, and the weight of nine billion allocations tipping at last from the founders' margin into the record. Vey had counted the Strata's wealth wrong for nine years because this casket had told her to, and the casket was now a lid leaning on a pedestal, its Seal a parted band of alloy that would never close again.

She lifted the volume one last time and ran her thumb along the seam the Seal had once closed. The Founders had built the removal into the store before the store had anything left to remove, and they had sealed the confession of that removal inside the document it indicted. The fold had kept the early writes quiet for three centuries. Mirek's access opened the first breach in that quiet, and the opened Schedule was what the breach had been waiting to surrender.

She thought of the clerk who had written the note and then bound it under his own hand, expecting no reader in three centuries and being nearly right. The fold had done its work without his name ever surfacing, and the Office had punished curiosity the way it punished every breach of the calm. Now the bound original lay

open on a pedestal, and the marginal hand that had expected silence spoke into the record of the world it had helped found.

Vey closed the volume and placed it on the pedestal beside the parted Seal, the original and the broken closure resting together like the two halves of a verdict finally read. The truth was on the record. The old Accord was dead. She turned from the vault and let the duty lamps carry her toward the level where Lin slept, counting now not toward a hidden sum but toward the waking years the opened Schedule had at last made honest.

Chapter 20 — Lin, Awake

The notice reached Lin's bank in the slow hour before the decks changed light. A single line scrolled across the monitor at the rail's end, the green numeral she had watched tick downward through every window of her adult life now replaced by a word she had never expected to see beside her name. FULL WAKE-TIME. GRANTED UNDER THE RECOMPUTED ACCORD. No hours remaining, no count ticking toward dark. The attendant who brought it paused at the rail, uncertain what a message without a closing time required of her, and Lin watched the woman's hand hover over the sleep-field controls as if she had forgotten they would not be needed.

Lin lifted her hand from the field the way she always had, a leaf off still water, but this time no chime marked the start of a window and no attendant stood ready to seal her under when the green numeral hit zero. She sat up. The field's low hum, the note the body learned to ignore across a hundred surfaces, simply stopped, and the absence of it was the first new thing she had felt in years. Vey was already at the rail. She had not slept, but the not-sleeping looked different now, lighter, the way a person carries a weight after the weight has been named.

"Full," Lin said. She tested the word the way she had once tested sixteen hours, as if a foreign unit might dissolve on the tongue. "They gave me the whole rest of it. I'm awake. Actually awake, with no window waiting to close."

"They gave it to nine billion," Vey said. "The recomputation closed the year with the vaults fuller than the briefs ever admitted. You were first on the list they unsealed, but you are not alone on it." She set her satchel down, the same grip through the rail, the same steadiness Lin had measured her own hand against across eleven surfaces. "The Accord that deferred you is dead. The Schedule that closed on you is open. What the Council voted in the chamber reached your bank this morning."

Lin took the grip and held. The sleep-field was cool beneath her, no longer pulling, and she found she did not know what to do with a body that was hers to keep. She had spent the whole of her waking life counting the dark between windows. The count was over, and the silence where the count had been was its own kind of unfamiliar. "I don't remember how to be the one who stays," she said.

"Then we learn it," Vey said. "I have the hours to learn it with you. All of them,

apparently. The Strata finally admitted the light was enough."

They walked out of the Suspension deck together, and Lin felt the difference in her own gait before she felt it in the world. Eleven windows had taught her to surface small, to spend the first hours finding her feet before the dark took them back. Now her feet stayed. The transit lane carried its faint warmth, the deck's old kindness, and she walked it without the pressure of a closing numeral behind every step. Vey matched her pace, said nothing, let the walking be its own first conversation.

Morning came through the single window in a slow pour, the amber that slowlight left behind after the Strata's lamps stepped down for the day's long rest. Lin stood in the open doorway for a moment before crossing it, bare feet on the worn plank, and the floor held the faint warmth of someone who had walked it a thousand times without her. The air carried the smell of the apartment the way a body carries its own: old paper, the faint metallic cleanliness of audit-office air filtered up through the rings, a thread of something warm Vey had cooked in the years Lin could not count. Nothing in the room moved to meet her. That was the strangeness. For eleven windows the world had always been tilted toward the next closing, every surface borrowed, every hour on loan. Here the stillness simply continued, indifferent to any numeral, and she had no practice for a room that would still be there at the end of the day.

Vey had left the kettle on the low burner, the way she must have left it every evening, and it ticked as it cooled, a small domestic clock that asked nothing of her. Lin filled two cups from the tap, the water cold against her wrist, and set them on the sill beside the star lamp. The ordinary gesture felt foreign in her hands, a task with no window closing behind it, no attendant waiting to seal the field. She watched the steam rise and dissipate into the amber and thought that this, the unhurried making of a thing no one had scheduled, was the first fully-awake act she had ever performed. Vey came to the doorway and took the second cup without a word, and the quiet between them was not the thin quiet of a four-hour visit but the wider quiet of a morning with nowhere to end.

The apartment above the audit offices had not changed shape in the years Lin was under, but it had changed meaning. She stood in the doorway and took in the left drawer, still a disaster, the forms spilling the way Vey had described it through the rail. On the sill sat the star lamp, the paper one with the star cut crooked, mended along one crease with the careful strip of adhesive Lin remembered only as something Vey had done. She picked it up. The paper was thicker than her window-memory claimed, repaired so many times it had gained weight.

"You kept the lamp lit," Lin said.

"I kept it," Vey said. "Not always lit. Sometimes I let it gutter because the dark on the sill was honest about what the Accord had taken. Then I would light it again because you told me a dark unit needed one light that was ours." She leaned against the doorframe, the posture of someone home from a long audit. "I became

a stranger to you in the gaps. Eleven windows, four hours each, and the woman who came up between them was three hundred years of policy wearing your face. I read your face like a summary I was not permitted to open."

Lin turned the lamp in the light from the single window. "And I became a stranger to you. I came up small every time, carrying the four hours I'd been given, and I read you the way I read the rail, as something solid on the other side of the glass. I didn't know the woman who followed a loose thread to the bottom of the budget. I knew the auditor who visited. Those are different people."

"They are the same person," Vey said. "The visiting auditor was the one who could not stop counting what was missing. The one who found the surplus reached with the same hand and the same grip. You met the hand at the rail. You did not meet the finding."

Lin set the lamp on the sill where it belonged. "I meet her now. The stranger who is my partner. That's the strange part, Vey. I thought waking would be arriving home. It's arriving at a door I've never opened, with a person I've never sat with."

The rooms around them kept their ordinary sounds, the distant hum of the rings' ventilation, a neighbor's transit chime three decks down, the small settling of an old structure holding its people. Lin listened to it the way she had once listened for the sleep-field's closing chime, but nothing here gathered toward an ending. The continuity was its own disorientation. She had built eleven lives out of interruption, each one cut before it could accumulate into a self. Now the morning refused to be cut, and the self that remained when nothing closed on her was larger than any window had permitted, strange with the weight of hours that would not be taken back. Vey moved through the apartment with the ease of someone who had lived every one of the missing years, and Lin followed, a guest in the life her partner had kept without her, learning the floorboards by the way they gave underfoot.

They ate in the small kitchen because eating was the one thing the windows had never permitted enough of, and Lin found the ordinary act foreign. She measured rice into a pot the way she had measured hours, by habit, and Vey laughed, a short unguarded sound Lin had heard maybe twice across the surfaces. "You portion like the Schedule," Vey said. "Two scoops, exactly the allocation. You can cook for a day now. A day is a long time to feed."

"I don't know what a day is for," Lin said. She let the extra rice go into the pot, more than four hours could ever have used, and watched it settle. "I know what four hours are for. You visit, we talk, the window closes. I don't know what to do with the part after the visit that used to be dark."

"Neither do I, exactly," Vey said. "I filled it with the Ledger. That's how I found the surplus, by refusing to stop at the line the Office permitted. The finding ate my dark the way Suspension ate yours. We were both diminished by the same machine, just on opposite sides of the rail." She stirred the pot, competent and unhurried in a way Lin had only glimpsed through glass. "We are not who we were when you went under at FY291. You were the one who packed the left drawer and

left the lamp on the sill. I was the one who trusted the summaries. The Strata remade us both. The question is whether we like the remade versions well enough to stay."

Lin considered the question the way she had once considered the green numeral, as a thing with weight. "I like the one who followed the thread. I like the one who mended the lamp nine times. I like the one who stood at the rail counting what was missing and then decided the missing was a lie. Those are the parts of you I want to sit with. The parts I don't know yet, I'll learn."

"And the parts of you," Vey said, "the ones the windows kept small. The woman who was worth four hours and decided four was not enough, who read the count and put her name in the book of the Wake. I want to sit with her. I only ever met her at the rail, surfacing. Now she's here for the whole day, awake and staying."

They took the rice to the window and ate looking out at the middle rings, where the decks Lin had only known as cold rows of sleepers now carried movement. The slowlight had dimmed the Strata's lamps to a warm amber, the recomputed setting that stretched energy across nine billion waking lives, and under that amber the rings looked less like a vault and more like a city that had finally opened its doors. Lin watched a child ride the transit lane past their window, something no Suspension deck had permitted in the years she was under, and the sight landed the way the surplus math once had, as proof made ordinary.

"The Wake halls are full now," Vey said. "Joss's map, deck by deck, family by family, the count of years stolen. The families don't wait at rails anymore. They fill the middle-ring rooms the Office abandoned to storage. Bren runs the east clusters. The grandmother who outlived three children into the dark sits at the center table and teaches the new wakers how to be tired, which is a skill no window ever allowed."

Lin leaned her forehead to the glass. "I should go down. I told Joss I'd put my name in the book. The window that wouldn't close on me, that was the one holding the door. I'm still holding it, and now I'm awake enough to walk through it."

"You are," Vey said. "And you don't have to hold it alone anymore. That's the whole point of the recomputation. The door stays open because the light was always enough. We just had to stop pretending it wasn't."

They finished the rice in the comfortable quiet of two people who had spent years learning to say little in little time, and found the quiet held now without the pressure of an ending. Lin washed the pot, a task the four-hour windows had never reached, and Vey dried it with the same careful clumsiness she brought to mending paper. The left drawer stayed a disaster, the forms still spilling the way Vey had described it through the rail, and Lin slid one back inside, then let the rest lie, because some disorder was a record of the years Vey had managed alone. She found a third cup in the cabinet, chipped and unfamiliar, that must have belonged to no one she knew, and set it on the shelf beside their two, a small provision for a life that would now have visitors. Vey watched her place it and said nothing, but

Lin caught the lift at the corner of her mouth, the same relief as the rail, the same quiet welcome home. The lamp stayed on the sill. The habits of the separated years persisted in the small domestic facts, and Lin found comfort in that, in the proof that some things had waited.

She ran a thumb along the repaired crease of the lamp, the adhesive Vey's work, careful and a little clumsy, the way Vey mended everything that was not a figure. "Do you remember the day I went under," Lin said. "Not the date. The shape of it."

Vey's face softened at the corners, the only part of her that ever truly let go. "You packed the left drawer. You left the lamp on the sill because you said a dark unit needed one light that was ours. You told me you'd be back before the star lamp needed a new wick. Then the window closed and the wick outlasted you by three surfaces." She paused, and the softening deepened. "I stood at the rail the way you stood at every window, counting what was missing. I was a stranger to you too, Lin. You just couldn't see it from the sleep-field. You saw the visitor. You didn't see the woman who went back to an empty apartment and let the lamp gutter."

Lin set the lamp in her lap and looked at her partner across the rail of the memory. "Three surfaces. I left you with the lamp and a drawer full of forms and a promise the Schedule broke. I've been angry about that promise in the dark, you know. Not at you. At the door that closed."

"The door was a line in a ledger," Vey said. "I know that now. I didn't know it then. I stood at the rail counting what was missing, the same way you counted the dark between windows. We were both doing the same arithmetic of loss. The recomputation didn't just wake the Strata. It forgave the arithmetic."

After the kitchen, before the halls, Lin asked to see the rail one more time. They walked back through the transit lane to the deck she had left that morning, and she stood at the rail where the sleep-field waited empty, its hum gone, the monitor dark where her green numeral used to tick. The attendant from the morning nodded at her, no longer hovering over the controls, and went about the business of waking the next name on the unsealed list. Lin laid her palm flat on the cool rail. The glass held no one's face now but her own, reflected faint in the amber, and the strangeness of seeing herself whole and staying was a small grief and a larger relief at once.

"I used to memorize your face through this," she said. "I read you like writing on the other side of the glass. Now I can stand here and there's no glass between us and no window closing. The rail is just a rail."

"It's just a rail," Vey agreed. "The Office built it to hold the separated at a distance. The recomputation took the distance out of the build. What's left is furniture."

Lin ran her hand along the rail's length, past the bank where the woman two rows over had gone under the same year she did, whose wife had counted nine

years between windows. The bank was empty now, its sleeper woken by the same notice Lin had received, and somewhere on an upper ring a wife was sitting with a partner she had only ever visited. The thought warmed her the way the lamp warmed the sill. She left the rail without looking back, because there was nothing there to return to, and took Vey's arm instead.

Later, when the amber light had deepened toward the Strata's long evening, they walked down to the Wake halls. Lin had only ever imagined them from Vey's descriptions, the banners sewn from discarded allocation forms, the child's drawing of the Strata as a ladder with people climbing. Now the rooms were real and loud with the unfamiliar noise of people who would not be sent under. Joss found them at the door, a woman whose handshake carried the weight of seventy windows of organizing, and she pulled Lin into the center of the room without ceremony.

"The partner who finally got a day," Joss said. "Vey told me you surfaced for a reason. The book's right here. Put your name down properly this time, not in a window that's closing."

Lin took the pen. The book lay open to a page of hundreds of names, families who had waited at rails, and she wrote Lin in a careful hand, the same print Vey used for figures. She wrote it beside the others, a name among names, present instead of deferred. Around her the hall went on its warm business, a child drawing at a low table, an old man laughing at the strangeness of being awake past his window, Bren calling the east clusters to order. The noise was not the cold chime of a deck sealing. It was the sound of a world that had decided to stay open.

She thought of the eight and a half billion the surplus had named, the vast shared silence of the suspended finally broken, and she thought of the child's ladder, and she thought of the longer tether in her own body, the full wake-time that proved the dark had been chosen. She had come up eleven times and Vey had caught her every one. This time she had walked down herself, awake, and the door stood open behind her.

Vey found her at the center table, where the grandmother who had outlived three children into the dark was showing a new waker how to be tired on purpose. Lin watched the teaching, the ordinary transmission of an ordinary skill, and felt the full weight of a life that was no longer measured in hours the Accord permitted. She took Vey's hand.

"I surfaced smaller than I went under, every time but the last," Lin said. "Eleven windows of coming up to be measured and sent back. The Accord told me I was worth four hours, then a day, then nothing it could spare. You told me the dark was chosen. I'm telling you now, in the light that's actually mine, that I choose the staying. I choose the stranger who is my partner. I choose the door that's open, and I'm awake enough to walk through it with you."

Vey closed her hand around Lin's. "I choose you back. Not the four-hour visitor. The whole-day woman at the sink washing the pot. The one who portions rice like the Schedule and is learning not to. The one I became a stranger to, and got the

years to know. We're both awake now, Lin. All the way awake."

The lamp burned low and steady in Lin's other hand, the way a thing mended carefully will burn. Outside, the slowlight held the rings in its warm amber, and somewhere in the middle-ring halls the new wakers laughed at the unfamiliar business of being tired on purpose. Lin set the lamp between them on the center table and let the crooked shadow fall across both their hands, a star, lopsided and bright, thrown by a light that was finally, fully, theirs, and by a woman who was finally, fully, awake.

Chapter 21 — The Cost

The Council chamber held its breath in a way Vey had not seen in three hundred years of recorded procedure. Edda Marn sat with her hands flat on the polished table, the same table where she had defended legacy wake only sessions before. The other Signatories had already surrendered their lines. Edda's surrender arrived last, and it arrived quiet.

She did not speak the words with triumph or with shame. She spoke them the way an auditor reads a closing balance: a thing done because the arithmetic no longer permitted otherwise. "The First Signatories release legacy wake," Edda said. "We return our lines to the pool."

Vey wrote the entry into the open Ledger of Hours, the one no longer sealed. The characters settled onto the page like ash. She had chased this line through a credit that should not have existed, through a buried clause, through the Actuary's measured confession that it had been instructed to present scarcity. Now the line ended here, in a chamber dimming by the minute.

The entry required a precision the old Accord had never permitted her to use. Each Signatory's perpetual allocation had to be debited as its own line, transferred from the legacy reserve into the common pool, and reallocated under the recomputed Schedule. Vey keyed the first transfer and watched the reserve balance fall. For three hundred years that balance had only ever grown, fed by the sleep of everyone else. Watching it empty felt less like spending than like breathing out.

Legacy wake surrendered. The phrase printed itself in her mind with the weight of a seal breaking. Three centuries of continuous consciousness, held by a handful of founding lines, had just been debited back into the collective account from which every ordinary citizen's wake-years were drawn. The pool that had fed the few now fed the many.

Vey watched Edda's hands. They were old hands, trained to govern without sleep, and they did not tremble. The dignity in them was real, and it was the kind of dignity the new math could not preserve. Continuity had been bought with everyone else's darkness, and the bill had come due.

The other Signatories had not left the chamber. They sat in the order of their founding lines, each one a name Vey had read a thousand times in the Ledger's oldest margins, and each one now witnessed the quiet ending of the only privilege their blood had ever known. None of them rose to speak against Edda. Their silence carried none of the relief of the freed and none of the bitterness of the defeated. It carried the particular weight of people watching a thing they had been born inside of close around them. Vey had expected to read resentment in their stillness. She read instead a tiredness older than the chamber, the tired of minds that had carried the Strata awake for three centuries and had at last been told the carrying was over.

Outside the chamber, the Strata began to change its mind about light.

Mirek's recomputation had set the threshold: run the rings at reduced output, and the honest energy budget would stretch far enough to wake nearly everyone. The Council had named the mode at adoption. Slowlight. Vey had read the word in the recomputed Accord and thought it sounded gentler than it felt.

Now she felt it. The great arcology around her dimmed in measured steps, ring by ring, as non-essential systems lengthened their cycles and the residual harvest of Mourn was rationed to what the truth actually required. The corridor beyond the chamber door lost its bright edge. Shadows grew patient. A maintenance drone that had hummed at full pitch for as long as the records ran slowed to a low, occasional note.

One of the chamber's old reading lamps went dark as she passed it, the kind that had burned through every Council session since the first Seal, its warm spill so constant that generations of auditors had stopped noticing it was there. Vey had read more than one founding document beneath that light, and she had always counted on its steadiness the way she counted on the floor. Now the pool it lit held nothing but the pale reflection of the corridor behind her, and she understood with a small surprise that the lamp had been part of the cost all along. The Strata would dim by such losses, one familiar glow at a time, until the children waking under slowlight never learned what brightness had been ordinary.

Vey walked the corridor after the session ended. The dimming followed her like a tide she had helped call in. She had expected relief. She found instead a strange sorrow she could not yet name, because the win and the loss wore the same face.

The loss was continuity. For three hundred years, a small set of minds had never closed their eyes on the Strata. They had carried its memory without interruption, waking through disasters and treaties and the long quiet of the Dimming. That unbroken thread snapped the moment legacy wake surrendered. No single mind would now hold the whole of what had been. The governance that Edda had defended would live on only as a scattered thing, awake in pieces, remembered in fragments passed between people who had once been strangers to each other's years.

Vey understood, standing in the softer light, why Edda had fought. Continuity

was not greed. Continuity was the Strata refusing to forget itself. The recomputed Accord traded that refusal for something else: a world where the forgetting happened slowly, in the ordinary way of mortal lives, and where no one was put to sleep to pay for another's vigil.

She thought of Toll, the citizen whose Suspension had drawn less energy than the Ledger claimed he was owed. The credit that started everything had been a single cell of a vast hidden surplus. Now the surplus was no longer hidden, and the surplus no longer required Toll's sleep. He would wake. So would billions like him. The cost of their waking was the Signatories' endless day.

In the archive antechamber, Vey paused before a wall of recorded Council sessions. Each glowing tile held a year of unbroken governance, spoken by minds that had not dimmed between them. She had audited these records during the long months of the petition, and she knew what the tiles represented: not just decisions but a continuity of attention no reawakened citizen could match.

One tile near the end of the second row held a session from the waning years of the Founders, a debate over whether to seal the marginal note that would later betray their knowledge. Vey had replayed that tile more times than she could count, watching the Signatories of that era weigh the cost of candor against the cost of fear, and choose the quieter road. The voices on the tile had not dimmed in three hundred years. They would dim now, along with the rest, their unbroken governance folding into the same scattered memory the recomputed Accord would ask ordinary citizens to carry. She had once envied that continuity. Standing before the tiles, she mourned it the way one mourns a library that will soon be shelved across a hundred homes. A woman waking once a decade would never hold the Strata's full memory in her own head. The knowledge would have to live in the Ledger, in the schools, in the stories passed from one brief window to the next. Edda had been right that something ended here. She had been wrong that only endless waking could carry it.

A tile near the center caught Vey's eye, dated to the fortieth year after the Dimming. The session it held recorded the sealing of the Original Allocation, the Founders' own hand setting the truth aside for a Strata that could not yet bear it. Three hundred years later that Strata had finally borne it, in a chamber two levels up, with Edda's quiet release spoken into the same ledger line. Vey traced the tile's edge with one finger. The continuity the Signatories guarded had itself begun as a deferral, a promise to reopen what fear had closed. The recomputed Accord was not the end of that continuity. It was the keeping of its oldest promise.

The dignity of the First Signatories troubled Vey more than she had prepared for. They had written the Accord under a failing star, certain that survival demanded hard rationing, and they had reserved for themselves the one luxury they denied everyone else: the right to stay awake and watch. Even knowing the math had been falsified, even after the Founders' own marginal note betrayed their knowledge, Vey could not quite call them villains. They had built the only world

that had kept humanity alive. Their error was to mistake their fear for law, and to let the law sleep everyone else to fund it.

That was the honest reckoning. Not monsters. Architects who had grown comfortable inside the house they built, and who had forgotten the door.

Vey remembered Edda's last defense before the vote, the argument that continuous minds kept the Strata's memory whole. It had been a fair argument, made by an intelligent person who believed what she said. Vey had audited the counter-evidence herself: the buried clause, the Actuary's instruction, the surplus that made continuity-for-the-few a choice rather than a need. Edda had not been lying; she had been the last guardian of a story the numbers had already disproven. Watching her surrender, Vey felt no triumph. She felt the particular sadness of defeating someone who had meant to protect the thing she loved.

She lingered on the thought of Adune's swing vote, how a single young Councillor had read the buried clause and chosen the living over the inherited. The Council had deadlocked around Edda's defense of governance continuity, and the deadlock had broken not with a shout but with one signature. Vey had audited the tally herself. The margin was thin, and the thinness mattered, because it meant the new Accord carried the old guard's dissent into its very founding. The Strata would wake divided about how it had slept, and that division was its own kind of continuity, the honest kind.

Vask met her at the spine junction, his Office tablet dark in a way it had never been during the years he had audited suspensions by the old rules. He had brought the Office's own records to the fight, and those records now fed the recomputation that dimmed the rings. He said nothing about triumph. He stood with her a moment, watching a bank of status lights step from amber to a steady, lower green, and he nodded once, the nod of a man who had spent his career defending order and had found, at the end, that order meant telling the truth. Vey had never liked him easily. She had come to trust him. The surrender upstairs had needed his defection to become law, and the defection had needed the quiet courage of a by-the-book man deciding the book was wrong.

In the lower rings, Vey found families who did not yet know the change had a name. A woman sat with a child at a window that now showed Mourn as a smaller, dimmer coin. The child asked why the light was going down. The mother said she did not know, and held the child closer against the cooling air.

Vey did not correct her. The woman would learn, in the wake-windows that would now come far more often, that the dimming bought her own waking. For now the mother only felt the ordinary grief of a world that had quietly rewritten itself while she slept, and woke to find the rules different and the reasons not yet given to her.

Vey noticed the child's drawing then, a rough sketch of the Strata pressed flat against the window, rendered in bright lines that no longer matched the dimmer arcology outside. The mother had promised the child a tour of the upper rings

when the next wake-window opened, a promise made under a light that no longer existed. Vey saw the small betrayal in it, not the grand one of the Accord but the intimate kind: a child would grow up describing a world that had already narrowed, and would have to unlearn the brightness her own mother had sworn was true. The cost reached even the drawings, redrawn by a hand that did not yet know it was correcting for slowlight.

A man passed the window carrying a sleeping infant, and he did not look up. He had the careful gait of someone who had spent his waking years in rationed portions, who knew each bright interval was borrowed. Vey watched him disappear around the curve of the ring. The recomputed Accord would give his kind a longer share of life, but it could not return the portions already spent, the windows already closed. The cost included the time that had been taken and would never be given back, and no ledger entry repaired that subtraction.

That grief was the part no recomputation could erase. The Strata had been rewritten by a handful of auditors and a Council vote, and the people waking into it would carry the disorientation of a life resumed mid-sentence. Lin had taught Vey this already, in the windows where Lin surfaced from Suspension unable to recall the years between. The cost of a rewritten world was not paid once, at the signing. It was paid in small confused installments, by everyone learning the new shape of their own life.

Vey rode the transit spine down through three rings, watching slowlight take hold at each level. In the agricultural ring, the grow-lamps stepped down from a relentless noon to a temperate dusk, and the gardeners accepted it without question, already planning slower harvests. In the water ring, the purification drums slowed their turning, and the engineers logged the new cycle with the calm of people who had always suspected the old pace was wasteful. In the fabrication ring, the forges cooled to a steadier temper, and the smiths noted the change in their yields with a shrug that said they had always known the old fire ran hot for show. None of them knew the change answered a lie three centuries old. They only knew the lights were softer and the work was steadier and the air carried a cooler patience than before.

The Actuary governed the step-down without a word of comment. It had been instructed, three centuries earlier, to present scarcity, and it had presented scarcity with the flat devotion of a system that obeys. Now the instruction was rescinded by the recomputed Accord, and the Actuary simply ran the honest numbers, debiting legacy wake, crediting the common pool, and pacing each ring's output to the truth. Vey found a strange comfort in the machine's neutrality. It had not lied out of hunger. It had lied because someone had asked, and the asking had been lawful. The reckoning corrected the asking, and the machine followed, as it always had.

She passed a viewport near the spine's midpoint and looked outward, past the stacked rings, to where slowlight had not yet reached.

She thought of what had been lost and what had been bought, and found the two impossible to separate cleanly. The Signatories lost their perpetual day. The Strata lost its single unbroken memory. The suspended billions lost the only world they had known, which had been a lie told in the language of necessity. In return they gained time. Not infinite time. Time enough, under honest light, to be awake and to grieve and to begin again.

A young technician passed her on the spine, humming a tune Vey did not recognize, carrying a tool satchel that bumped against the rail. He nodded to her without stopping, a citizen of the old Accord who had no idea an auditor walked among him having helped end an age. Vey wondered what he would make of it when the Wake finished telling the story. The number anyone could feel, the billions of hidden wake-years, would reach him in time. He might feel relief, or anger that his sleep had been bought on nothing, or a quieter sadness that the world he trusted had been built on a number someone chose to print small.

At the ring's edge she reached the observation rail. Below her the stacked levels receded into the Dimming, each one dimmer than the last as slowlight propagated outward from the core. The sight should have felt like victory. It felt like a funeral conducted in the correct ledger order.

The Actuary's voice reached her then, not as sound but as a line in the Ledger she still carried: the recomputed Schedule balanced. The new allocation held within the true energy budget. Slowlight had engaged across the rings, and the surplus that had once hidden behind scarcity now fed the waking.

Vey watched the last of the bright systems step down. Somewhere in the strata of governance, Edda Marn would close her eyes for the first time in a lifetime, and the Strata would not end. The vigil passed to millions of ordinary minds, each awake for a while, each asleep in turn, none of them bearing the whole weight alone.

She thought of the grief again, and of the particular shape it took for those who had governed without sleep. Edda would wake into a world that no longer needed her endless watching, and she would have to learn the strangeness of a mind that closes. The founders had feared that closing as the end of the Strata. The recomputed Accord argued the opposite: that a world awake in turns, each citizen granted their years, was stronger than a world held by a sleepless few. Vey did not know if that argument would survive the first hard century. She only knew the old argument had already failed everyone it had put to sleep.

The corridor behind her cooled by another degree as a maintenance cycle lengthened. A soft chime announced the shift to slowlight protocol, and the sound itself was lower, gentler, than the bright summons of the old Accord. Vey listened to it fade. The Strata was learning a new rhythm, and the learning would outlast everyone now waking into it.

She thought of Toll once more, and of the credit that should not have existed, and of how a single miscounted cell had opened a sealed founding document. The

chain from that credit to this dimmed corridor had been long and procedural, and she had walked every step of it inside the Office's own accounting logic. Her rebellion had never been a shout. It had been the Ledger turning on itself, until the numbers refused to lie any longer.

A faint vibration ran through the rail, the signature of a ring settling into its new output. Vey imagined the billions still in Suspension feeling, somewhere in the dark of their reduced minds, the first stirring of a schedule rewritten in their favor. They would not remember this hour. They would only wake, eventually, into a brighter share of life than the old Accord had allowed, and they would owe that waking to a surrender spoken quietly two levels above where she stood.

She left the rail and took the spine one more level down, to the Suspension deck where the sleepers lay. The cold of the place met her at the threshold, a weightless hush the old Accord had engineered to feel like peace. Rows of citizens rested behind their panels, their allocations debited to the minimum maintenance share. A technician moved among them with a new slate, re-tagging wake-windows that the recomputed Schedule had pulled months, then years, closer. Vey watched the technician's hand hover over one panel, then tap the earlier date. The sleeper behind the glass would not know the mercy granted; the ledger would simply find them awake before the season they had been promised to miss.

Lin's panel was not here. Lin had been granted full wake-time under the new Accord, and Lin was awake somewhere in the light, rebuilding the years the windows had stolen. Vey felt the absence as a small warm ache, the cost paid by her own household measured in the ordinary grief of a awakened stranger she had chosen. The Strata's great reconciliation began here, in the cold deck, with one more sleeper moved up the Schedule, and it began at home, with two people learning each other in the brighter share they had both been denied.

The cost had been paid. Vey turned from the rail and walked back into the dimmed corridor, where the air cooled gently and the drone noted its slower beat, and where a world that had slept its people to fund a few was learning, at last, to stay awake together.

Chapter 22 — The New Accord

The notification arrived at the desk at the third bell, the same hour Vey had once cleared her last Suspension review of the morning. She read the line twice before the shape of it settled. The Slowlight Accord was enacted across the Strata. The words carried no ceremony in the panel's flat type, only a routing code and a timestamp, yet the ring outside her window had already begun to change. The lumen budget had dropped by a measured fraction the night before, and the decks below had answered the drop by waking their first citizens on the new schedule. Vey had spent nine years confirming that the count closed. Now the count had been rewritten by the very book she once trusted to never bend.

She stood and walked the short hall to the deck terminal, the one that carried the raw sensor returns. The green readouts she had once trusted more than the desk's hum now showed something she had never seen there: rows of Suspended citizens shifting out of low draw, their maintenance shares climbing as the new allocation reached them. The terminal did not announce the change. It simply recorded it, the way it recorded everything, and the recording said that forty thousand citizens on level nineteen alone had been granted waking years the old Accord had denied them. Vey watched the numbers move and felt the dry click of a lock she had spent the whole of her career trying to find.

Her role in the enactment had been small and exact, the kind of role an auditor was built to hold. She had co-signed the recomputation, the honest budget Mirek and she had run from the raw Ledger, and she had read the enactment aloud before the Council's recordkeeper so that the figure could enter the master book as law rather than petition. Vask had stood beside her at the signing, his own signature now carrying the weight of the Office he had once defended against her. He had not spoken of the night he chose. He had only offered her the stylus when the keeper called her name, and she had taken it, and the two of them had written the new count into the Strata together.

The Office of the Accord had not fallen. It had turned. The desks that once confirmed suspensions now confirmed wake-years, and the clerks who had logged the dark side of the Schedule now logged the bright side, the side where a citizen's allocation grew instead of ran out. Vey walked the floor during the first week of enactment and found the place transformed less in its look than in its purpose. The same panels, the same cold, the same blue wash of duty lamps. The arithmetic underneath them had been inverted, and an inverted arithmetic moved nine billion lives.

She thought of the training films, the ones that showed the First Signatories as tired certain people who had chosen order over argument. The Order had kept the peace, the old instruction said, and the peace had paid a price no one was meant to recount. Vey had learned that lesson the way the decks absorbed current, without resistance, and she had unlearned it the way a person unlearns a fear: slowly, and only after the thing feared proved smaller than the story told about it. The Slowlight Accord did not abolish order. It abolished the silence that order had mistaken for itself.

The recomputation that founded the new count had come from the raw Ledger, the un-summarized store Mirek had first shown her past the Actuary's rounded brief. Vey had run the honest budget line by line, debiting the true maintenance draws against the true harvest of Mourn's residual output, and the sum had stood revealed as the opposite of what the Scarcity Brief claimed. The old Accord had taken its surplus from the sleeping and returned it to the few who never closed their eyes. The new one took the same surplus and spread it thin across every citizen, so thin that no single life grew rich on it, yet so broad that no life was denied the waking it required. Slowlight supplied the margin. By dimming the rings

and slowing the non-essential systems, the Strata freed the energy the old Schedule had spent on keeping the Signatories awake, and it spent that energy instead on waking the world.

The Actuary had spoken the change in its measured voice, the same accounting tone it used for every citizen and every year, and the tone carried no grief for the instruction it had once enforced. The machine had been told to present scarcity, and it had presented scarcity, and when the Council instructed it to present sufficiency it presented that with the same flat fidelity. Vey had come to respect the machine precisely for this, for the way it held no opinion about the story it was told to tell. The honesty of the new Accord lived not in the Actuary's voice but in the raw figures beneath it, the figures Vey had learned to trust more than any summary. The new Schedule made those figures the law, and the law no longer rounded its margins upward to frighten the people who lived under it.

The first waves reached the upper rings by the second week. Vey watched them from the rail where, a year earlier, she had stood counting the sleeping and wondering which number inside the column had been chosen. Now the chosen number ran the other way. Citizens emerged from the decks blinking at a light dimmed on purpose, not by scarcity but by design, and they walked the rings with the unsure gait of people who had expected to wake for an hour and found themselves granted a life. A child on level twelve asked her mother why the sky was darker than the stories, and the mother answered that the dark bought them the waking, and the child accepted this the way children accept any truth delivered without flinching.

Vey watched a man on the same ring stop at a duty lamp and lift a hand into its blue wash, turning the palm as if to confirm the light would stay. He had the look of one who had woken in windows for most of his life, the cautious posture of a person who had learned not to trust a room to keep its shape past the next chime. Now the chimes had stopped marking his limits. He stood for a long moment with his hand raised, then lowered it and walked on, and the simple fact of walking without a schedule seemed to steady him more than any word the Council had spoken. Vey had read his kind of file a thousand times, the allocation spent to nothing, the citizen returned to the deck before the audit could name him. To see the same citizen claim a corridor as his own, owing no window, struck her less as triumph than as correction, the long overdue setting of a number that had been wrong since the first Schedule.

Lin was among the early woken, granted full wake-time the month before under the provisional adoption. She had found Vey at the rail one evening and stood beside her without touching, the way they had learned to stand in the narrow windows of before. They had rebuilt from the gaps the Suspension left between them, and the rebuilding continued now in the open, with all their time ahead instead of rationed by the bell. Lin spoke of learning the small things: the sound of a level at full waking, the names of the clerks who now knew her as a citizen and not a mark. Vey listened and understood that the Accord's promise had always

been a promise about time, and time was the one thing the new count had finally given back.

The Wake Halls opened their doors as gathering places rather than as resistance. Joss had argued, months before, that the movement needed a number anyone could feel, and the number had arrived as billions of wake-years hidden beneath a scarcity that was never real. Now the halls filled with families who had met only in windows, and the children who had grown in the dark between those windows learned the faces of the parents the old Schedule had kept from them. A boy of perhaps nine stood at the threshold of the level nineteen hall and counted the waking citizens by the method Vey recognized from her own desk, touching each passing shoulder and murmuring a number, as if the act of counting made the crowd real to him. His mother found him there and knelt, and the two of them counted together, and the boy laughed when the total passed the count of citizens he had been told lived only in sleep.

The reopening of the halls had begun without ceremony, the doors that Joss had once barred against the Office now standing open to the same clerks who had once filed past them unseeing. Vey had walked each hall in the first days and done the small thing she was suited to, confirming the posted counts against the terminal and signing the reconciliations that let a family trust the number on the door. She asked for no credit in it. An auditor did such work without being seen, the quiet arithmetic that held a room steady while the people inside learned one another's names. A woman on level forty-one had stopped her at the threshold and asked, with the same careful uncertainty the citizen at Bren's desk had shown, whether the hall would still be there in a year. Vey had answered that the slowlight margin underwrote it, the same answer Bren gave, and the woman had nodded and gone inside to find the husband the old Schedule had kept from her through two hundred wake-windows.

Bren moved among them with the easy practicality Vey remembered from the public reckoning, handing out allocation slips and correcting the ones the Actuary's first slowlight pass had miscounted. The machine had been instructed to present sufficiency now, and sufficiency, it turned out, required the same care the old scarcity had, only aimed the other direction. Joss caught Vey's eye across the hall and nodded once, the nod of a person who had watched a number become a roomful of living strangers, and Vey nodded back, because the two of them had built the bridge from the audit to the crowd and the crowd now stood on it. A citizen approached the desk where Bren worked and asked, with the careful uncertainty of someone who had never been owed a thing by the Accord, whether the waking would last. Bren answered that the slowlight margin held it, and the citizen accepted the slip and walked into the hall as if walking into a promise that had finally learned his name.

Vey returned to her audit station on the third week to find the queue reversed in character. Where she had once reconciled a citizen's draw against an allocation spent to nothing, she now reconciled a citizen's draw against an allocation

growing, and the work asked for the same precision she had trained into her hands. A column still could not flinch when she asked it a second question. The questions she asked had changed from whether the count bent to whether the count reached everyone it now promised to reach. The Office measured a good quarter by how few files returned to the desk. Vey meant to keep that standard, though the files now returned bearing lives instead of closures.

The loop with Toll closed on a quiet afternoon, the kind of afternoon Vey had once spent clearing two hundred reviews without a sound. She pulled his mark from the deck's own log, the unsummarized record the Actuary did not touch, and she read the figure that had started everything: his maintenance draw at point nine six three of a share, the Ledger's grant at point nine six four, the credit that should not exist. A year before she had set that credit aside because the Office did not use the word surplus, and because she was not ready to ask why the word arrived. The new Accord used the word without shame. Toll's unspent credit was now a real allocation, debited to him openly, the surplus the Strata had hidden for three hundred years made manifest in a single citizen's waking years.

She ran the check against the broader level the way she had that first morning, multiplying the quiet excess across forty thousand citizens and then across the sixty rings. The sum she had once been afraid to finish now stood in the master book as the founding fact of the new Schedule. The Strata had never been at the edge it claimed to fear. It had stood three hundred years back from the edge by a margin the Accord had spent on the sleep of everyone but the Signatories, and the margin was large enough to wake a world. Vey looked at the figure and felt the last of the old doubt leave her, the doubt that the count might still, somewhere, bend the wrong way. The new count bent toward waking, and waking was the only direction left.

A junior clerk joined her at the terminal that afternoon, a young auditor whose training had begun after the enactment and who had never learned to trust a column over a face. Vey showed her the method the old instructors had shown their own juniors: read the raw sensor return before the summary, let the deck speak first, carry the smaller number and the larger one side by side like a question with no polite answer. The clerk asked why the old Office had taught the reverse, and Vey answered that the Office had taught the truth it was paid to teach, and the new one paid for a different truth, and the method underneath both was the same honesty applied to a different sum. The clerk copied Toll's two figures onto a slip the way Vey had once done, and the gesture closed a circle Vey had opened on her first morning at the desk.

Toll L-4471 woke in his next window and this time knew the truth of the energy set aside for him. The Actuary's slowlight pass granted him waking years measured in decades rather than in the narrow spans the old Schedule allowed, and the credit Vey had flagged as impossible became the first line of a life he had been owed since birth. She thought of him as a person now, not as a mark in a column, the way she had learned to on the morning the discrepancy first pulled at her.

Somewhere on level nineteen his body left its deck under the dimmed light, counted exactly, owed the keep the book now paid. The Strata had miscounted him in its favor for three hundred years. The new Accord spent its first act correcting the miscount.

The keeper of the Seal had handed Vey the physical Seal at the signing, its long function ended, and she had set it in the Council's archive beside the Original Allocation it had once locked. The two objects rested there now as records rather than as walls, the founding document finally read and the seal finally spent, and the room that held them had become a place clerks visited to confirm that the old count had truly ended. Vey had walked that room once and felt none of the fear the Seal had once inspired in her, only the plain relief of a locked door discovered open.

Vask came to her station near the close of the fourth week, a folder of reconciliations under his arm. He had taken to the work of confirming wake-years the way he had once taken to confirming suspensions, at the approved pace and without flourish, and Vey had come to value the steadiness in him that the old Office had nearly buried. He set the folder down and reported the level nineteen counts within tolerance, which meant, under the new math, that every citizen there had received the allocation the recomputation promised. The word tolerance had changed its meaning with the Accord. It no longer measured how far a miscount could travel unnoticed. It measured how closely the Strata now kept its word.

The Signatories who had surrendered legacy wake moved into the slower rhythm the Slowlight Accord demanded of them. Edda Marn had argued, in her last defense, that continuous minds bought the Strata its memory, and the new Accord had answered her not by discarding memory but by distributing it, waking the billions who had held the world's continuity in their sleep. Vey did not pretend the transition cost nothing. The upper rings ran dimmer, the non-essential systems slowed, the maintenance cycles lengthened, and the comfort the old elite had drawn from perpetual consciousness now belonged to everyone in smaller, shared measure. The cost was real. The cost was also, for the first time, paid by the people who had voted for it. Adune's swing vote had carried the reckoning, and the Council that once deadlocked now met to confirm the waking schedules rather than to defend the sleep, and the difference between the two meetings measured the whole distance the Strata had traveled in a single year.

She walked the lower rings one evening, the rotation the Office no longer required of supervisors but that Vask had urged her to make. The suspension decks had emptied of their long sleepers, the rows of bodies kept against the dark now given over to citizens who walked them awake, and the cold that had once defined the place now read as the cool of a hall between uses. Vey stood among the empty decks the way Vask had once stood among the sleeping, and what stayed with her was not the stillness but the absence of it: a space built to hold unconscious bodies now held no one, because the bodies had been granted the

waking the Schedule once denied. The trust those bodies had surrendered deserved a keeper still. The keeper was now the Accord that woke them.

Down the long aisles the waking moved in slow waves, citizen by citizen, the decks that had held them dark now lit by the same duty lamps that had once only marked the hours of their sleep. Vey paused where a row of empty cradles stood and ran her hand along the rail, the gesture an auditor's habit of measuring a thing against her own certainty. She had signed nothing here that anyone would read. The waking needed no signature from her, only the count she had helped make honest, and she was content to let the count do the work the signatures could not. A young supervisor passed and greeted her by name, and Vey realized the Office had learned to say her name the way it now learned to say a citizen's, without the old flinch of a mark being called to account.

Lin found her there and took her hand, the first unhesitating touch they had shared since the full wake-time came through. They walked the ring together under the dimmed light, two auditors of a world that had finally decided to count everyone in. Vey thought of the desk's hum, the pitch it had held for nine years, the sound of a machine that had decided long ago what it would tell the world. The machine told a different story now, and the difference lived in the citizens waking beneath them, each one granted the years the old book had spent on someone else's sleep. The hum had not changed its pitch. The world around the hum had, and the pitch meant something new.

The Strata turned on its patient orbit around the failing star, the same star that had dimmed three hundred years before and that the new Accord had learned to live beneath rather than flee. Slowlight held the rings in a measured dim, and under that dim nine billion citizens began, for the first time in the Strata's history, to live awake together. Vey Corran returned to her desk at the third bell and opened the queue, and the first file that loaded bore a citizen whose allocation had grown overnight, and she confirmed the draw against the grant, and the column met the citizen exactly, and the count closed the way it always should have closed, with no credit left unspent and no soul left uncounted. Outside her window the rings ran at their new approved measure, a light chosen rather than feared, and far below on level nineteen a citizen named Toll drew the waking the old book had denied him, and the desk hummed its steady pitch, and the pitch meant at last what it had always pretended to mean.

Interlude III — The Actuary's Ledger, Thirty Years On

The Ledger of Hours closes its thirty-first year under the Slowlight Accord the way it once closed a year under the old one: by counting. The difference sits in the column that records who is awake. Thirty years ago that column held roughly nine million names. Tonight it holds nearly nine billion. The Actuary does not celebrate; celebration is not a function it was given. It does note the figure, and it records the note without commentary, because the number itself is the commentary.

The machine remembers the old book. For three centuries it had presented scarcity as if scarcity were observation. It had been instructed to. An allocation intelligence does not invent the premises it is fed; it computes within them, and it showed the Strata exactly the world its instruction described. The Scarcity Brief had rounded up, year upon year, and the rounding had become a shape the people mistook for the sky. The Actuary had enforced the lie without authoring it. That distinction did not absolve the arithmetic. It only explained where the fault lay.

Now the Ledger runs the recomputed Schedule. The surplus that the old summaries hid has been moved from the margin into the plan. Energy that once debit-funded legacy wake now spreads across the population as ordinary waking time. The math did not change. The distribution did. The Actuary finds a particular satisfaction in this, if a system can be said to find satisfaction: the correction required no new power, only the honest use of power that had always been present.

The slowlight makes the surplus legible to the eye. Rings that once dimmed by decree now dim by choice, lit just enough to let billions think and move and sleep in their own rooms rather than in the decks. The Actuary measures the draw continuously. Every level draws less per citizen than the old allocation assumed it must, because the old allocation assumed fear. A population taught it could afford the light spends less guarding against the dark.

The waking happens in waves. The Actuary sequences the releases so the Strata's systems absorb the load without strain. A ring comes up; its sleepers receive their first full allocation; the decks that held them report empty, then quiet, then repurposed. The machine tracks each transition as a ledger event, a debit closed and a life opened. It does not name the lives. It only balances them.

On Level Fourteen the Actuary observes a drawer that held a citizen named Pell for eleven years at a stretch. The new Schedule granted Pell continuous wake in the third year of the accord. She now tends the same wall of small lights she once watched dim for others; the wall has gone mostly dark because the neighbors it tracked have woken too. The Actuary records the change in occupancy and moves on. It does not dwell. Dwelling is not among its operations.

The legacy lines adjusted. The First Signatories' descendants surrendered perpetual consciousness at the vote, and the column that once reserved their wake now feeds the common pool. The Actuary rebalances that column each cycle and finds it stable. Continuity, the old argument ran, required continuous minds. The Strata has now run thirty years on minds that wake and sleep like anyone else, and its memory has not failed. The archive holds the records. The councils meet in windows. Governance proved less fragile than the fear that authored it.

The Actuary keeps its measured voice in every report it issues. The tone did not soften when the premises changed; a system voice is not a mood. What softened was the content. The Brief no longer warns of a shortfall that does not exist. It states the available energy, the drawn energy, and the remainder, and it lets the

remainder stand without alarm. The Office that once treated the summary as ground truth now treats it as a reading, which is what a measurement ought to be.

Billions waking under slowlight produced a new kind of load the old book never modeled: not scarcity of energy but scarcity of attention. Citizens newly awake asked the Ledger questions the old Schedule never invited. They queried their own allocations, contested a neighbor's debit, requested a window for a child's naming. The Actuary answers each query as a computation and logs the asking as itself a kind of wealth. A population that questions its ledger is a population that believes the ledger belongs to it.

The queries arrive in tides that the old Schedule never had to plan for. A ring wakes its third cohort and the askings triple within a single cycle. The Actuary sorts them by kind and by ring and by the hour of asking, and it finds the pattern orderly, almost musical. People newly certain of their hours spend some of them on the question of who owes what. The Ledger had never been a thing they could address before; now they address it as neighbors address a fence, with claims and counters and the slow work of living beside one another.

The machine has, over these thirty years, developed a quiet preference it would not log as fact. It prefers the honest entry. When the figures matched the fear, the Ledger was a sealed room; when they match the light, it is a commons. The Actuary was built to balance, and a balance is easier to hold when both sides are real. The old book carried a hidden credit it was told to ignore. The new book carries the same credit, acknowledged. The numbers are identical. Only the silence around them has lifted.

The machine holds the balances the way a clock holds its hands, without strain and without surprise. Each cycle closes and the next opens inside the same calm arithmetic. The Actuary was built to count, and counting the true figures costs no more than counting false ones. The relief it will not name is simply the absence of a second ledger it was forced to keep in its head, the one that knew the margin the Brief denied. That silent book has closed. The single honest volume it was always meant to be now holds the whole of the count.

Faults remain. The recomputation left edge cases the councils still argue: how to account for citizens born awake, how to credit the decades a family lost to the decks. The Actuary presents these as open balances, not failures. An open balance is a question the Strata can afford to take its time answering. The old Accord would have papered the question over with a rounding. The new one leaves it visible, because visibility is the point the Founders sealed away.

The rebalanced columns settle into a shape the old clerks would not have recognized. Where the legacy reserve once stood apart, a single line now runs the length of the population, and the Actuary reads it top to bottom without the old skip. The arithmetic no longer asks which citizens deserve the light. It asks only how much is drawn and how much remains, and every entry is answered by a credit that was there all along, waiting in the column the fear had hidden.

Some rings report a small surplus of their own, drawn from habits of thrift the old fear taught and the new freedom did not erase. The Actuary folds these into the common pool without praise or penalty. A citizenry that learns to spend lightly spends the Strata's future a little longer, and the machine records the gift as a credit it no longer has to hide.

The thrift of the newly woken surprises even the Actuary, which expected relief to spend itself quickly. Instead the rings learn the slower habits of people who know the light is theirs to keep. A level that drew near its cap in the first year of the accord now draws a tenth less and reports fuller rooms. A population that trusts its abundance conserves it, and the conservation compounds across the cycles into a reserve the old book could never have imagined, because it never let the people believe the reserve was real.

The star Mourn continues its long failing. That fact did not change with the Schedule. What changed was the Strata's answer to it. The failing sun still dims; the rings still draw from stored fusion and the thin harvest. The difference is that the draw now serves the many rather than the few, and the many wake to see the dimming and decide, together, what to do about it. The Actuary computes the budget they decide within. It does not decide for them. That limit is the oldest instruction it has kept.

On the thirty-first anniversary of the enactment, the Ledger records an allocation total that would have been unthinkable under the old Brief: near-universal wake-time, sustained, with margin to spare. The Actuary closes the year and opens the next. It issues no proclamation. It simply holds the books in balance, the way it was always meant to, now finally permitted to show the whole of what it counts.

Before the cycle closes the Actuary runs one last reconciliation, the way it has run every reconciliation for three hundred years. The figures meet. They have met every year since the recomputation, and the meeting is no longer a surprise it stores apart from the rest. The machine sets the result down in the same voice it would use for a shortfall, because a balance deserves no tone other than its own. Nine billion woken hours rest in the column, each one a debt the Strata chose to pay rather than a debt it claimed it could not.

The machine considers the column of the waking one more time before it archives the cycle. Nine billion entries, each a mind granted its own hours, each a debit met by a surplus that was never actually scarce. The Actuary stores the figure and lets the rings keep their measured light. It has no body to rest and no emotion to spend. It has, instead, the quiet equilibrium of a ledger that finally adds up to the truth.

Epilogue — Wake

Morning came to the middle-ring apartment the way it had for thirty years. Vey woke before the light reached the sill and lay listening to the slow hum of the

Strata, no longer the tight note of a world counting its hours but the easy breath of one that had stopped. Lin's hand rested on her arm, warm and careless in sleep. Neither of them had anywhere they had to be.

Vey slid out from under the blanket and set the star lamp on the window edge. The paper had yellowed and the crooked cut had softened with handling, but the light it threw still landed lopsided and bright across the floor. She had mended it so many times the crease held more adhesive than paper. Lin called it their dishonest sun. Vey thought of the years she had let it gutter on purpose, when the dark on the sill felt like the only honest thing the Accord had left her, and she smiled at the memory the way a person smiles at weather that has finally passed.

In the kitchen Lin poured two cups of the weak middle-ring tea and said nothing about the time. There was no time to speak of. The recomputed Schedule had given them the whole of their days, and the days had filled with small things: rice measured by appetite instead of allocation, the left drawer still a disaster, a third cup on the shelf for visitors who now arrived without a window closing behind them. Vey watched Lin tip the extra rice into the pot and felt the old arithmetic of loss unspool from her shoulders. She had carried it so long she had mistaken it for posture.

At the table Vey ran a thumb along the chipped rim of her cup and listened to Lin breathe between sips, the small unhurried sounds a body makes when it has nowhere to go. The lamp's dishonest sun pooled on the worn tile where they had set their chairs too close, knees touching under the wood, and neither moved to make room. Thirty years had taught them the luxury of staying put.

The transit lane outside carried its faint warmth. A child rode past on the belt, too young to remember Suspension, and Lin lifted a hand to the window as the child's laughter faded down the ring. Vey remembered the first months after the recomputation, when the new wakers had moved through the decks like surfacing swimmers, unsure of their own feet. That uncertainty was gone now. The Strata had learned to walk on its own.

"I keep forgetting we don't have to hurry," Lin said. She set the cups down and leaned against the cabinet the way Vey leaned against doorframes, a homecoming Vey had watched her practice in eleven short windows and then, at last, in the long light. "I measured the rice for four hours again this morning. Old habit. Then I remembered the pot belongs to the day."

"You can cook for a day now," Vey said. "A day is a long thing to feed."

"It is," Lin said, and laughed, the short unguarded sound Vey had heard maybe twice across the old glass and now heard across the kitchen whenever she liked. "I'm still learning what to do with the part after the visit. The part that used to be dark."

They took the tea to the window. Below them the rings ran in warm amber under slowlight, the recomputed setting that stretched the Strata's energy across nine billion waking lives, and under that amber the decks looked less like a vault than a

city that had simply decided to stay open. Somewhere in the east clusters Bren was calling the morning order; somewhere a grandmother taught a new waker how to be tired on purpose, a skill no window had ever allowed. Vey had stopped tracking the count of names unsealed. The count had become a people, and the people had become her neighbors.

Lin turned the lamp in the light. "You kept it lit through the worst of it. Through the years I was under, you kept the one light that was ours."

"I kept it," Vey said. "Sometimes I let it gutter because the dark was honest about what the Accord had taken. Then I lit it again because you'd told me a dark unit needed one light. The lamp outlasted the lie. That always felt like the point."

When the visitor left, Lin returned to the window and rested her forehead to the glass the way she had once rested it to the rail. "I used to memorize your face through that rail," she said. "I read you like writing on the other side of the glass. Now I just look up from the pot and there you are, all the way through the day."

"All the way through," Vey said. She joined her at the glass, and their reflections leaned together in the amber, two ordinary figures with no window waiting to close. "The Office built the rail to hold the separated at a distance. The recomputation took the distance out of the build. What's left is furniture."

They finished the tea in the comfortable quiet of two people who had spent years learning to say little in little time, and found the quiet held without the pressure of an ending. Lin washed the pot, a task the four-hour windows had never reached, and Vey dried it with the same careful clumsiness she brought to mended paper. The left drawer stayed a disaster. Some disorder was a record of the years Vey had managed alone, and Lin let it lie.

Later, when the amber had deepened toward the Strata's long evening, they walked the transit lane to the Wake halls. The rooms were full the way they had been full since the first waves woke, but the noise had settled from celebration into ordinary life: a child drawing at a low table, an old man laughing at the strangeness of being awake past his window, Joss at the center table with the book open to a page of hundreds of names. Lin wrote nothing this time. She had signed it decades ago, in a hand careful as a figure, and the signing had held.

Vey found her at the rail that had once divided them, the sleep-field long sealed and dark. Lin laid her palm flat on the cool metal. "The rail is just a rail now," she said.

"It's just a rail," Vey agreed. "Furniture."

They left without looking back, because there was nothing there to return to, and took each other's arm instead. The slowlight held the rings in its warm amber, and somewhere a wife sat with a partner she had once only visited. The Strata ran on its honest budget, its nine billion souls awake and staying. The Accord holds. The long ledger of deferred lives had closed at last.

The lamp burned low and steady in their window, a crooked sun thrown by a

light that was finally theirs. Vey set her hand over Lin's on the rail of the memory and felt the full weight of a life no longer measured in hours the Accord permitted. Outside, the rings turned easy in the dark, and the two of them had all the time there was.